



Tata Sons IPO cloud stays; RBI vets plea ▶ P1



JSW chases scale, Tata Steel value, as growth paths differ ▶ P1

Apple iPhone 17 PRO



Go to [IndiaiStore.com](https://indiaistore.com) to find Apple Authorised Reseller stores near you.

Available with benefits up to **₹16000***

Up to **₹6000*** instant cashback on credit cards of



+



Exchange bonus up to **₹10000***



*Terms and conditions apply.
Please scan the QR Code for terms and conditions.

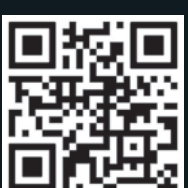
Lovable. Drawable. Magical.



Apple iPad

Go to [IndiaiStore.com](https://indiaistore.com) to find Apple Authorised Reseller stores near you.

Up to ₹6000* instant cashback on credit cards of



*Terms and conditions apply.
Please scan the QR Code for terms and conditions.



Friday, August 7, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why food labels are under the FSSAI scanner

BY NEETHI LISA ROJAN

Recent FSSAI bans on Dabur's misleading claims and select United Spirits products have triggered court challenges and sent Dabur's shares tumbling. The food safety regulator's intensifying crackdown is increasingly pulling major FMCG brands into legal battles and shifting stock prices. What's driving this tougher scrutiny? *Mint* explains.



1 Has the FSSAI stepped up enforcement recently?
The FSSAI has not introduced any new laws. What has changed is the regulator's approach to enforcement and public communication. It has become more vocal on social media, publicly highlighting violations by companies. In July, the FSSAI urged consumers through its official X account to report unsafe food. Its Food Safety Connect mobile app also allows users to report misleading packaging claims by uploading photographs of product labels. The heightened enforcement follows months of criticism from health influencers and NGOs, who argued on social media that India's food standards lag those in Europe.

TURN TO PAGE 8

QUICK EDIT

A test of liberty

China's inventive success has been a particular perplexity for those who see freedom of conscience as integral to originality, innovation and its economic yield. Perhaps its 're-education' camps in Xinjiang are an isolated story. Or maybe that liberty falls in a grey zone, like in many other parts of Asia. India's Constitutional guarantee of this right often finds favour for reasons of expedience over economics, given the country's social diversity. Either way, for its promise to hold, every law must pass its test. Therefore, if Parliament outlaws failures of deference to ever more embodiments of national honour than already protected, it must not result in conflicts of conscience. No doubt, a balance of ideals always call for delicate judgements in a democracy, as seen in America's flag debate, but one observation across the history of nation-states is now taken as axiomatic: that a minimal list is optimal for a national consensus. India must take note of this for a pragmatic reason too. For overall social stability, nobody should be in a position to cite a particular enforcement of law as evidence that a basic right no longer holds. It's also why all matters of nationhood demand wide deliberation.



Think NorthEast
Think POLO



POLO HOTEL,
AGARTALA



POLO TOWERS,
SHILLONG



POLO RESORT,
CHERRAPUNJI

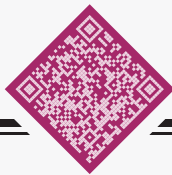


POLO FLOATEL,
CALCUTTA



POLO HOTEL,
KOHIMA
(OPENING SOON)

PLAIN FACTS

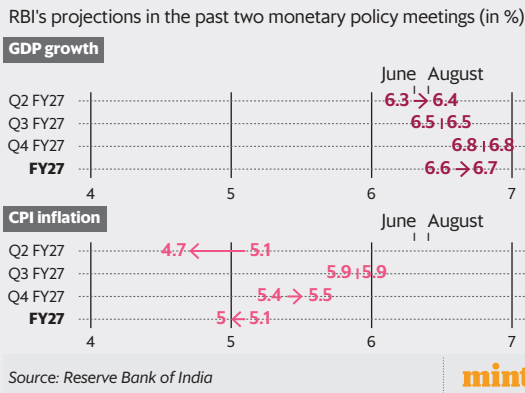


DATA RECAP THE WEEK IN CHARTS

CURATED BY MANJUL PAUL

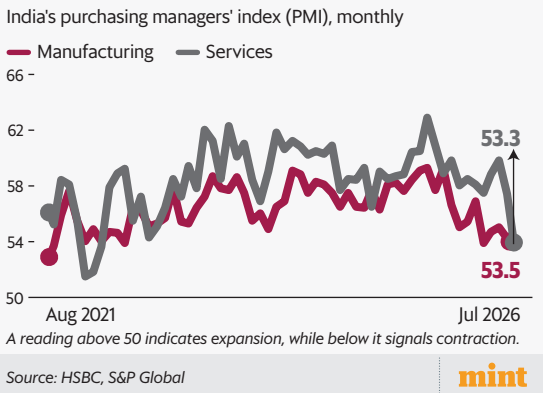
From the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) keeping interest rates unchanged while revising its growth and inflation outlook, to manufacturing and services' expansion moderating in July, banks raising billions through the foreign currency deposit scheme, promoter share pledging edging higher in Q1FY27, and India recording its lowest Commonwealth Games medal haul since 1998—here is a compilation of this week's news in numbers.

REVISED OUTLOOK



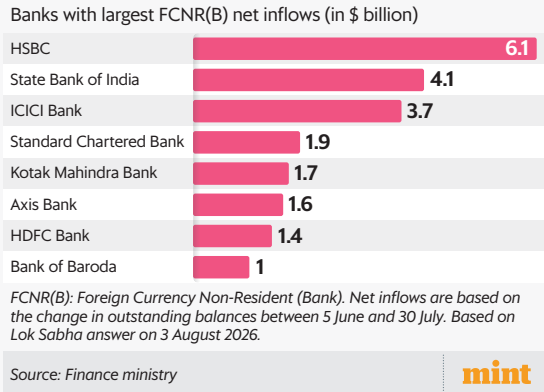
AT ITS August monetary policy meeting, the RBI kept the repo rate unchanged at 5.25% for the fourth straight meeting. The Monetary Policy Committee also retained its neutral stance, signalling future policy decisions will be data dependent. This came against the backdrop of an increase in growth projection and a cut inflation forecast, albeit moderately. The central bank raised its FY27 GDP growth forecast to 6.7% from 6.6% projected in the June meeting, while lowering its consumer price index (CPI) inflation estimate to 5.0% from 5.1%. While growth-inflation dynamics supported a pause for now, the increase in inflation forecast to 5.5% from 5.4% in Q4 keeps possibility of rate hikes alive.

MOMENTUM EASES



BOTH MANUFACTURING and services activity remained in expansionary territory in July, however, its pace of expansion moderated to multi-year lows. The HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) slipped to 53.5 in July from 54.2 in June, its lowest reading since August 2021, as a sharp decline in new orders curbed input purchases, even as export demand strengthened and inflationary pressures eased. The HSBC India Services PMI fell more sharply, to 53.3 in July from 57.4 in June, marking its slowest pace of expansion in nearly four years. Challenging market conditions, softer new business inflows and order postponements weighed on activity.

DOLLAR BOOST

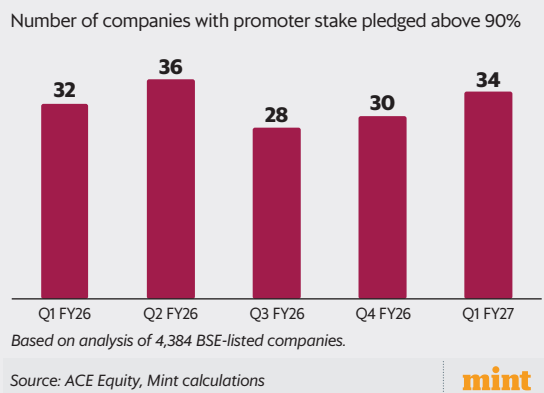


INDIAN BANKS mobilized about \$28 billion in net fresh foreign currency non-resident (FCNR) deposits between 5 June and 30 July under the RBI's special incentives scheme aimed at attracting foreign currency inflows and supporting the rupee. HSBC, State Bank of India, and ICICI Bank together accounted for nearly half of these inflows, according to data tabled in Parliament, *Mint* reported. Public sector banks mobilized \$8.8 billion under the scheme, private sector banks \$10.7 billion and foreign banks \$8.4 billion, with the remainder flowing to small finance and cooperative banks. The scheme was announced on 5 June and rolled out three days later and will run until the end of September.

NUMBERS TALK

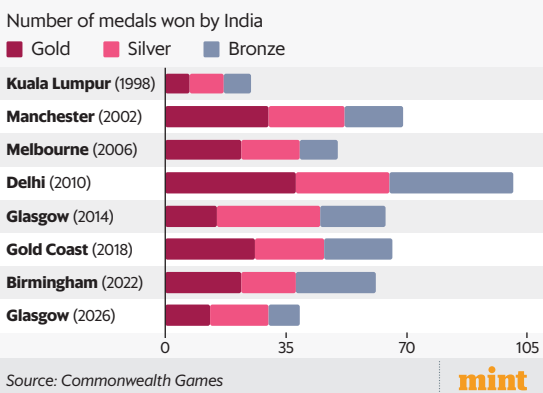
- **2.9%:** The decline in kharif crop sowing as of 31 July compared with the corresponding period a year earlier, though revival in monsoon rainfall in July has narrowed the gap from nearly 4-6% earlier.
- **40%:** The rise in the Centre's apprenticeship target under National Apprenticeship Training Scheme for FY27, to 600,000 students, *Mint* reported. It has allocated ₹1,250 crore for the scheme.
- **₹31,552 crore:** The amount raised through Life Insurance Corp. of India's offer for sale, the largest public share sale by an Indian company. The Centre reduced its stake in the insurer to 90%
- **2.37 million tonnes:** India's LPG consumption in July, a six-month high, driven by easing West Asia disruptions and the lifting of supply curbs for commercial users, official data.
- **37:** The sanctioned strength of Supreme Court judges, excluding the Chief Justice of India, up from 33, following the passage of the Supreme Court (number of judges) Amendment Bill 2026 by the Parliament.

PROMOTER PLEDGING



PROMOTER SHARE pledging edged higher in the June quarter, with four more companies reporting over 90% of promoter holdings pledged than in the previous quarter. A *Mint* analysis of 4,384 BSE-listed companies using Ace Equity data showed that 34 firms crossed the 90% pledged threshold by the end of Q1FY27, up from 30 in the March quarter and 32 a year earlier. The count had peaked at 36 in September before easing to 28 in December. While promoters often pledge shares to raise funds, unusually high levels can leave companies vulnerable to margin calls and forced selling if their share prices decline. The latest uptick suggests funding stress may be resurfacing in some pockets.

FEWER MEDALS



INDIA'S 39-MEDAL haul at the 2026 Glasgow Commonwealth Games was its lowest since Kuala Lumpur 1998. India secured 14 gold, 16 silver and nine bronze medals to finish fourth overall. The lower tally this time largely reflected the inclusion of just 10 sports, compared with the usual 15-20 featured at previous editions, and the exclusion of several disciplines that have historically bolstered India's medal count Even so, India remained among the top-performing nations, trailing only Australia (171 total medals), England (110), and Canada (63). The outcome underscores how changes to the event programme can significantly influence overall medal tallies beyond athletes' on-field performances.

MINT BEST OF THE WEEK

Visa's AI reset



giant restructures around AI. Employees say engineers, managers and senior leaders were affected, reflecting how AI is reshaping hiring and workforce needs across tech.

Adani's capex ripple



clutch of listed engineering and construction firms, many of which rely heavily on Adani-linked orders. The investments could fuel years of growth, but also raise dependence on a single customer.

Reading the RBI



projections offer clues on what comes next. Stable growth, manageable inflation and a neutral stance suggest no immediate rate cuts, while markets are beginning to price in a possible hike later this year.





Industry wants Bharat Vecto to replace the CSFC test

BEE to scan progress of new tool for truck fuel efficiency

Manas Pimpalkhare
manas.pimpalkhare@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) will periodically review the development of Bharat Vecto amid a standoff with the automobile industry over implementing stricter Constant Speed Fuel Consumption (CSFC) testing protocol for medium and heavy commercial vehicles, according to two people aware of the matter.

Bharat Vehicle Energy Consumption Calculation Tool, or Bharat Vecto, simulates the real-world conditions of Indian roads and tests the fuel efficiency of commercial vehicles. Based on the European vehicle energy consumption calculation tool (Vecto), it's being developed by Arai.

In recent consultations between the government and industry over the CSFC norms, the BEE, which comes under the Union power ministry, conveyed that the tool (Bharat Vecto) "should not be developed as a black box", said the first of the two persons on condition of anonymity.

"One of the key outcomes of the consultation was that the BEE and the Arai (Automotive Research Association of India) will hold periodic review meetings on Bharat Vecto from now onwards so that the BEE can also understand the methodology used," said the second person, also on condition of anonymity.

The auto industry wants Bharat Vecto to replace the proposed CSFC test for measuring truck fuel efficiency. Unlike the CSFC test, which involves driving vehicles at 40kmph and 60kmph on test tracks, Bharat Vecto is designed to reflect real-world Indian operating conditions, according to automakers.

The ARAI, which started developing Bharat Vecto with direction from the transport ministry in January 2025, plans to launch it in diesel vehicles by December 2026.

Queries emailed to the BEE, power ministry, road transport ministry, and Tata Motors, Ashok Leyland, and Montra Electric went unanswered.

Urad defies El Niño, prices seen stable as supply to hold

Consumer affairs department sees stable urad supply keeping a lid on related food inflation

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Our plate of idli, dosa, dal makhani or a pack of papad is unlikely to get much costlier this year despite concerns that the El Niño impact could fan food inflation by clipping the harvest of kharif crops, including these items' key input, urad. The government is confident India will have comfortable supplies of the key pulse as, unlike most crops of the season, urad sowing is higher than last year while imports from Myanmar and Brazil are also seen adequate, said two officials in the know.

The consumer affairs department expects stable urad supplies to keep a lid on inflation in its related food items.

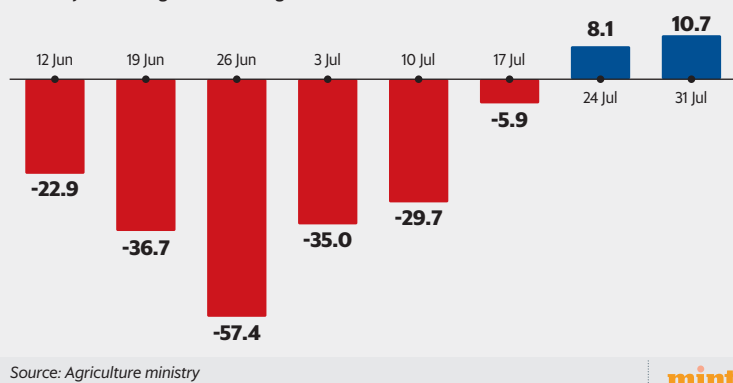
Urad has emerged as an outlier this kharif season that has seen 13% shortfall in rain so far. Overall kharif acreage has fallen nearly 3% year-on-year, while urad sowing is up nearly 11%. In contrast, tur's area is down 9.2% while staple food grain paddy 2.6% lower.

While the El Niño weather phenomenon, which typically curtails monsoon rains, has raised concerns over the output of several crops, the government expects urad to remain at least at last year's level of 2.16 million tonnes, buoyed by higher kharif acreage. As per latest

Power pulse

Unlike most crops of the season, urad sowing is higher than last year while imports from Myanmar and Brazil are also seen adequate.

Year-on-year % change in urad sowing in 2026 as on...



Source: Agriculture ministry

mint

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

available data, the consumer affairs department, citing a Niti Aayog evaluation of the Price Stabilisation Fund (PSF), pegged India's annual consumption of urad at 3.189 million tonnes in 2022-23.

Agriculture ministry sowing data showed urad was sown across 2.108 million hectares as of 31 July 2026, up nearly 11% from 1.9 million a year ago. Although acreage is still below the five-year normal of 2.96 million hectares, the year-on-year rise has eased concerns. Urad is grown across all three cropping seasons: kharif, rabi and summer. But despite being cultivated through the

year, its output has largely dwindled from 2.776 million tonnes in 2021-22 to 2.16 million tonnes in 2025-26.

Acreage rise is seen across the major producing states. In Rajasthan, urad area has risen to 375,000 hectares from 311,000 a year ago; Madhya Pradesh, India's largest producer, at 672,000 hectares from 579,000 hectares; and Uttar Pradesh at 552,000 hectares, marginally up from 542,000 hectares. Sowing has also expanded in Gujarat, up from 50,000 hectares to 71,000, and in Bihar, from 4,000 hectares to 5,000 hectares. "There are concerns over higher

international urad prices. However, with a favourable domestic supply outlook and robust production estimates from Brazil and Myanmar, urad prices are unlikely to rise despite market speculation," the second official said. "Consumers need not worry. Adequate quantities of urad will be available, and prices are expected to remain stable."

The price of fair average quality of Myanmar-origin urad is up around 6%, from about \$789 per tonne in late October 2025 to \$835-\$840 per tonne for June-July 2026 shipments.

Government estimates indicate that Brazil and Myanmar could together export nearly 900,000 tonnes urad to India this year. "Around 700,000 tonnes in Myanmar and 200,000 tonnes in Brazil will provide adequate importable surplus to supplement domestic supplies," this official said.

Industry executives said stable urad supplies would help food manufacturers keep prices steady and would not lead to price rises for consumers. "Urad is a key ingredient in many foods. A rise of up to 5% in the price of a key ingredient is manageable and does not impact the prices of food items. But any increase beyond that starts affecting costs," said Jigish Devta, managing director of Deepkiran Foods, an Ahmedabad-based exporter of ready-to-eat food products.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Parliament okays tax reform, clears extra FY26 spends

Subhash Narayan
subhash.narayan@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Parliament advanced two key pieces of financial legislation on Thursday, with the Lok Sabha passing the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, to fine-tune the country's tax and payments architecture, and the Rajya Sabha returning the Appropriation (No. 3) Bill, 2026 to the lower house after approving it, completing the legislative process for authorising additional government expenditure for 2025-26.

The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, passed by the Lok Sabha, seeks to amend three laws: the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, the Income-tax Act, 2025, and the Finance Act, 2026. The legislation is aimed at carrying out consequential changes and addressing issues arising from the implementation of recent tax and financial sector reforms.

The amendments to the Income Tax Act, 2025 are expected to align provisions introduced under the new direct tax framework, while changes to the Finance Act, 2026 seek to remove ambiguities and ensure smoother implementation of tax measures announced in the Union Budget. Amendments to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 are intended to update the legal framework



Parliament advanced two key pieces of legislation.

governing payment systems in line with evolving regulatory and technological requirements.

The amendment to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, could pave the way for banks to charge merchant discount rate (MDR) fees on large Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions in the future.

Separately, the Rajya Sabha returned the Appropriation (No. 3) Bill, 2026 to the Lok Sabha after approving it. The legislation authorises the withdrawal and appropriation of certain further sums from the Consolidated Fund of India to meet expenditure for the services of financial year 2025-26. Such appropriation bills are a constitutional requirement and allow the government to incur expenditure approved by Parliament through supplementary demands for grants.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Govt to crack whip on fake drug data

Priyanka Sharma
priyanka.sharma@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Pharmaceutical companies and other entities seeking drug approvals will now face debarment from filing further applications with central and state authorities if they submit fake or fabricated data, the health ministry said.

This assumes significant for India's \$60-billion pharmaceutical market, as the government aims to clean up the approval system and ensure drug safety and quality.

As part of the plan, the Union health ministry has notified amendments to the Drugs Rules, 1945, empowering regulatory bodies to penalize entities that submit fraudulent documents when applying for approvals and to improve the accuracy and openness of the drug regulation system.

The ministry emphasized the role that data verification plays in evaluating pharmaceutical products prior to market authorization.

"Sound scientific data submitted by applicants forms the



The aim is to enforce data accuracy, accountability.

basis for regulatory evaluation of the quality, safety and efficacy of drugs," the ministry said in a statement.

"Submission of fake or fabricated data compromises the integrity of the regulatory process, casts aspersions over the quality of drugs and may pose serious risks to public health."

The new framework expands the legal authority of state and central drug regulators when processing applications under the existing drug framework.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Drug import approvals fully online with new rulebook

Priyanka Sharma
priyanka.sharma@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's apex drugs regulator is planning a new rulebook for importing bulk drugs and finished medicines by migrating all approval processes online, according to a document reviewed by *Mint*.

The proposed changes have been outlined in the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation's "Guidance Document on Common Submission Format for Import & Registration of Drug(s) (Bulk & Finished Formulations) in India", which will impact the country's \$60 billion pharmaceutical market, according to the department of pharmaceuticals. With bulk drug import dependence limited to around \$5.2 billion, India remains significantly reliant on foreign active pharmaceutical ingredients for critical bulk drugs and finished formulations used locally and for export.

RITES chairman and managing director Rahul Mithal told *Mint* in an interview that the company, working closely with Indian Railways, is now developing a prototype of a standard-gauge version of the in-service diesel locomotive for an Australian customer.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

RITES to help boost locomotive exports

Subhash Narayan
subhash.narayan@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

State-run railway engineering and consultancy firm RITES Ltd is preparing to open a much larger export market for Indian Railways' surplus diesel locomotives by developing a standard-gauge version of the country's in-service locomotives. The move could pave the way for sales across Australia, Europe, the Americas and parts of Africa, said a senior official aware of the matter.

The initiative comes on the back of RITES's successful development of Cape gauge variants of Indian Railways' broad-gauge diesel locomotives for South Africa, demonstrating that locomotives nearing the end of their domestic utility can be refurbished and adapted for overseas markets instead of being retired.

RITES chairman and managing director Rahul Mithal told *Mint* in an interview that the company, working closely with Indian Railways, is now developing a prototype of a standard-gauge version of the in-service diesel locomotive for an Australian customer.



RITES chairman and managing director Rahul Mithal said RITES is developing a prototype for an Australian customer.

The prototype is expected to be ready shortly for testing and validation.

Unlike India, which operates on the 1,676-mm broad gauge, most locomotives around the world use the 1,435-mm standard gauge. This has historically prevented Indian Railways' locomotives from being exported without extensive modification.

The ongoing project seeks to overcome that hurdle by redesigning the locomotive's running gear while retaining the proven powertrain and

other critical systems. "Once the prototype is approved by the customer, we see significant opportunities to offer these locomotives in other

standard-gauge markets," Mithal said, noting that once validated in Australia, the design can be replicated for other customers with relatively few modifications. Standard

gauge is the most widely used railway configuration globally, deployed across Europe, the Americas, East Asia, and several African nations.

The project marks the next phase of RITES's strategy to monetize Indian Railways' surplus diesel fleet at a time when the national transporter is aggressively electrifying its network. As electrification expands, hundreds of diesel locomotives that still have substantial operational life are expected to become available for redeployment.

According to official estimates, Indian Railways has more than 10,000 electric and 5,000 diesel locomotives in its network. According to Mithal, many of these diesel locomotives still have another 10-15 years of useful service left, making them attractive for freight operators, mining companies and industrial users that continue to depend on diesel traction.

"The biggest demand is for freight movement, particularly transportation of minerals from mines to ports and industrial locations. Several countries continue to rely on diesel locomotives for such operations," Mithal said.

Queries emailed to the railway ministry remained unanswered at the time of publishing.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

MINT SHORTS

Cabinet clears ₹23,700 crore GOBARdhan biogas scheme

New Delhi: The Union Cabinet on Thursday approved a ₹23,731-crore scheme to address the biggest hurdles holding back India's compressed biogas (CBG) sector. The GOBARdhan scheme, which is to be implemented over a period of 10 years from fiscal year 2027 (FY27) to FY36, aims to increase domestic CBG production by nearly ten-fold. **VIJAY C. ROY**

India, Singapore review bilateral ties in key areas

New Delhi: India and Singapore on Thursday reviewed

the progress of bilateral cooperation across the eight key areas outlined by the Roadmap for the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP) between the two countries. The two sides also exchanged views on regional and global developments and reaffirmed the importance of close coordination at international and regional fora, including Asean, in addressing shared challenges. **PTI**

Rupee falls 14 paise to close at 95.22 against US dollar

Mumbai: The rupee depreciated 14 paise to close at 95.22 against the US dollar on Thursday, on slight gains in the US Dollar Index and a modest increase in US Treasury yields. Traders said the rupee was pressured by a slight US Dollar Index recovery and foreign fund outflows, even as lower crude oil prices gave support. The rupee opened at 95.13 against the greenback and traded in a range of 95.12-95.24 during the session. **PTI**

Heavy rains may persist across much of India



New Delhi: Heavy rainfall may continue across parts of north-west, central, eastern and north-eastern India over the next week, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) warning of localized flash floods in Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Kerala and Tamil Nadu. IMD said rainfall is likely over northwest and central India as well as eastern and northeastern states. **VIJAY C. ROY**

'India needs to ease land acquisition for industries'

New Delhi: India needs to ease the process of land acquisition for setting up industries to attract more investments, Niti Aayog vice chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri said on Thursday. Addressing NCAER 'India Policy Forum 2026'.

India crosses 300GW non-fossil fuel capacity: Joshi

New Delhi: Union minister Pralhad Joshi on Thursday said India's non-fossil fuel electricity generation capacity has crossed the 300 gigawatt (GW) mark and the nation is on track to achieve its target of having 500GW of renewable energy by 2030. The minister informed that between January to June, 30.58 GW of non-fossil fuel-based electricity generation capacity was added. **PTI**

CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS

Mint welcomes comments, suggestions or complaints about errors.

Readers can alert the newsroom to any errors in the paper by emailing us, with your full name and address to feedback@livemint.com.

It is our policy to promptly respond to all complaints. Readers dissatisfied with the response or concerned about Mint's journalistic integrity may write directly to the editor by sending an email to askthedeitor@livemint.com

Mint's journalistic Code of Conduct that governs our newsroom is available at www.livemint.com



KKR buys Medicover's India hospital business

The Stockholm-based hospital chain offers over 80 clinical specialties

Priyamvada C.
priyamvada.c@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Global private equity firm KKR has acquired Indian hospital operations of Stockholm-based Medicover AB, which provides healthcare and diagnostics services globally, the companies said in a statement on Thursday.

The companies did not disclose the financial details of the transaction. The investment in Medicover India reflects KKR's belief in the long-term potential of India's healthcare ecosystem.

The development comes as the healthcare segment undergoes a strong wave of consolidation, as standalone and single-region players are increasingly being acquired by regional and national chains. This trend is expected to continue as larger chains move to solidify their presence, particularly in tier-II and tier-III cities, creating an integrated and competitive healthcare landscape, KPMG said in a December 2025 note.

"We are pleased to invest in Medicover India and look forward to contributing to its next phase by investing behind its talent, technology, infrastructure and clinical capabilities, while reinforcing strong clinical governance and operational standards," said Akshay Tanna, partner and head of India private equity at KKR.

Tanna added that the PE firm aims to broaden access to advanced healthcare and patient services through this investment.

Growing interest from PE funds is providing a large capital pool to back scaled-up assets and accelerating this trend. These funds are exploring platform approach in India to create larger and more integrated hospital networks.

More hospitals are now also exploring public markets to provide exit opportunities to PE funds, further shaping the sec-



Medicover India operates 24 multi-specialty hospitals with 4,800 beds and over 1,900 doctors across South and West India.

MINT

tor's evolution, KPMG added.

In December, KPMG highlighted that the multi-specialty hospital market in India is expanding rapidly, with an estimated market value of ₹6.3 trillion in 2024, projected to reach ₹9.8 trillion in 2028, reflecting a CAGR of around 12%.

As India advances the objectives of the National Health Policy 2017, sustained

Established in 2017, Medicover India is a multi-specialty hospital network with 24 hospitals and about 4,800 beds across South and West India. It provides comprehensive care across more than 80 clinical specialties and has more than 1,900 doctors and advanced clinical infrastructure and technology.

Since 2004, KKR has invested more than \$20 billion across the global healthcare ecosystem, supporting healthcare providers and businesses in strengthening clinical capabilities, investing in technology and infrastructure, and expanding access to high-quality care.

In India, KKR has invested across healthcare delivery, medical technology and related services, supporting businesses across the broader ecosystem.

KKR offerings span alternative asset management as well as capital markets and insurance solutions. It sponsors investment funds that invest in private equity, credit and real assets.

GROWTH PRESCRIPTION

KKR plans to invest in Medicover India's talent, technology, infrastructure and clinical capabilities

THE private equity fund is betting big on the long-term growth of India's healthcare sector

IT has invested over \$20 bn in healthcare globally since 2004, including India's fast-growing market

investment in healthcare infrastructure, clinical capabilities, technology, and innovation will help strengthen the delivery of high-quality care for patients and communities across the country, KKR said in the statement.

Kotak Investment Banking advised KKR on the acquisition of Medicover Hospitals India.

Shiprocket bets on non-shipping services

Sowmya Ramasubramanian
sowmya.r@livemint.com
BENGALURU

As Shiprocket prepares to launch its initial public offering (IPO) next week, managing director and chief executive Saahil Goel is betting on non-shipping services to drive the logistics aggregator's next phase of growth.

Offerings like cross-border commerce, omnichannel software, checkout tools, and marketing solutions generate over a quarter of total revenue and are growing nearly three times faster than its core business.

These emerging tech solutions accounted for more than 25% of revenue in FY26, surging 65% year-on-year compared to the company's overall revenue growth of about 25% and 14% growth in the core shipping business. The shift underscores Shiprocket's transition from a logistics enabler into a broader e-commerce technology platform.

"It's the same merchant transaction. Earlier, we only handled shipping. Today, we



Saahil Goel, managing director and chief executive officer, and Tanmay Kumar, chief financial officer, Shiprocket.

can improve checkout, help a merchant in Indore sell to customers in Indianapolis, or enable marketing. We're now monetizing multiple margin pools from the same transaction," Goel told *Mint* in an interview.

The strategy is important for Shiprocket as competition intensifies in merchant logistics. Rivals including Amazon Shipping, Delhivery, Blue Dart and XpressBees have all expanded their direct merchant offerings over the years, making logistics infrastruc-

ture increasingly competitive.

Goel, however, argued that Shiprocket's differentiation lies in solving a much broader set of merchant problems than merely moving parcels. "Our customer isn't someone sending a parcel from point A to point B. Our customer is anyone trying to build and scale a successful business. That's a fundamentally different DNA," he said on Thursday, adding that micro, small and medium businesses remain pivotal to Shiprocket's shipment volumes.

The company is set to open its ₹1,618-crore IPO for subscription on 12 August at a price band of ₹92-97 per share. The offering comprises a fresh issue worth up to ₹885.5 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of up to ₹731.9 crore by existing shareholders, including investors and founders.

The company will use the IPO proceeds to develop technology, including AI capabilities, make acquisitions and strategic investments, expand its fulfillment and dark-store network, and for general corporate purposes.

The issue size is materially lower than the ₹2,342 crore Shiprocket proposed in the draft prospectus it filed in December. Goel attributed the reduction to stronger profitability and cash generation, saying the business generated ₹53 crore of cash flow in FY26 while substantially improving its financial position.

Shiprocket reported operating revenue of ₹2,024 crore in FY26, up from ₹1,632 crore the previous year.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Super.money eyes commerce credit push

Salman SH
salman.hameeth@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Flipkart-backed fintech platform super.money is seeking to expand its revenue pool by adding a commerce-linked credit product to its Unified Payments Interface (UPI)-based financial services app.

The product, called splitStore, lets customers make a down payment and pay for purchases in three instalments, while the platform earns commissions from merchants. Currently in beta on Flipkart, it will soon go live on the app.

It can contribute up to 20% to the platform's revenue by December, chief executive Prakash Sikaria said in an interview. Credit products, including personal loans and credit cards, currently account for 80-90% of super.money's revenue, Sikaria said. That share will fall to around 60% by December, while payments and commerce will account for 20% of revenue each, he said.

Sikaria said splitStore is a closed-loop, small-ticket credit product designed primarily for new-to-credit users. Customers begin with a limit of ₹1,000-2,000, make a down payment and repay the balance in instalments.

The fintech firm is expanding beyond lending with splitStore, a commerce-linked credit product on its UPI app

"Once the customer proves that they will not default and will repay, they not only receive a higher limit on the platform, but also become eligible for open-loop products such as personal loans and credit cards," Sikaria said. The company believes its pay-in-three model reduces

transaction risk because the credit can be used only to purchase products from its catalogue. The limit is tied to a specific purchase rather than available for unrestricted spending, as with an open-loop credit card or credit line.

This differentiates splitStore from some buy-now-pay-later and zero-cost EMI products, in which customers may receive a pre-approved credit limit that can be used for a wider range of purchases.

It is positioning splitStore as an offering similar to Klarna's pay-in-four model in the US.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



ENHANCING MOBILITY AS ONE OF INDIA'S LEADING ELECTRICAL AND ELECTRONICS COMPANIES.

As an *established leader in automotive solutions*, we are delivering continued growth and value.

- One of India's leading electrical & electronics (E&E) companies.*
- One of India's top 2 players in wiring harnesses for two & three wheelers.*
- A diversified presence across multiple end markets, including commercial vehicles, off-highway vehicles, farming & industrial equipment.
- 22 manufacturing facilities, 3 engineering and design support centers & 7 warehouses across India and globally.**
- Providing access to major automotive clusters both in India & the world over.

*Source: CRISIL Report | ** As of March 31, 2026



Dhoot Transmission Limited

www.dhoottransmission.com

This pictorial representation of map of India does not purport to be the political map of India. Map not to scale.

DHOOT TRANSMISSION LIMITED, is proposing, subject to applicable statutory and regulatory requirements, receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP dated August 3, 2026 with the RoC. The RHP and Abridged Prospectus shall be available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, as well as on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE and NSE at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively, on the website of the Company at www.dhoottransmission.com and on the websites of the BRLMs, i.e. Axis Capital Limited, Jefferies India Private Limited, Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited, Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) Private Limited, SBI Capital Markets Limited and 360 ONE WAM Limited at www.axiscapital.co.in, www.jefferies.com, https://investmentbank.kotak.com, www.nomuraholdings.com/company/group/asia/india/index.html, www.sbicap.com and www.360.one, respectively. Any potential Bidders should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see **"Risk Factors"** on page 24 of the RHP. Potential Bidders should not rely on the UDRHP-1 filed with SEBI and the Stock Exchanges for making any investment decision and should instead rely on the RHP, when filed, for making an investment decision.

The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the United States Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the **"U.S. Securities Act"**) or any other applicable law of the United States and, unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, the Equity Shares are being offered and sold (a) within the United States only to persons reasonably believed to be "qualified institutional buyers" (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act and referred to in the RHP as **"U.S. QIBs"**); for the avoidance of doubt, the term **"U.S. QIBs"** does not refer to a category of institutional investor defined under applicable Indian regulations and referred to in the RHP as **"QIBs"** in transactions exempt from, or not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act; and (b) outside of the United States in offshore transactions as defined in and in compliance with Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act (**"Regulation S"**) and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales are made.

It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by Stock Exchanges should not in any way be deemed or construed that the Offer Document has been cleared or approved by Stock Exchanges nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the Offer Document. The investors are advised to refer to the Offer Document for the full text of the Disclaimer Clause of NSE and BSE Limited.

BSE Sensex				Nifty 50				Nifty 500				Nifty Next 50				Nifty 100				BSE 150 MidCap				BSE 250 SmallCap			
CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE	
78,954.76		0.48		24,636.00		0.05		23,729.45		-0.03		74,526.75		0.08		25,757.40		0.05		17,209.26		0.01		7,240.09		0.25	
PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	
78,581.00		78,782.43		24,624.65		24,641.00		23,735.55		23,756.15		74,469.95		74,478.90		25,744.05		25,758.60		17,207.26		17,275.92		7,222.09		7,248.53	
HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW	
78,954.76		78,633.73		24,677.05		24,604.15		23,783.85		23,708.55		74,649.75		74,236.90		25,798.45		25,720.05		17,277.23		17,169.78		7,261.86		7,222.68	

Airtel stock short on catalysts

Manish Joshi
feedback@livemint.com

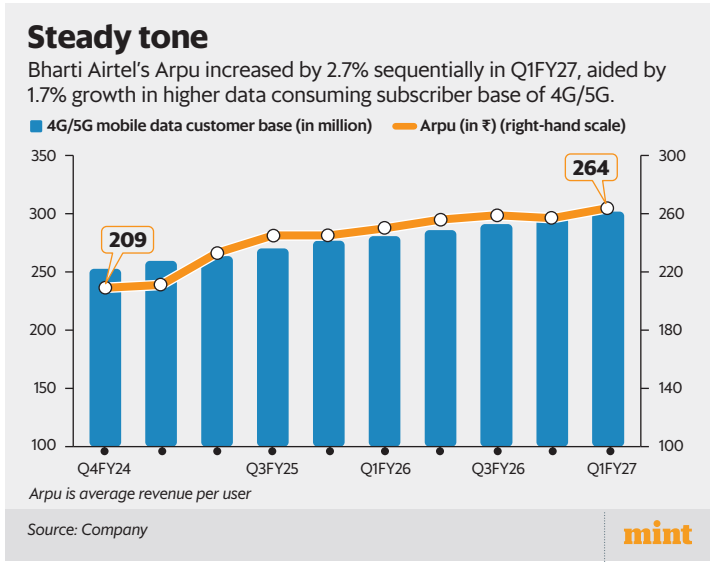
Bharti Airtel has delivered 6% sequential growth in consolidated Ebitda to ₹33,302 crore in the June quarter (Q1FY27). But the Street isn't impressed. The stock stayed flat post results, and is down 7% so far in 2026, as tariff hikes in India's mobile services business remain elusive.

India's mobile services account for nearly 80% of Airtel's sum-of-the-parts (SoTP) valuation; hence, its prospects are critical.

India mobile Arpu (average revenue per user) rose 2.7% q-o-q in Q1FY27 to ₹264 due to a combination of factors such as more days, upgrading customers from 2G services to 4G/5G and growth in postpaid users.

Airtel has used 5G network slicing technology to launch a 'fast lane' for postpaid users in Q1FY27. This may have aided a 3.6% q-o-q increase in postpaid user base to 30 million.

The 'fast lane' plan enables fast and stable data speed in crowded areas



for postpaid users, which now form about 8% of total user base that rose by about 20 bps q-o-q and 70 bps y-o-y. While the number of postpaid users has increased, it remains to be seen how much more the company can earn from each customer.

Nonetheless, higher Arpu led to 4% q-o-q increase in Ebitda of India

mobile services to ₹18,187 crore. Airtel business or enterprise segment, the second biggest vertical, reported 5.7% q-o-q increase in Ebitda to ₹2,492 crore. The segment has been gaining momentum after winning several deals across cloud, core connectivity, security and internet of things. However, the huge gap in

Ebitda of the top two verticals indicates that mobile services will stay the crucial driver for the stock.

Homes services (broadband internet services) and digital TV services had a poor quarter in terms of net subscriber addition. Homes services subscriber addition fell 58% q-o-q to 473,000, and digital TV addition was negligible. The Arpu of both segments remained flat q-o-q at ₹523 and ₹160, respectively.

Besides India, can Airtel's investors hope for material gains from Africa telecom operations? The gains could come from two factors—Bharti increasing stake in Africa business beyond 79% and higher valuation multiples for the business.

Well, the gains may not be material. The value of Airtel's stake in Airtel Africa based on the current market capitalization works out to ₹1.35 trillion. So, the business contributes about ₹200 per share to Bharti's SoTP valuation. If Bharti buys the

remaining 21% stake in Airtel Africa, the SoTP valuation increases by ₹40 per share. This hardly moves the needle for the stock, which is trading at ₹1948.

Can Airtel Africa be assigned higher valuation multiples? Airtel Africa is trading at a price-to-earnings multiple of 17, based on annualized profit of Q1FY27. Even if a 50% higher multiple is assumed, Airtel's value can increase by just ₹100 per share, which is just about 5% upside. So, Airtel's stock may not see large upsides in the near term driven by Airtel Africa business.

In the long term, further value accretion for Airtel's shareholders will depend on profits from its Africa telecom operations. For now, the stock might remain range-bound. Apart from tariff hike, a higher-than-expected IPO valuation for Reliance Industries' telecom business Jio Platforms, can act as a re-rating catalyst for the Bharti stock.

LIMITED GAIN

FURTHER stake increase in Africa telecom might lead to upside of only ₹40 per share

EVEN if a 50% higher valuation multiple is assumed for Airtel Africa, Bharti's gain is ₹100 per share

New loan recovery rules from 1 Jan as RBI defers rollout

Shayan Ghosh
shayan.g@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has agreed to the banking industry's request to defer the implementation of its guidelines on the conduct of regulated entities in loan recovery and engagement of recovery agents by three months to 1 January 2027. The regulator also clarified that the directions would not apply to the lenders' own employees.

"Considering the technical and operational changes necessitated by the directions, the effective date has been extended to 1 January 2027 to facilitate smooth implementation," the central bank said on Thursday. The norms were earlier slated to kick in from 1 October.

In February, RBI had proposed norms barring recovery agents from going too far in their pursuit of defaulting bor-



RBI had told lenders to avoid harsh loan recovery tactics.

rowers. The regulator had said that neither the bank's employee, nor the recovery agent should engage in any harsh methods to recover dues. Use of abusive language, sending inappropriate messages either on mobile or through social media, excessively calling or calling outside the prescribed hours would be considered harsh.

In its latest statement, RBI said the terms 'recovery agent' and 'recovery agent' indicate that lenders' own employees are not covered under these definitions.

"A recovery agent does not include a collection agent who is engaged for collection of regular periodic instalments from borrowers. If multiple activities such as collection, recovery or

possession are carried out through the same agent, the instructions, as applicable to the activity being carried out, shall be required to be followed by the agent," RBI said. Loan recovery has emerged as a contentious issue in recent years, bringing back memories from the late 2000s, when private banks used coercive tactics for the process.

In September 2022, RBI had asked Mahindra & Mahindra Financial Services (Mahindra Finance) to stop recoveries through external agencies after the death of an individual allegedly in the recovery process. The restrictions were lifted four months later.

In its latest statement, RBI directed banks to have a dedicated mechanism for redressal of recovery-related grievances. It said the details of this mechanism shall be provided to the borrower by including it under the loan agreement and while advising the details of the recovery agency. The regulator also said a bank or the recovery agencies engaged by it will have to carry out verification of the antecedents of the recovery agents.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

RBI has directed banks to have a dedicated mechanism for redressal of recovery-related grievances

Berger Q2 may beat Asian Paints, but rivals rising for both

Harsha Jethmalani
harsha.j@livemint.com

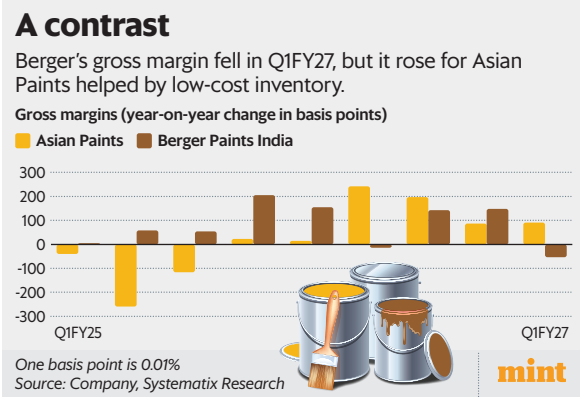
Berger Paints India's June quarter (Q1FY27) result was decent, but lagged larger rival Asian Paints on some parameters. Consolidated revenue at ₹3,583 crore grew 12% year-on-year, a multi-quarter high, led by price hikes and volume. Mainstay decorative paints volumes rose 8.4%, slightly below Asian Paints' 9%.

Traction in high-margin emulsions and construction chemicals aided value growth of 13.5%. Input cost inflation and delayed price hikes in

industrial paints reduced gross margin to 40.9%, while Asia Paints' margin rose, mainly shielded by low-cost inventory.

Asian Paints is bracing for full impact of cost inflation from Q2FY27, but Berger could be better off. Q2 revenue growth may be better than Q1 due to volume and price growth of 7-8% each, the management said.

Double-digit revenue growth would sustain in FY27 aided by distribution expansion, product launches and festive demand starting late Diwali. It expects high single-digit volume growth in FY27.



Berger, which added 2,100 tinting machines in Q1, aims to add 10,000 more in FY27, signalling aggressive market

expansion. "We believe the numerical gap between the distribution network of the market leader (Asian Paints)

and Berger could materially reduce in the next three years," said ICICI Securities. Demand trends were healthy with south and north India continuing to outperform, while east was impacted by Assam floods. Ebitda margin expanded to 16.9%, led by operating leverage and disciplined cost control. FY27 operating margin guidance was retained at 15-17%.

Berger expects Q2FY27 operating margin to expand year-on-year, implying a high-teens Ebitda growth and a lower-than-feared input cost inflation impact in Q2, said Systematic Shares and Stocks. It raised

Berger's FY27 and FY28 EPS estimates by 9% and 5%, respectively. Both paint makers acknowledged intense competition as new entrants gain grip. Berger said Birla Opus' pricing is now at par with the industry, but rebates to larger dealers have increased.

The overhang of competition could delay a meaningful re-rating for the sector even as demand improves. The Berger stock is around 10% away from its 52-week high seen in November and trades at a rich FY28 price-to-earnings multiple of 44 compared to Asian Paint's 46, showed Bloomberg data.

Option traders face delivery risks under closing auction

Srushti Vaidya
srushti.vaidya@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Derivative traders and institutional funds could face unexpected stock delivery on monthly stock option expiries under the newly introduced closing auction session, as final settlement prices are determined only after the order-matching window closes, market experts told *Mint*.

Because a stock option triggers stock delivery only if it expires in the money (ITM)—at a price that beats the open market—market participants will not know whether they are obligated to take or deliver underlying shares until the auction concludes.

Options that finish out of the money (OTM)—when the market price is better than the option's price—expire worthless without triggering any delivery obligations.

The upcoming monthly stock option expiries on 25 August for the NSE and 27 August for the BSE will serve as the first key test for the new mechanism. In contrast, index derivative traders will remain unaffected by these settlement uncertainties, as index contracts are settled strictly in cash.

Market experts warned that traders caught short on underlying stock during an unexpected ITM assignment—a surprise demand to fulfill the contract—may have to deliver shares at a much higher premium the next day.



Options that finish out of the money, expire worthless without triggering any delivery obligations.

pected ITM assignment—a surprise demand to fulfill the contract—may have to deliver shares at a much higher premium the next day.

"The weekly Nifty expiry on Tuesday saw positions changing from OTM to ITM because the last 15 minutes brought greater volatility. The chances of that happening in the month-end physical delivery expiry sessions are also very high," said an executive at a leading domestic brokerage.

The new trading mechanism creates volatile price movements during the 3:15 pm to 3:30 pm auction window, which can abruptly push an option contract from OTM to ITM, creating a delivery liability that the trader had not anticipated or hedged against.

Puneet Sharma, chief executive officer and fund manager at WhiteSpace Alpha, which runs long-short alternative investment funds (AIFs), said the risk arises mainly for traders with multiple positions rather than someone with a single open position.

For instance, someone who has sold both a call and a put at different strike prices could see a sharp swing in the closing auction push an OTM option into the money, instantly triggering an unexpected physical delivery obligation, Sharma added.

If physical delivery is triggered and the trader does not possess the required shares, the obligation is met through the exchange's auction mechanism that runs daily in parallel to the normal trading session between 2:30 and 3:00 PM. This auction is not to be confused with the closing auction session.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Trent store count jumps in Q1, misses Street view

Vaeshnavi Kasthuril
k.vaeshnavi@livemint.com
BENGALURU

Trent Ltd delivered another quarter of double-digit revenue and profit growth, powered by an aggressive store expansion strategy, but slowing demand at existing outlets kept the Tata Group retailer from meeting Street expectations.

Consolidated revenue from operations rose 17.8% year-on-year to ₹5,754.7 crore in the June quarter, missing the *Bloomberg* consensus estimate of ₹5,870 crore. Consolidated net profit increased 22% to ₹518.1 crore, below analysts' expectations of ₹530 crore.

"The business delivered encouraging performance during the quarter notwithstanding continuing macroeconomic volatility and geopolitical events," chairman Noel N. Tata said. Trent brands represent only a small share of the overall addressable market, providing significant headroom for growth, he said.

In Q1, Trent added 22 Zudio stores and one Westside store, while consolidating three Zudio outlets. It entered nine cities, taking its portfolio to 301 Westside stores, 982 Zudio stores, including seven in the UAE, and 29 stores across other lifestyle concepts.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Gulf war unleashes an input cost storm

Abhinaba Saha
abhinaba.saha@livemint.com
MUMBAI

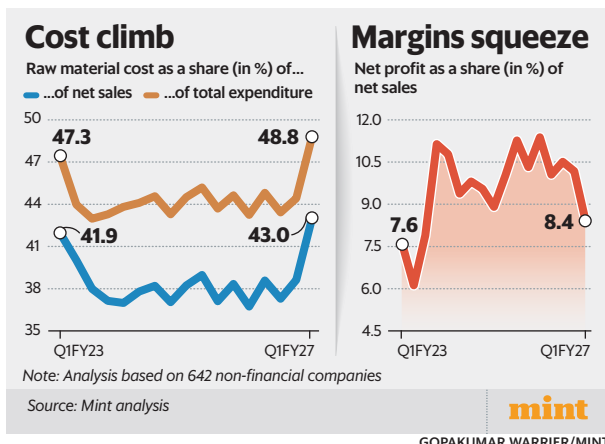
The West Asia conflict has inflicted a steeper raw material cost shock on Indian companies than the Russia-Ukraine war, eroding profitability across the board.

In the April-June quarter of FY27, Raw materials accounted for a larger share of both expenditure and sales than they did at the peak of the crude oil crisis in 2022 triggered by Russia's invasion of Ukraine, squeezing India Inc's operating and net profit margins to three-year lows.

A *Mint* analysis of standalone earnings of 642 non-banking, financial services and insurance (non-BFSI) companies shows raw material cost accounted for almost 45% of net sales and about 50% of total expenditure during the quarter. In other words, manufacturers spent nearly ₹45 out of every ₹100 earned on raw materials, while almost half of every rupee of expenditure went towards procuring inputs.

By contrast, in Q1 FY23, when companies first faced a spike in global commodity prices due to the Russia-Ukraine war, raw materials accounted for 42% of net sales and 47% of total expenditure. The latest data suggests crude-linked input costs are exerting a bigger drag on non-financial companies than they did three years ago.

As a result, aggregate net profit fell nearly 9% year-on-year in Q1 FY27, marking the weakest performance in almost two years. Operating



margins contracted about 450 basis points from a year ago to 15.3%, while net profit margins declined almost 300 basis points to 8.4%, both at their lowest levels since FY23.

The weakening trend is also visible at the index level, with the Nifty 500's net profit margin shrinking to 9.8% from 11.3% a year earlier, even as

As inventories are replenished and supplier contracts repriced, margin pressure is likely to intensify in Q2 and Q3

This 153-basis-point contraction already exceeds the latest forecast of a 100 bps margin hit for FY27, based on the current situation in West Asia, said Mishra. By comparison, the Russia-Ukraine commodity shock compressed all-listed companies' operating margins by about 100 basis points over the first nine months of FY23, he said.

"So on a pure bps-of-compression basis, the current

shock has already done comparable or worse near-term damage in a single quarter than the 2022 episode did over three," he added.

The US-Iran war, which erupted in late February, has disrupted West Asian oil and gas supplies, pushing up raw material prices by nearly 45% year-on-year and 20% sequentially in the June quarter.

The trend suggests investments in captive renewable capacity, waste-heat recovery systems and long-term power purchase agreements have lowered energy intensity across manufacturers, helping absorb part of the commodity shock, said Joshi.

Mishra of SKG Investments added that India's captive power generation capacity is expected to rise at an annual rate of about 8.5% through 2030, reflecting sustained investment in energy self-sufficiency to reduce exposure to volatile grid tariffs. "This is a durable competitive advantage, but its impact will be sector-concentrated, not economy-wide," he added.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

As inventories are replenished and supplier contracts repriced, margin pressure is likely to intensify in Q2 and Q3, particularly for chemicals, paints, auto ancillaries and packaging companies, Joshi cautioned. "That said, I don't expect a hit like FY23, since (India Inc's) sourcing and balance sheet improvements are real," he added.

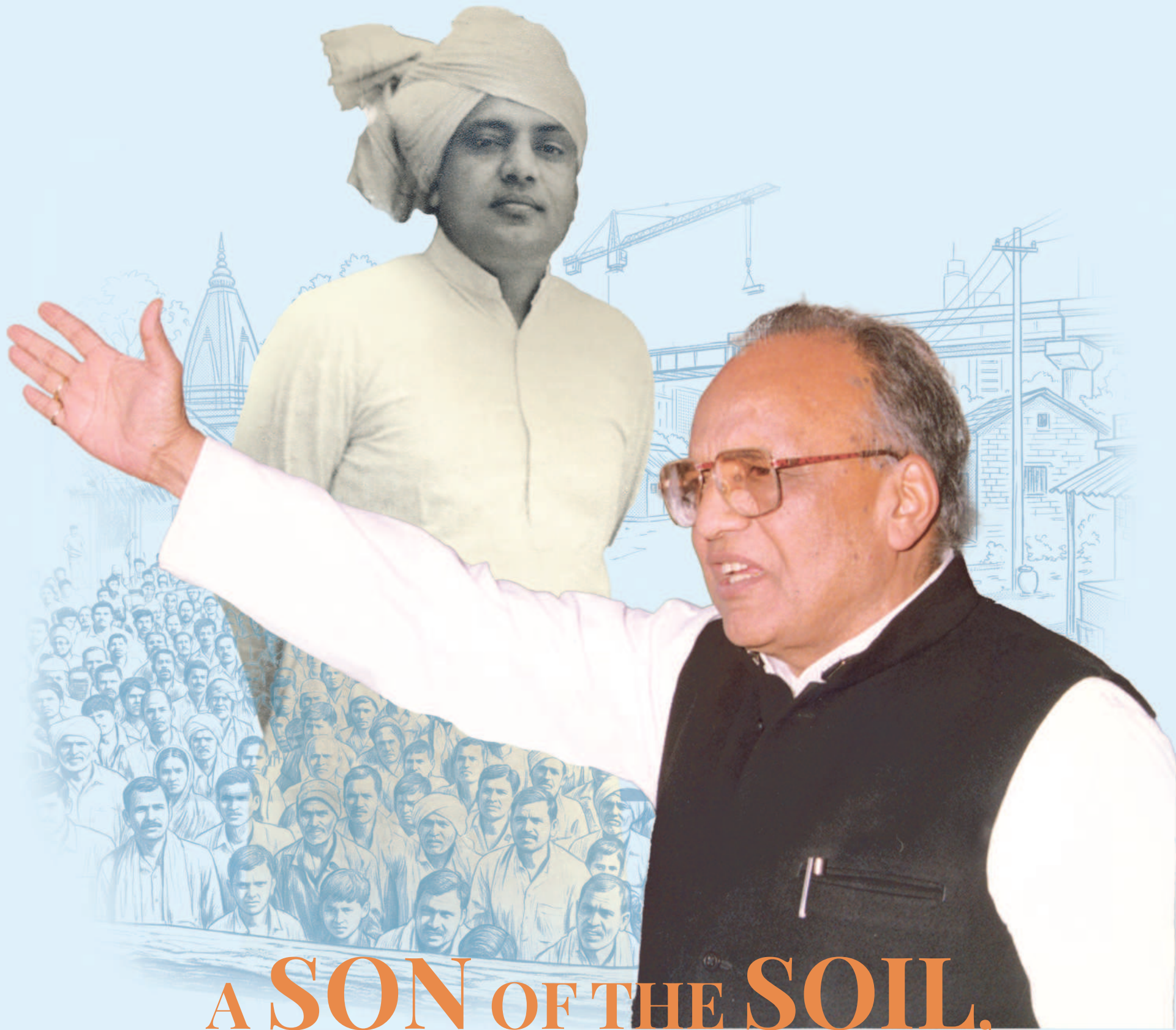
A part of that resilience also stems from companies being structurally less exposed to energy costs, the analysis showed. Power costs accounted for 4% of sales, down from nearly 6% during the Russia-Ukraine crisis. They also made up just 5% of total expenditure, compared with almost 7% three years ago, despite power expenses rising nearly 15% year-on-year and about 20% sequentially in the June quarter.

The trend suggests investments in captive renewable capacity, waste-heat recovery systems and long-term power purchase agreements have lowered energy intensity across manufacturers, helping absorb part of the commodity shock, said Joshi.

Mishra of SKG Investments added that India's captive power generation capacity is expected to rise at an annual rate of about 8.5% through 2030, reflecting sustained investment in energy self-sufficiency to reduce exposure to volatile grid tariffs. "This is a durable competitive advantage, but its impact will be sector-concentrated, not economy-wide," he added.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

#RememberingBauji



A SON OF THE SOIL, A LEADER WHO SHAPED SOCIETY

7TH AUGUST 1930 ~ 31ST MARCH 2005

Shri O.P. Jindal never saw barriers. He saw possibilities waiting to be unlocked. A son of the soil, a visionary, and a nation-builder, he opened doors to new horizons of development—expanded access to education, promoted affordable healthcare, and pioneered employment opportunities in rural India. He transformed countless lives, and helped build our India.

On his 96th Birth Anniversary, we remember a legacy that continues to inspire generations.



SCAN THIS QR CODE
TO WATCH THE VIDEO



Coal India to enter iron ore mining with Odisha block

CIL won the bid by quoting a 114% premium for the Gadadharpur block over the notified value

Dipali Banka
dipali.banka@livemint.com
MUMBAI

State-owned Coal India Ltd (CIL) has launched a gambit to diversify into iron ore mining after emerging as the top bidder for a key mining block in Odisha. This marks the coal behemoth's entry into a highly competitive sector dominated by its public sector peer, NMDC Ltd.

The Gadadharpur block, spread over 265.05 hectares in the Keonjhar district, holds estimated resources of about 258.04 million tonnes of iron ore. CIL won the bid by quoting a 114% premium over the notified value, according to people familiar with the matter.

In a stock exchange filing post market hours on Thursday, Coal India confirmed it is the preferred bidder for the Odisha block and that the auction premium was 114.05%.

The development comes at a time when India's leading steelmakers have repeatedly flagged concerns over soaring premiums for iron ore blocks, warning that these erode the economic benefits of owning captive mines. Iron ore is a key raw material used in steel production.

Coal India did not immediately respond to *Mint's* queries.

In an earlier interview with *Mint*, Tata Steel chief executive T.V. Narandran had said the economics of iron ore mining have changed sharply over the past few years.

"The cost of iron ore in India is going up. A lot of the value of upstream, not just for Tata Steel but for the industry, was that iron ore was plenty and available at a competitive price. But in the last five or six years, the iron ore cost has gone up hugely," Narandran had said. "So, a lot of that value is going as premium and taxes and levies to the government even before you start



The Gadadharpur block holds estimated resources of about 258.04 million tonnes of iron ore.

BLOOMBERG

making steel. Some of that value which was automatically available upstream is no longer available so easily."

His remarks show why major steelmakers have become increasingly selective in mine auctions. Both Tata Steel and JSW Steel have indicated reluctance to bid for iron ore blocks

increasing domestic production of iron ore to support the country's ambitious steel capacity target of 300 million tonnes by 2030.

"Unlike integrated steel producers, whose profitability is directly influenced by the cost of captive ore, CIL could potentially monetize the resource

The bid premium also highlights the intense competition for high-quality iron ore deposits in Odisha, India's largest iron ore-producing state. With steel demand expected to remain strong over the coming years, access to long-term iron ore reserves has become important even as high auction premiums continue to divide opinion within the industry.

The coal ministry is also pursuing a broad diversification strategy for coal public sector enterprises (CPSEs) to reduce their dependence on coal and ensure long-term sustainability amid the country's green transition, while strengthening India's energy security.

As part of this push, companies such as Coal India are expanding into renewable energy, critical minerals, coal gasification and power generation. However, iron ore was not a part of this strategy.

IRON WILL			
COAL India said it is the preferred bidder for the Odisha block and that the auction premium was 114.05%	STEELMAKERS have flagged concerns over soaring premiums for iron ore blocks	TATA and JSW avoid bidding for iron ore blocks where auction premiums are above 100%	COAL India's move supports the government's 300mt steel goal by 2030
where auction premiums exceed 100%, arguing that such bids make the long-term economics difficult to justify despite the strategic importance of securing raw material.		through commercial mining and supply to the domestic steel industry. This would also increase the supply of the ore in the country as India's top steelmakers add capacities," said Dhruv Goel, chief executive of BigMint, a commodities market intelligence firm.	

Two-wheeler makers revamp, gear up for EV, premium shift

Ayaan Kartik
ayaan.kartik@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's legacy two-wheeler makers, including Hero MotoCorp Ltd, Bajaj Auto Ltd and TVS Motor Co. Ltd, are revamping their organisations and retail strategies to drive growth in electric and premium motorcycles and scooters.

The leading two-wheeler makers are undertaking a series of measures, including integrating their electric vehicle (EV) businesses with core two-wheeler operations, creating dedicated leadership roles for high-growth segments and rolling out exclusive retail networks to boost sales.

Analysts said rising EV sales have prompted companies to integrate their electric businesses more closely with core two-wheeler operations, while premium vehicles require a differentiated marketing strategy.

EV sales surged 22% to 1.4 million units in fiscal year 2026 (FY26) while premium motorcycles sales, defined as those above 125cc engine capacity,

rose 15% to 3.5 million units, according to the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) data. Entry-level sales rose 3% to 9.5 million units in FY26.

Bajaj Auto has merged its standalone electric two-wheeler business with its legacy two-wheeler division to scale up EV manufacturing, plans to double exclusive EV outlets to 1,000 over the next two years, and is expanding its KTM and Triumph dealership network to strengthen its presence in the premium motorcycle segment.

"Domestic two-wheelers, to capture some synergies, we have brought our electric two-



EV sales surged 22% to 1.4 million units in FY26 while premium motorcycles sales rose 15% to 3.5 million units.

PTI

wheeler business under the umbrella of the two-wheeler business unit," Rakesh Sharma, joint managing director at Bajaj Auto, said in an earnings call on 21 July.

Sharma also explained how the company's retail store strategy is evolving for both its electric two-wheeler business through the Chetak brand and the premium motorcycle brands KTM and Triumph.

"I think, 530-550 stores to 1,000 stores. I can see 1,000 stores coming in a couple of

years. And now that's something solid we are talking about. Those number of stores with the brand Chetak with a full portfolio, I think should set us up very, very nicely," Sharma said. For

its Triumph and KTM brands, it has rolled out 90 stores where both brands are available as part of its premium dealership playbook.

To be sure, TVS Motor Co. and Bajaj Auto lead the Indian electric two-wheeler market.

Earlier this week, Hero MotoCorp announced it has created a dedicated premium business leadership division and expanded premium retail outlets. This followed the com-

pany's appointment of Kausalya Nandakumar as chief business officer of its Emerging Mobility Business Unit in July 2025, creating a separate leadership role for its EV business.

On Monday, the New Delhi-based two-wheeler maker also announced the appointment Anuj Dua as chief business officer to lead its premium segment, overseeing portfolio expansion and the rollout of exclusive retail stores.

"Driven by strong FY26 momentum, the company is sharpening its focus on the premium segment through dedicated leadership, an expanding product portfolio, differentiated retail experiences and global partnerships," the company had said in its statement on the appointment.

TVS Motor combined its EV and commuter business leadership in FY26 to improve planning and execution while creating a new TVS Paddock retail network for premium vehicles. The company also elevated Aniruddha Haldar to lead its EV business in addition to his existing responsibilities as head of the commuter business and corporate brand and media during the last financial year.

TVS did not respond to *Mint's* queries.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

ADVERTISEMENT

Celebrating scientific excellence to advance India's life sciences ecosystem

Backed by ₹7 crore in grant support across categories, applications are now open for the inaugural Bharat Life Sciences Award.

India has emerged as one of the world's fastest-growing life sciences ecosystems, with significant advances across pharmaceuticals, biotechnology, medical devices, diagnostics, and digital health. As the country strengthens its position as a global innovation hub, investments in research, infrastructure and entrepreneurship must be complemented by credible platforms that recognise and elevate scientific excellence. Such recognition not only celebrates achievement but also inspires future innovators, strengthens collaboration and accelerates the translation of breakthrough discoveries into real-world impact. It is this belief—and Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji's conviction that India's scientific excellence deserves greater visibility and recognition—that underpins the Bharat Life Sciences Award, a national platform created to celebrate those shaping the future of healthcare and life sciences in India.

India's emergence as a global innovation powerhouse has been

driven by a combination of talent, entrepreneurship and supportive public policy. From information technology and pharmaceuticals to digital public infrastructure, the country has consistently demonstrated its ability to build globally competitive sectors anchored in innovation. Today, life sciences represent the next frontier of this growth. Advances across biotechnology, pharmaceuticals, medical devices, diagnostics and digital health are transforming healthcare while creating high-value employment, attracting investment and strengthening India's position in the global knowledge economy. As nations compete for leadership in science and technology, research capability is increasingly becoming a strategic national asset.

India is well positioned to capitalise on this opportunity. The country is home to a deep pool of scientific talent, globally respected research institutions, a vibrant startup ecosystem and a growing culture of entrepreneurship. Indian scientists and innovators are advancing progress across drug discovery,



biotechnology, vaccine development, precision medicine, diagnostics, medical technology and digital health. Startups are translating scientific ideas into scalable healthcare solutions, while research institutions continue to generate discoveries with global relevance. Yet many of these achievements remain known primarily within specialist communities.

It is against this backdrop that Lilly India and FICCI, have launched the Bharat Life Sciences Award a first-of-its-kind national platform dedicated to recognising excellence across India's life sciences

ecosystem. Convened in consultation with the Office of the Principal Scientific Adviser to the Government of India and the Department of Pharmaceuticals and supported by the Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council and Invest India, the initiative seeks to create a credible national platform that celebrates scientific excellence while encouraging collaboration across the ecosystem.

The inaugural Bharat Life Sciences Award ceremony will be held on 1 October 2026, bringing together scientists, innovators, institutions, entrepreneurs, and ecosystem

leaders from across the country. The Award is guided by an eminent Advisory Council and judged through an independent jury comprising distinguished experts in life sciences, innovation, and public health. Sir Thornton Bharat will serve as the Process Advisor, reinforcing the platform's commitment to transparency, independence, and integrity.

The Award recognise excellence across the life sciences ecosystem—from young scientists and multidisciplinary research teams to research institutions, healthcare and life sciences startups, and organisations advancing scientific innovation in India.

The Award comprises two streams—Samman (Grant) and Gaurav (Recognition)—covering six awards across five categories. Together, they recognise contributions across scientific research, collaborative innovation, translational medicine, institutional leadership, healthcare entrepreneurship, and ecosystem development. Backed by ₹7 crore in grant support, the initiative seeks not only to celebrate

achievement but also to encourage continued scientific advancement.

For applicants, participation in a credible, independently governed platform can strengthen credibility, create opportunities for cross-sector collaboration, and connect innovators with key stakeholders across academia, industry, investors, and government. For startups, it offers valuable validation; for research institutions, it highlights scientific leadership; and for early-career scientists, it provides encouragement at a defining stage of their professional journey.

HOW TO APPLY?
Applications for the inaugural Bharat Life Sciences Award are now open.



For more information, visit:
bharatlifesciencesawards.com



'US generics tariffs more negotiation tactic than threat'

Jessica Jani
jessica.jani@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Biocon Ltd is not rushing to react to proposed US tariffs on generic drugs in its largest market as it sees the move as a negotiation tactic rather than a real threat, executive chairperson Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw told *Mint* in an interview, noting that tariffs would undermine Washington's efforts to lower healthcare costs.

The biopharmaceutical giant, which is among the world's top biosimilar manufacturers, remains in wait-and-watch mode, while exploring US manufacturing partnerships if required, Shaw said.

The company has already expanded manufacturing capabilities in the US and is open to looking at other opportunities, she added.

"There are certain products that we are already looking at making in the US. We announced that we are looking at a partnership in insulins for fill and finish and we are looking at some other opportunities that we have of bringing biologics manufacturing in the US through Syngene," she said. "I think we will wait and watch, but we don't believe that this is going to be carried through."

The US remains an important market for both generics and biosimilars as it continues to rely heavily on them for affordable healthcare. Generics and biosimilars account for roughly 90% of prescriptions in the US but only around 10% of drug spending by value.

Imposing steep tariffs on these medicines would increase healthcare inflation in the US, making it difficult for policymakers to meet their objective of lowering drug



Biocon executive chairperson Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw. REUTERS

costs, Shaw said, describing the tariff proposal as "more like a negotiating threat and less of a real threat".

While Biocon has a manufacturing presence in the US, she said firms need not necessarily build wholly-owned plants to raise local production. "You can partner, you can outsource... what is the right balance is what we need to look at."

In July, US President Donald Trump proposed a phased tariff plan for imported generic drugs, starting at 100% in 2028 and rising to 200% the year after. The plan is widely believed to be unviable, given the short timeline and the country's dependence on generics. It is also unclear if biosimilars are included in the plan. While generics are exact copies of chemical drugs, biosimilars are highly similar versions of innovative biologic drugs.

Biocon's business spans biosimilars, generics and research services under Syngene International. It merged its biosimilars subsidiary Biocon Biologics with the parent company last year.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Storage, transmission in focus

India's energy transition depends on rapid expansion of the two, said experts at the *Mint* Sustainability Summit

Rituraj Baruah
rituraj.baruah@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

With renewable energy capacity expanding and tariffs lower than conventional power, the next phase of India's energy transition will depend on a rapid expansion of transmission infrastructure to integrate green power into the grid along with large-scale energy storage, stakeholders said at the *Mint* Sustainability Summit 2026.

"India is clearly moving from building renewable energy assets to building a dependable energy system. The next phase is fundamental," Deepak Thakur, managing director and chief executive of Hinduja Renewables, said during a panel discussion on "Energy Transition 2.0: Green Power, Hydrogen & the New Energy Economy".



(From left): Derek M. Shah, MD and CEO, L&T Greentech, Madhav Pai, CEO, WRI India, and Deepak Thakur, MD and CEO, Hinduja Renewables

"It will not be measured in gigawatts (GW), it will now be measured in terms of...can we deliver when customers actually need it? Projects which we are conceiving cannot be standalone solar and wind; we have to talk about integrated portfolios. This has to combine generation, storage,

forecasting and transmission."

Noting that investors' viewpoints are also changing, Thakur said that investors are looking at project evacuation, storage integration, operating capability, and long-term reliability.

According to Madhav Pai, CEO of WRI India, India needs greater trans-

parency regarding delays in the addition of transmission capacity and the expansion of "behind-the-meter" battery storage systems installed at consumers' premises, such as those of PM Surya Ghar beneficiaries and commercial and industrial users. Behind-the-meter installation of battery storage would help add 20% of the required battery energy capacity, Pai added.

"It's very clear that the grid is going to lag 40-50GW behind what we generate...To reduce this gap, just being able to make this information much more transparent, much more visible...can get the right attention to accelerate it," Pai said.

Speaking on the transition in sectors other than electricity, Derek M. Shah, MD & CEO of L&T Greentech, said that in sectors such as refineries and fertilizers, efforts have already

started towards the adoption of green hydrogen and green ammonia from the conventional feedstocks of grey hydrogen and natural gas.

"Beyond electricity, there are these chemical industries, oil and gas industries, fertilizers, refineries, mobility, and steel. There is a need to look into this. Transition is not only

happening in the electricity sector...The decarbonization of refineries has started to happen. The oil marketing companies are coming up with their

tenders to replace part of their grey to green hydrogen," Shah said, while mentioning Solar Energy Corporation of India Ltd's recent tender for green ammonia and the government's plans to bring a green methanol tender for the shipping industry.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



India's water crisis is about management, not rainfall: Bisleri CEO

Vijay C. Roy
vijay.roy@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Despite receiving roughly 4,000 billion cubic metres of annual rainfall, India's rapidly depleting per capita water availability has escalated into a management crisis that poses direct financial risks to businesses, according to Bisleri International CEO Angelo George.

Speaking at the *Mint Sustainability Summit 2026* held recently in Mumbai, George warned that India's per capita water availability has plummeted by 75% over the past 70

years. If the current trajectory remains unchecked, he noted, large urban centres will face critical shortages by 2035.

"The NITI Aayog 2023 report says that the water crisis accentuates the financial risk for businesses in India. It is not a challenge of rainfall, it is a crisis of water management and governance,"

George said, adding that the future of the water sector relies on intelligent resource optimization rather than merely increasing supply.

To mitigate these growing

environmental and operational risks, the packaged drinking water major is aggressively expanding its conservation footprint. According to George, Bisleri has integrated rainwater harvesting infrastructure across its facilities and is actively restoring local watersheds.

Extending its mandate to rural areas, the company is building check dams to support farmer livelihoods and has committed to constructing at least one new reservoir every year.



Angelo George, CEO, Bisleri International.

For the packaged water industry, he identified packaging, water security and energy use as the three biggest sustainability challenges. While

plastic remains under scrutiny, he argued that the material itself is not the problem; rather, inadequate waste collection and recycling systems are the primary challenge.

He maintained that packaging decisions should be based on product safety, affordability, scalability and lifecycle emissions rather than on public perception alone. "We are not in the business of selling plastic. We are in the business of selling water," he said, adding that any alternative packaging material must be commercially viable and capable of serving India's mass market.

Bisleri has also advocated the creation of a water credit

market, similar to the one for carbon credits, to reward measurable improvements in water conservation. The company said its research, carried out with scientific institutions, found that a significant portion of its water footprint lies outside factory operations, highlighting the need for broader, ecosystem-wide resource management.

It has also increased the share of renewable energy in its operations to 37% and expanded the use of electric vehicles and forklifts to lower emissions across its logistics network, the company said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



FROM INDIA TO THE GLOBE

Delivering quality diagnostics, one innovation at a time.

Truenat, our flagship technology, is patented in 100+ countries and enables timely and accurate diagnosis of 30 diseases.

Molbio is an innovative point-of-care diagnostics company focused on expanding access to accurate, rapid and cost-effective healthcare technologies to diagnose infectious and non-infectious diseases.

The company has strong in-house R&D capabilities with 153 permanent employees, including 136 scientists and a proven track record of developing innovative diagnostic products.

Molbio's flagship innovation, Truenat®, is a novel portable multi-disease diagnostic platform patented in over 100 countries. As of March 31, 2025, it can diagnose 30 diseases.

Truenat® is one of only two rapid molecular tests in the world endorsed by the WHO for the initial diagnosis of tuberculosis (TB) and the detection of rifampicin resistance detection using molecular diagnostic technology. (Source: 1Latitude Report)

Molbio's product portfolio also includes solutions for radiology, digital pathology, and breast health screening through its subsidiaries, Prognosys Medical Systems Private Limited and OptraScan, as well as its collaboration partner, UE Lifesciences.

Molbio's products are offered globally across public health programs, diagnostic laboratories, and both private and public hospitals.



Molbio Diagnostics Limited
[molbioldiagnostics.com](#)

Why food labels are under the FSSAI scanner

FROM FRONT FLAP

2 What laws govern food labelling in India?

Food and beverage labelling in India is governed primarily by the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 (FSS Act) and its subordinate regulations. Dabur's use of the '100%' claims contravenes the FSS (Advertising & Claims) Regulations, 2018, as they are ambiguous, unverifiable and likely to mislead consumers. Product packaging provides the clearest evidence of misleading claims, making labelling violations among the most common enforcement actions by the FSSAI, according to industry experts. The FSSAI rules also do not allow functional or therapeutic claims like "boosts energy levels", or "enhancing focus". The FSSAI has initiated action against makers of energy drinks such as Sting, Campa Gold Boost, Red Bull, Adrenaline Rush and Hell over such claims.

MINT

3 Why has labelling become so important?

Labelling has emerged as a key competitive tool as health-focused products see rapid adoption. According to iDigitalStack, sales of protein bars, makhana, healthy chips, nuts and seeds doubled to ₹327.7 crore in Jan-Mar 2026 from ₹154 crore a year ago on quick commerce platforms. Redseer found that two in three millennials are willing to pay about a 15% premium for cleaner ready-to-eat and ready-to-cook products.

4 How are companies responding?

Companies are either revising packaging or challenging the regulator in court. In May, clean-label brand The Whole Truth replaced its "no added sugar" claim with "sweetened with dates" following an FSSAI notice. Reports indicate energy drinks like PepsiCo's Sting are updating labels to avoid health claims. On Thursday, Dabur moved the Delhi High Court seeking an urgent hearing against the latest FSSAI ban. After the 3 August ban, Dabur said that it had already initiated transitioning of the product labels as mentioned in the FSSAI letter to new labels without the 100% claim.

5 What are the labelling standards globally?

The EU and several Latin American countries are considered global leaders in food labelling and consumer disclosure. The EU enforces some of the world's strictest food safety standards, including tighter limits on pesticide residues. Where a pesticide is not specifically approved, a default residue limit of 0.01 mg/kg applies. The bloc has also withdrawn approvals for certain food additives and closely regulates food colourings. Latin America has emerged as a global leader in front-of-pack warning labels, designed to combat obesity and non-communicable diseases.

LIC flags stress on customer incomes

The warning comes even as LIC delivered strong profitability

Samridhi Mahar
samridhi.mahar@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Life Insurance Corp. of India Ltd (LIC) delivered stronger profitability in the June quarter, but the country's largest insurer warned that shrinking household disposable incomes continue to weigh on premium growth.

"We depend on the disposable income of the customers, and when that income gets impacted, there will be an impact certainly on the way people save," chief executive and managing director R. Doraiswamy said at a post-earnings briefing on Thursday.

He said the impact was already visible in LIC's growth numbers, with businesses linked to interest rates and financial markets, including unit-linked plans and annuities, remaining the most exposed to the fallout from the West Asia conflict.

"Though the numbers are good this quarter, if you look at the growth in premium or the APE, it is not that high what you would have expected," he said, adding that it was too early to say whether the worst had passed.

Total premium income for the April-June quarter (QFY27) rose 6.75% to ₹1.27 trillion. Individual business premium increased 5.52% to ₹75,416 crore, while group business premium rose 8.61% to ₹51,834 crore. Individual policies sold grew 2.06% to 3.10 million, annualized premium equivalent (APE) rose 8.22% to



Management said the pressure is concentrated in LIC's savings business, where persistency has remained broadly range-bound for many quarters.

₹13,692 crore, and profit after tax climbed 22.81% to ₹13,492 crore. Management said the pressure is concentrated in LIC's savings business, where persistency has remained broadly range-bound for several quarters despite repeated

remained modest, profitability improved sharply as LIC continued to shift towards higher-margin products.

Value of new business (VNB) rose 61.32% to ₹3,136 crore in Q1, while the net VNB margin expanded 750 basis points to 22.9% from 15.4% a year earlier.

Doraiswamy attributed the improvement entirely to product mix.

"The growth has been on those product buckets which have a higher VNB margin. The growth has been muted in some areas which are not that value accretive," he said, pointing to both non-par protection and non-participating (non-par) savings.

COVER STORY

LIC warned that shrinking household disposable incomes continue to weigh on premium growth

THE country's largest insurer's profit after tax climbed 22.81% to ₹13,492 crore in Q1

LIC's total premium income for the April-June quarter increased 6.75% to ₹1.27 trillion

renewal efforts. The longer-tenure cohorts continue to face the greatest pressure.

"We have been a strong savings player, and hence any pressure that we feel is on the savings portfolio only," Doraiswamy said.

Even as premium growth

Tata Sons IPO cloud stays; RBI examines plea for de-registration

FROM PAGE 1

status quo for Tata Sons. Since its application for deregistration as an NBFC is still under examination, the company will continue to be treated as an upper layer NBFC and comply with the applicable regulatory requirements until the RBI takes a final decision," said Abizer Diwanji, founder at NeoStrat Advisors.

Diwanji said the five-year continuity provision in the revised framework applies to NBFCs that no longer meet the asset-based criteria, whereas Tata Sons is a separate case because it is seeking deregistration.

"The intent behind the RBI's revised framework was to ensure that entities such as Tata Sons, which voluntarily seek de-registration as a CIC, are not required to continue complying with the enhanced upper layer regulatory requirements for the next five years," said Prakash Agarwal, partner at Gefion Capital.

"The deregistration process



The upper layer forms part of the RBI's scale-based regulation framework, which classifies NBFCs into four tiers.

deregistration as an NBFC rather than merely falling below the threshold, the five-year continuity provision underscores the RBI's preference for regulatory continuity.

The upper layer forms part of the central bank's scale-based regulation framework, which classifies NBFCs into four tiers—base, middle, upper

and top—based on their size, activity and systemic importance. The top layer is intended to remain empty unless the RBI identifies extraordinary systemic risks.

NBFCs with an asset size of ₹1 trillion or more, based on their latest audited balance sheet, are classified in the upper layer and become subject to enhanced regulatory requirements. One of the key requirements is mandatory listing on stock exchanges within the timelines prescribed by the RBI.

Tata Sons had standalone assets of ₹2.01 trillion at the end of March 2026. Its listing now hinges on whether the RBI accepts its application to surrender its CIC registration, which the company has already submitted.

A core investment company is a non-bank whose business is to acquire shares and securities, and hold at least 90% of its net assets in the form of investment in equity shares, preference shares, bonds, debentures, debt or loans in group companies.

The latest upper-layer list comprises 17 NBFCs, including REC Ltd, Power Finance Corp. Ltd, Indian Railway Finance Corp. Ltd, Bajaj Finance, Shriram Finance, LIC Housing Finance, Cholamandalam Investment and Finance, Tata Capital, Tata Sons, Muthoot Finance, Aditya Birla Capital, Housing and

Urban Development Corp., Mahindra & Mahindra Financial Services, L&T Finance, Bajaj Housing Finance, HDB Financial Services, and Piramal Finance.

Among them, Tata Sons is the only unlisted company.

The central bank also said PNB Housing Finance and Sammaan Capital, which no longer meet the revised identification criteria, will continue to remain in the upper layer because the framework requires NBFCs to stay under the enhanced regulatory regime for at least five years after classification.

PNB Housing Finance's standalone assets were at ₹93,533 crore and that of Sammaan Capital's was at ₹71,124 crore at the end of March 2026.

The regulator did not issue an upper-layer list for FY26 while reviewing the identification criteria.

The FY27 list has now been prepared under the revised framework using financials as of 31 March 2026.

The RBI governor indicated that Tata Sons could continue to feature on the revised upper-layer list

JSW Steel and Tata Steel choose different growth paths

FROM PAGE 1

By comparison, Tata Steel has a capacity target of 40 mt from a domestic capacity of 27.4 mt. Initially, the guidance was to reach this target by 2030, the company is now not in a hurry to increase capacity. "At some point in time in the future, the downstream volume can be bigger than upstream. I can always buy upstream from someone else," Narendran had told *Mint* in an earlier interview.

In the steel industry, upstream refers to the production of primary steel and downstream involves processing this primary steel into higher-value, ready-to-use products such as precision tubes, specialty steel wires, and coated sheets for use in automobiles, construction, infrastructure and agriculture.

Tata Steel is unlikely to see a significant increase in steel volumes before 2031, when the 4.8 mtpa expansion at its Neelachal Ispat Nigam Ltd unit is to be commissioned.

Tata Steel, to be sure, has the option to expand capacity to 65 mt—Narendran said earlier that it is in talks with the Maharashtra government for around 3,000 acres land in Gadchiroli that could support a 15-million-tonnes expansion.

Separately, the CEO is of the view that in the domestic market, Tata Steel wants to fly solo rather than in partnerships, as India's steel demand grows at a steady pace.

However, not all analysts are convinced by that approach.

"Steel remains a scale business. Companies first need to build upstream capacity and then add downstream capabilities," said Sumangal Nevatia,



Tata Steel is prioritizing expanding its portfolio of downstream products such as precision tubes, specialty steel wires.

director at brokerage Kotak Institutional Equities. "Tata Steel has traditionally grown both together, but this time, its upstream expansion is progressing more slowly."

JSW Steel has outperformed both Tata Steel and the

benchmark Sensex this year, with its shares gaining 12.28% from the beginning of the year versus Tata Steel's 6.22% rise and the Sensex's 7.60% loss.

Nevatia pointed out that expansion at both ends of the value chain can be pursued

with a strong balance sheet like JSW Steel and Jindal Steel are doing. Jindal Steel, India's no. 5 ranked steel maker by capacity, is controlled by Naveen Jindal, Sajjan's younger brother.

Nevatia added a nuance:

what appears to be contrasting strategies is, to some extent, "a matter of communication," he said, implying that there was a larger divergence in the narrative set by the two companies around rather than underlying strategies.

Analysts at Jefferies, too, were sceptical of the Tata Steel strategy. "Tata's focus has shifted from primary steel expansion to downstream, although we are unconvinced

that the latter requires de-prioritizing the former," analysts Sagar Sahu and Nitij Mangal wrote in a 2 August report.

Analysts also attribute JSW Steel's aggressive expansion to the financial strength it gained from its stake sale of Bhushan

Power & Steel, announced last December, netting it nearly ₹24,500 crore.

Equirus analysts Siddharth Gadekar and Shivansh Singh back JSW's strategy. In a 19 July note, they said the company "offers the strongest medium-term volume growth visibility within our coverage universe," supported by its expansion pipeline, growing value-added products portfolio and continued cost optimization.

JSW Steel aims to raise steelmaking capacity through brownfield and greenfield expansions and joint ventures

MOVES

A weekly list of C-Suiters who have moved up the corporate ladder either within or outside their companies.

Akshay Murthy	Appointed as vice president and country head, India at Darwinbox
Anjali Byce	Appointed as chief human resources officer at Suzlon
Arindam Chakraborty	Appointed as chief human resources officer at Saatvik Solar
Chetan Naik	Appointed as managing director at L Catterton
Dr Uday Harle	Appointed as chief executive officer at Shilpa Biologicals
Dr Vikas Gupta	Appointed as managing director and chief executive officer at Novartis India
Harsha Subramaniam	Appointed as regional director, South Asia at BBC
Kavita Kulkarni	Appointed as chief technology and operations officer, India and South Asia at Standard Chartered Bank
Kirtiraj Jilkar	Appointed as managing director and chief executive officer at ANDRITZ Technologies India
Mohit Dhingra	Appointed as chief executive officer and president, India at CIBC
Nandita Sinha	Appointed as chief executive officer at Instamart (Swiggy)
Narottam Sharma	Appointed as chief transformation officer at Tata Communications
Navin Nathani	Appointed as group director, IT and group chief information officer at Allana Group
Nikunj Nangalia	Appointed as chief executive officer, biofuels at Hindustan Power
Nitin Chengappa	Appointed as head of wealth management, India at DBS Bank India
Pradeep Prabhala	Appointed as senior managing director and lead, India market unit at Accenture
Rajiv Kumar	Appointed as chief operating officer at Jindal Steel
Sabyasachi Bandyopadhyay	Appointed as chief executive officer at Amalgam Steel
Sarabjeet Singh Gujral	Appointed as chief human resources officer at Varun Beverages
Shekhar Srinivasan	Appointed as managing director, India at Eurofragance
Siddharth Rastogi	Appointed as managing director, India at Roquette
Sreenivasulu Bandaru	Appointed as vice president, head of chemical development at Syngene
Sukumar Hebbar	Appointed as managing director and chief executive officer at Projects
Viswanath P.S.	Appointed as managing director, India at HeadFirst Global

Source: Accord India, executive search worldwide

Metropolis speeds up tier-II, III push

Jessica Jani
jessica.jani@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Diagnostics major Metropolis Healthcare is accelerating its expansion into India's tier-II and tier-III markets, capitalizing on a multi-year investment push designed to capture a growing shift toward organized healthcare.

The strategy is already showing results: about 27-28% of its business now comes from tier-III towns and beyond, markets that are growing at about 25-26%, significantly above its overall growth rate.

"The tier-III expansion and the outcome that you are seeing is a result of a very long journey. We have been investing in tier-II and tier-III towns for the past two to three years, knowing that they will definitely start turning towards the organized operators," managing director Surendran Chemmenkotil said in an interview. The company

has added 70-75 labs in smaller towns in the past three years, he added. Rivals such as Dr Lal PathLabs have also been making inroads in tier-III markets over the past few years.

Executive chairperson Ameera Shah said the entry of organized players is not just taking market share away from unorganized providers, but actively creating new demand for specialized diagnostic testing in smaller towns.

"We are creating the market when we go into tier-II and tier-III towns," Shah said. "We are educating doctors about tests they may not know about."

Those samples naturally come back to organized players because local laboratories don't have the capability to perform these tests. "In a previous interview, Chemmenkotil had told *Mint* that the firm employs a micro-market pricing strategy with market-relevant pricing in different regions.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

About 27-28% of Metropolis Healthcare's business now comes from tier-III towns and beyond

**SULA VINEYARDS LIMITED**

Registered Office: 201 A, Solaris One, N.S. Phadke Marg Andheri (E), Mumbai, Maharashtra, India – 400069
Tel: 022-6128 0606/607 Email: info@sulavines.com CIN: L15549MH2003PLC139352

STATEMENT OF UNAUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30TH JUNE, 2026

The Board of Directors of the Company at their meeting held on 6th August, 2026, approved the unaudited Standalone & Consolidated Financial Results of the Company for the quarter ended 30th June, 2026.

The full Financial Results along with the limited review report are available on stock exchanges and are posted on the Company's website at <https://sulavineyards.com/investor-relations.php> and can also be accessed by scanning the QR Code.

Place: Mumbai

Date: 6th August, 2026

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors

Sd/-

Rajeev Samant

CEO and Managing Director

DIN: 00020675

Note: The above intimation is in accordance with Reg. 33 read with Reg.47(1) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015

**Introducing
mint Portfolio****A Smarter way to
analyse your investments**

Track all your
wealth in one place

Insights on which
funds to hold/exit

Free one on one call
with a wealth expert



IRCON INTERNATIONAL LIMITED
NAV RATNA COMPANY
(A Govt. of India Undertaking)
Website: www.ircon.org CIN: L45203DL1976GOI008171

e-Procurement Notice
e-Tender No.: IRCON/e-Tender/JBRPL/2051/Civil Works/ Dated 06.08.2026
Construction of Formation, Blanketing, Minor Bridges, and other ancillary works from
Ch: Km 8.00 (Nepal Custom Yard, Nepal) to 18.600 (Biratnagar Nepal) in connection with
construction of new BG Rail Line from Jogbani (India) to Biratnagar (Nepal) Railway project.

Estimated cost of the work: Rs. 22.85 Crore
Last Date & Time of e-Bid Submission: 31/08/2026 up to 3:00PM

For further details, visit website <https://etenders.gov.in/procure/app>. Corrigendum, if any,
would be hosted only on the website. Executive Director/Projects,
C-4, District Centre, Saket, New Delhi- 110017

Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation
Tender No: 3/2026-27

Publication of Notice for Request for Proposal (RFP)**for
Selection of Agencies for carrying out Road and Footpath
Manual Sweeping in all zones of Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal
Corporation**

Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation (PCMC) is the municipal body that governs the neighborhood of Pimpri Chinchwad, north-western city limits of Pune. Through this notice PCMC invites proposal from suitable entities (hereafter called "agency") for carrying out Road and Footpath Manual Sweeping in all zones of Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation.

Interested participants are advised to study this RFP document carefully before submitting their proposals in response to this Tender Notice. Submission of a proposal in response to this notice shall be deemed to have been carried out after careful study and examination of this document with full understanding of its terms, conditions, and implications.

Interested participants are requested to download the RFP document published on www.mahatenders.gov.in from 07/08/2026. The last date for proposal submission is 31/08/2026 by 3:00 PM. For any type of clarifications, Bidders can visit www.mahatenders.gov.in or contact help desk contact no. 0120-4001 462, 0120-4001 002, 0120-4001 005, 0120-6277 787, Email: support-eproc@nic.in

Name of Work	Estimate Tender Amount	Tender Fees (Non-Refundable)	EMD
Selection of agencies for carrying out Road and Footpath Manual Sweeping in all zones of Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation	1. Zone A - Rs. 42.42 Cr. 2. Zone B - Rs. 30.58 Cr. 3. Zone C - Rs. 57.26 Cr. 4. Zone D - Rs. 50.86 Cr. 5. Zone E - Rs. 63.24 Cr. 6. Zone F - Rs. 62.65 Cr. 7. Zone G - Rs. 28.16 Cr. 8. Zone H - Rs. 33.78 Cr. 9. Zone J - Rs. 90.84 Cr. 10. Zone L - Rs. 81.34 Cr.	1. Zone A - Rs. 37,430 2. Zone B - Rs. 37,430 3. Zone C - Rs. 74,704 4. Zone D - Rs. 74,704 5. Zone E - Rs. 74,704 6. Zone F - Rs. 74,704 7. Zone G - Rs. 37,430 8. Zone H - Rs. 37,430 9. Zone J - Rs. 74,704 10. Zone L - Rs. 74,704	1. Zone A - Rs. 4242566 2. Zone B - Rs. 3058780 3. Zone C - Rs. 5726137 4. Zone D - Rs. 5086058 5. Zone E - Rs. 6324122 6. Zone F - Rs. 6265969 7. Zone G - Rs. 2816729 8. Zone H - Rs. 3378437 9. Zone J - Rs. 9084416 10. Zone L - Rs. 8134607

Tender No	3/2026-27
Duration of Contract	5 years (which may be extended at the sole discretion of Municipal Commissioner upon mutually agreed terms and conditions)
Tender document availability	Available on Website: www.mahatenders.gov.in
E-Tender available period	From 07/08/2026 to 31/08/2026
Last date and time for submission of bids	Date: 31/08/2026 Time: 15.00 PM
Last Date of Submission of Pre- Bid Queries	Date: 14/08/2026 up to Time: 12.00 PM (As per Annexure 11: Format for pre-bid queries)
Pre-bid meeting date and time	Date: 14/08/2026 Time: 12.00 PM
Pre-bid venue	Dy. Commissioner, Health Department, 2 nd Floor, Main Building, PCMC
Tender opening date	Date: 01/09/2026 Time: 15.00 PM (If possible)
Bid Submission Mode	Online submission on www.mahatender.gov.in
Method of Selection	Least Cost Selection (LCS)
Validity of bids	180 days from bid submission due date
Validity of EMD	180 days from bid submission due date
Bid Language	English
JV / Consortium	Not Allowed
Currency	Indian National Rupees (INR)
Nodal Officer	Deputy Commissioner, Health Department, Second Floor, Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation, Pimpri, Pune 411018 E-mail: healthho@pcmcindia.gov.in

Commissioner, PCMC, reserves the right to reject any or all applications without assigning any reasons thereof. In this regard his decision will be final and legally binding on all the Bidders.

SD/-

Commissioner
Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation
Pimpri - 411 018

ADVT No. - 2026-27/104

ElH Limited**A MEMBER OF THE OBEROI GROUP**

CIN: L55101WB1949PLC017981

Registered Office: N-806-A, 8th Floor, Diamond Heritage Building, 16, Strand Road Fairley Place, Kolkata – 700 001, India
Phone : 91-33-22486751 Fax: 91-33-22486785 Website: www.eihltd.com E-mail ID: isdho@oberoigroup.com

**EXTRACT OF STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL RESULTS
FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30TH JUNE 2026**

(Rs. in Crores)						
	Standalone		Consolidated			
	3 months ended 30.06.2026 UNAUDITED	Year ended 31.03.2026 AUDITED	3 months ended 30.06.2025 UNAUDITED	3 months ended 30.06.2026 UNAUDITED	Year ended 31.03.2026 AUDITED	3 months ended 30.06.2025 UNAUDITED
1 Total Income from operations	658.00	2,812.49	571.12	697.94	3,105.74	609.06
2 Net Profit/(Loss) before tax (before Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	169.72	918.66	159.44	169.31	1,080.79	164.67
3 Net Profit/(Loss) before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	169.72	787.66	49.12	169.31	948.71	54.18
4 Net Profit/(Loss) after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	127.09	538.51	36.36	120.31	657.29	36.88
5 Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	126.88	537.29	36.50	119.27	752.95	52.35
6 Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face Value - Rs. 2 each)	125.07	125.07	125.07	125.07	125.07	125.07
7 Other Equity (excluding Revaluation Reserve) in the audited Balance Sheet as at 31 March 2026	4,563.61		5,137.21			
8 Earnings per Equity Share on net profit after tax (fully paid up equity share of Rs. 2 each):						
(a) Basic	2.03	8.61	0.58	1.87	10.05	0.54
(b) Diluted	2.03	8.61	0.58	1.87	10.05	0.54

NOTES:

- The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Statement of Financial Results is available on the Stock Exchange websites, www.bseindia.com, www.nseindia.com and on the Company's website, www.eihltd.com. The same can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided alongside.
- The above financial results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at the meetings held on 6th August 2026. The statutory auditors have carried out a limited review of these financial results.



VIKRAMJIT SINGH OBEROI
Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer
(DIN: 00052014)

Delhi
6th August 2026

**EXTRACT OF THE FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30TH JUNE 2026**

(₹ in Crore)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Standalone		Consolidated		
		Quarter ended		Quarter ended		Year ended
		30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	30.06.2025 (Unaudited)	30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	30.06.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1	Total Income for the period	11,370.04	11,256.88	46,995.88	11,696.72	11,444.42
2	Profit before Tax and Regulatory Deferral Account Balances	4,246.32	4,172.27	16,759.10	4,587.32	4,285.75
3	Net Profit after Tax for the period	3,410.95	3,653.23	15,921.00	3,598.42	3,630.58
4	Total Comprehensive Income comprising Net Profit after Tax and Other Comprehensive Income	3,451.02	3,842.94	16,066.78	3,527.21	3,821.34
5	Paid up Equity Share Capital (Face value of share : ₹10/- each)	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60
6	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Balance sheet	94,091.13	86,757.99	90,629.01	94,727.70	87,181.37
7	Securities Premium Account	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28
8	Net worth	1,03,391.73	96,058.59	99,928.61	1,04,028.30	96,481.97
9	Total Borrowings	1,45,586.45	1,30,645.77	1,48,009.01	1,45,586.45	1,30,645.77
10	Debt Equity Ratio	1.41	1.36	1.48	1.40	1.35
11	Earnings per equity share including movement in Regulatory Deferral Account Balances (Face value of ₹10/- each): Basic and Diluted (in ₹) *	3.67	3.93	17.12	3.87	3.90
12	Earnings per equity share excluding movement in Regulatory Deferral Account Balances (Face value of ₹10/- each): Basic and Diluted (in ₹) *	3.78	3.70	20.15	3.98	3.67
13	Bonds Redemption Reserve	2,573.82	3,032.86	2,721.31	2,573.82	3,032.86
14	Debt Service Coverage Ratio	1.36	1.04	1.54	1.46	1.06
15	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	3.52	4.00	3.93	4.32	4.64

(*) Figures for the quarters have not been annualized

Notes:

- The above is an extract of the Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulations 33 and 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The Complete Financial Results are available on the Investors section of our website <https://www.powergrid.in> and under Corporates Section of BSE Limited & National Stock Exchange of India Limited at <https://www.bseindia.com> and <https://www.nseindia.com> respectively. These can also be accessed by scanning Quick Response Code:
- Previous periods figures have been rearranged/reclassified wherever considered necessary.



Place: New Delhi
Date: 05 August, 2026



POWER GRID CORPORATION OF INDIA LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)
Corp. Office: Saudamini, Plot No.2, Sector-29, Gurugram -122 001 (Haryana) Tel.: 0124-2571700-719
Reg. Office: B-9, Qutab Institutional Area, Katwaria Sarai, New Delhi 110 016 Tel.: 011-26560112, 26560121 CIN : L40101DL1989GOI038121

A Maharatna PSU

For and on behalf of POWER GRID CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.
Sd/-
Dr. Yatindra Dwivedi, Director (Finance)
DIN: 10301390



Have fun with facts on Sundays



Catch the latest column of



A quiz on the week's development.





Regulator bets on tech, simpler rules

Apoorva Ajith

apoorva.ajith@livemint.com
MUMBAI

India's markets regulator will focus on simplifying regulations, easing compliance, deepening capital markets and expanding the use of technology in supervision in FY27, chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said in the Securities and Exchange Board of India's (Sebi) annual report for the year ended March.

"In the coming year, Sebi will continue to focus on identifying and removing regulatory redundancies, simplifying procedural requirements and leveraging technology to ease the compliance burden," Pandey said on Thursday.

Sebi will introduce a fast-track mechanism for launching alternative investment fund (AIF) schemes and establish a single-window clearance system for intermediaries operating across multiple market infrastructure institu-



The markets regulator also plans to launch the Sebi Setu portal and revamp the Securities Lending and Borrowing Scheme. REUTERS

tions.

The regulator plans to launch the Sebi Setu portal to streamline interface with market intermediaries. It will also revamp the Securities Lending and Borrowing Scheme to boost price discovery and strengthen the link between cash and derivatives markets.

Pandey said work will continue on growing the com-

modity markets, and Sebi will also start a pilot to tokenize corporate bonds using distributed ledger technology.

Investor education will remain a priority. Project Jagrook, launched this year, will bring together Sebi, market institutions, the Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi) and the National Institute of Securities Markets (NISM) for

this aim.

The regulator also plans to boost its capabilities to keep pace with increasingly sophisticated markets. It has expanded employee training in areas including data analytics, surveillance and technology. Sebi officials are actively engaging with peer regulators and global bodies for exposure to global best practices, Pandey said.

For capacity-building, Sebi will expand its regional presence by opening more local offices to improve investor outreach, strengthen monitoring of unregulated activities and gather market intelligence.

The regulator is also investing in technology. It launched the Single Universal Platform for Communications to speed up interactions with external entities and an e-adjudication portal to digitize quasi-judicial proceedings. AI is being used to help detect market manipulation and fraud.

Omnivore to back deep science, consumer bets

Co-founder says company positioning itself for next investment cycle

Rwit Ghosh

rwit.ghosh@livemint.com
BENGALURU

Impact investment-focused venture capital firm Omnivore plans to deploy most of the remaining capital from its ₹1,800-crore Fund III into deep science and consumer brands over the next year, as it positions itself for the next investment cycle, managing partner and co-founder Mark Kahn said.

"I would say most of our remaining investments will be in deep science and consumer brands as we're looking to be done deploying by the middle of 2027," Kahn said in an interview with *Mint*.

The deployment comes at a time when demand for high-protein foods is rising and investor interest in deeptech, particularly drones, robotics and physical AI, is accelerating globally.

The firm has deployed about 55% of Fund III, and is expected to finish deploying the balance 45% by H1 of 2027.

Average cheque sizes from Fund III range between ₹30 crore and ₹80 crore, with most investments targeted at Series A companies and select pre-Series A bets.

While this is not a fundamental pivot for Omnivore, whose investment thesis remains centred on agriculture, it signals where the firm expects its next wave of returns to emerge.

Consumer investing has never been a core strategy for Omnivore. Even today, the firm has only three consumer brands in its portfolio. "We're not fundamentally a consumer investor. We're an investor that focuses on agrifood systems in India," Kahn said.

The firm's first consumer investment came in 2020, when it wrote a \$2 million seed cheque to healthy snacking brand Farmley. Omnivore remains invested and also participated in the company's \$40 million Series C round led by L Catterton.

In 2024, the firm, alongside the Narotam Sekhsaria Family Office, invested \$10 million in the Series A round of direct-to-consumer dairy brand Sid's Farm. This



Mark Kahn, managing partner and co-founder, Omnivore.

year, it doubled down by leading the startup's \$8.4-million pre-Series B funding round alongside new and existing investors.

In 2026, Omnivore also led craft chocolate brand Manam Chocolate's \$9 million Series A round with participation from the Turner Morrisson consortium.

Although these investments have been spread over several years, Kahn said the

extends to adjacent sectors. In July, Omnivore and Edelweiss Alternative Asset Advisors co-led specialty food and nutraceutical ingredients startup Arboreal Bio-innovations' ₹230-crore (around \$24 million) Series A round.

Omnivore has been an investor in IP-led startups focused on companies building in the life sciences as well as those that can create impact for farmers through robotics.

It has previously invested in companies like Loopworm, Pixxel, Niqo Robotics, Varaha, and Intello Labs.

The firm is doubling down on the category as physical AI, robotics and automation see a sharp uptick in investor and founder interest globally. Two of Omnivore's portfolio companies in the sector have found themselves well-poised to take advantage of the swing, especially in markets outside India.

"This is kind of the year of physical AI, and we're seeing it across multiple portfolio companies," Kahn said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Sebi sees fall in appeals, settlements in FY26

Apoorva Ajith

apoorva.ajith@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Appeals against Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) orders before the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) fell to 429 in FY26 from 533 a year ago, according to Sebi's annual report for the fiscal year.

In the same period, Sebi's settlement collection plunged to ₹109.8 crore from ₹798.9 crore in FY25. The decline in settlement collections coincided with a lower number of settlement applications—439, down from 703.

The report also showed a moderation in appellate activity, but the overall litigation pipeline remained elevated.

Appeals dismissed by the SAT fell to 135 from 308. At the same time, the number of Sebi orders upheld with modifications rose to 88 from 42. Pending appeals before the SAT increased to 1,066 as of March end 2026, up from 960 a year ago, suggesting that while fresh filings slowed, the tribunal continued to face a growing backlog.

Sebi took up fewer insider trading investigations during the year. The regulator initiated work on 221 insider trading cases in FY26, down from 287 in FY25. However, it completed more investigations, closing 202 cases

compared with 192 a year ago, indicating improved disposal despite fewer fresh matters.

Investigation into suspected price and volume manipulation moved in the opposite direction. Sebi took up 72 such cases in FY26, up from 61 in FY25.

Front-running investigations edged higher, with 49 cases taken up compared with 44 a year ago

Front-running probes also edged higher, with 49 cases last fiscal compared with 44 a year ago. It also initiated two takeover-related cases, completing one, after reporting no activity in this category in FY25.

Adjudication activity, however slowed. Fresh adjudication proceedings fell to 135 in FY26 from 204 a year earlier,

while disposal orders declined to 319 from 962.

According to the report, Sebi completed adjudication proceedings involving 640 entities through these 319 orders. No monetary penalty was imposed on 123 entities, while 46 entities opted for settlement. In comparison, Sebi completed 1,293 adjudication proceedings in FY25.

The report also highlighted a mixed trend in court litigation. Cases pending before the Supreme Court, excluding recovery-related matters, increased to 539 as of 31 March 2026, from 520 a year ago. During the year, 73 new cases were filed, and 54 were disposed of.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

EMERGING THEMES

OMNIVORE'S consumer-focused investments are aimed at benefiting farmers directly

THE VC is doubling down on deep science, including robotics, physical AI and life sciences

INDIA'S deeptech market is likely to grow from \$9-12 bn in 2025 to \$27-33 bn within five years



CROSSING BORDERS

ISSUE OUT TOMORROW

Pakistan looms large in the Indian cultural imagination as perennial antagonist, but also as a landscape of memory, loss and reconciliation



THINK: The rise and fall of Batanagar, a company town

TASTE: It's travel that brings flavours to life

SPORTS: Commonwealth victories fuel India's Olympic dream

CULTURE: Charli XCX's latest is mood board art

Missing corp filings signal compliance woes, stress

FROM PAGE 1

(22.9%) to 662,349 (37.5%) over the same period.

The parliamentary reply also exposed a striking enforcement gap. While more than 664,000 companies failed to file annual returns in FY25, action was initiated against only 277 companies for such violations. Similarly, only 291 of more than 662,000 companies faced action for failing to file financial statements.

"Annual returns and financial statements are the primary mechanism by which the MCA (ministry of corporate affairs) gathers data that becomes public record about a company's shareholding, management and financial position. Large-scale non-filing degrades the reliability of this public record for parties conducting due diligence, credit assessment or KYC," said Jay Parikh, partner at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas.

Mint's queries sent to the corporate affairs ministry remained unanswered.

The parliamentary reply does not explain the sharp rise in non-compliance, but legal experts say it is likely the result of several factors.

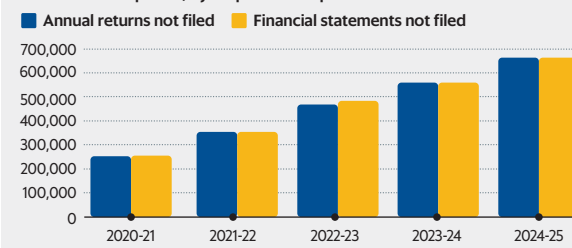
According to Anuj Trivedi, partner at Dentons Link Legal, the rise in the number of companies not undertaking statutory filings appears to be driven by increasing compliance obligations and financial constraints faced by smaller businesses, among other reasons.

"Limited compliance capacity among small businesses, frequent regulatory changes, portal-related issues, audit delays, and lack of awareness are key

Compliance lapse

Statutory filing compliance has deteriorated steadily over the past five years, even as the number of eligible companies has surged.

Number of companies, by corporate compliance



Based on Lok Sabha answer given on 20 July 2026.
Source: Corporate affairs ministry

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

factors behind delayed or missed statutory filings. Limited use of automated compliance tools further adds to the challenge," said Prasad Nakashe, partner at Deloitte India.

Under the Companies Act, 2013, businesses are required to file annual returns and financial statements every year with the ministry of corporate affairs, providing key information on their ownership, management and financial position.

Hardeep Sachdeva, senior partner at AZB & Partners, said compliance has become technology-driven and documentation-intensive, making it more difficult for smaller companies with limited governance infrastructure to keep up with filing requirements.

Lawyers said the ease-of-doing-business reforms have made company incorporation smoother, but annual compliance remains challenging, particularly for small businesses without dedicated legal or company secretarial support. "For firms that are financially stressed or being wound down informally, escalating late filing fees and penalties

can make catching up expensive and may discourage them from undertaking remedial actions," said Parikh.

Under the Companies Act, companies that file their annual returns or financial statements late must pay an additional fee of 100 for each day of delay, with no upper limit. If they continue to default and regulatory action is initiated, they may also face statutory penalties of up to ₹2 lakh for the company and up to ₹50,000 for each officer in default.

To improve compliance, Vijaykumar Puri, partner at chartered accountancy firm VPRP & Co LLP, recommended capping late filing fees, making it easier for inactive companies to obtain dormant status or exit, resuming large-scale strike-offs, increasing awareness of compliance schemes and strengthening enforcement.

Sudhir Bassi, executive director at Khaitan & Co, also suggested MCA should publish the names of persistent defaulters and conduct wider awareness campaigns to improve compliance. He also suggested that the Institute of Company Secretaries of India (ICSI) play a bigger role in educating companies through seminars and outreach programmes.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Bigger role for clearing corporations proposed

Apoorva Ajith

apoorva.ajith@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India has proposed sweeping changes to settlement and risk management rules, to hand more operational responsibility to clearing corporations, eliminate outdated norms and reduce compliance and reporting requirements for market infrastructure institutions (MIIs).

A Sebi consultation paper seeks to make it easier for stock exchanges and clearing corporations to operate by updating master circulars governing settlement and risk management. The proposals are part of Sebi's fifth consultation paper on the regulatory framework for exchanges and clearing corporations.

Among the biggest changes is a proposal to make clearing corporations solely responsible for monitoring pay-in shortages and collecting penalties. Now, these responsibilities are split between stock exchanges and clearing corporations, even though clearing corporations have complete visibility of settlement shortfalls. Sebi has also proposed replacing the penalty thresholds linked to a broker's base minimum capital with fixed monetary limits or a percentage of net worth, making it easier to administer.

The regulator also proposed replacing references to stock exchanges with clearing corporations in provisions on margin reporting, shortfall monitoring and penalty collection, reflecting the current division of responsibilities.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

**CAMPUS**

BUILT FOR SUSTAINABLE GROWTH

MOVE YOUR WAY



Campus Activewear Limited
CIN: L74120DL2008PLC183629

STATEMENT OF UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30 JUNE 2026

(All amounts are in INR crores except per share data or as otherwise stated)

S. No.	Particulars	For the quarter ended 30 June 2026	For the quarter ended 31 March 2026	For the quarter ended 30 June 2025	For the year ended 31 March 2026
		Unaudited	Audited	Unaudited	Audited
1	Total income from operations	393.24	461.68	349.41	1,796.96
2	Net profit for the period (before tax, exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	35.29	58.78	30.38	202.17
3	Net profit for the period before tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	35.29	58.78	30.38	202.17
4	Net profit for the period after tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	26.14	44.14	22.20	150.09
5	Total comprehensive Income for the period [comprising profit for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive Income (after tax)]	25.79	44.36	22.17	150.36
6	Equity Share Capital (face value of INR 5 each)	152.83	152.80	152.73	152.80
7	Reserves (excluding revaluation reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year				753.45
8	Earnings Per Share (face value of INR 5 each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)*				
	1. Basic (INR):	0.86	1.44	0.73	4.91
	2. Diluted (INR):	0.86	1.44	0.72	4.91

*Basic and Diluted EPS is not annualised except for yearly figures.

See accompanying notes to the financial results.

Notes:

1 The above financial results of the Company as published in accordance with Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended ('Listing Regulations') have been reviewed and recommended by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors in their respective meetings held on 6 August 2026. These financial results have been prepared in accordance with recognition and measurement principles of Indian Accounting Standards ("Ind AS") prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013, read with the relevant rules issued thereunder and the other accounting principles generally accepted in India. The Limited Review under Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, has been carried out by the statutory auditors of the company. The auditors have expressed an unmodified report on the Financial Results of the Company. For more details on results, visit investors section of our website at www.campusactivewear.com and Financial Results at Corporate Section of www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com.

2 Based on guiding principles given in Ind AS 108 "Operating Segments", the Company's business activity falls within a single operating segment namely "Footwear and its related products", hence the disclosure requirements relating to "Operating Segments" as per Ind AS 108 are not applicable.

3 During the previous year, the Company has changed its method of inventory valuation from First In First Out (FIFO) to Moving weighted average. The change was made to better reflect the consumption pattern and cost flow of inventory, and to enhance the relevance and reliability of financial information presented. In accordance with Ind AS 8, this change has been applied

retrospectively. The impact of this change in the current quarter and corresponding previous quarters/year is not material. Management believes that the new method provides a more accurate representation of inventory costs and aligns with industry practices.

4 The Company does not have any subsidiary/associate/joint venture company(ies), as at 30 June, 2026. Accordingly, the Company is not required to prepare consolidated financial results.

5 The figures for the quarter ended 31 March 2026, included in above statement, are the balancing figures between audited figures in respect of the full financial year up to 31 March 2026 and the unaudited published year to date figures up to 31 December 2025, being the end of the third quarter of the financial year which were subject to limited review.

6 The Board of Directors at its meeting held on 25 May 2026 has recommended a final dividend of Rs. 1.50 /- per equity share for the year ended 31 March 2026. The same is subject to shareholders' approval in the ensuing Annual General Meeting. The record date for such final dividend in accordance with Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 has now been fixed as 31 July 2026.

7 The Government of India has consolidated 29 existing labour legislations into a united framework comprising four Labour Code, viz. Code on wages 2019, Code on Social Security 2020, Industrial Relation Code 2020, and Occupational Safety, Health and Working Condition Code 2020 (collectively referred to as the New Labour Codes). These Codes have been made effective from 21 November, 2025. The Company has no material incremental liability for own employees under new labour code announced. The Company continues to monitor the clarifications from the Government on various aspects of the Labour Code and would provide appropriate accounting effect on the basis of such developments as needed.

Place: Gurugram
Date: 6 August 2026

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors of
Campus Activewear Limited
Sd/-
Hari Krishan Agarwal
Chairman and Managing Director
DIN: 00172467

Scan the QR code for the Financial Report



D-1, Udyog Nagar, Main Rohtak Road, New Delhi-110041, Delhi, India, Telephone: +91 11 4327 2500, Email: investors@campussshoes.com, Website: www.campusactivewear.com

Investing in the US isn't that difficult

Get expert insights, market analysis
and macro trends with

BARRON'S

Now exclusively available on **mint**

Subscribe now



It's not just oil the UAE has managed to ferry out, it has also been getting vital supplies of LNG to global customers. REUTERS

UAE continues to keep crude flowing to global markets

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

The United Arab Emirates (UAE) has moved more oil through the Strait of Hormuz than any other producer over the past two months, providing a much-needed buffer for global markets reeling from a historic energy crisis.

Supertanker Romania Prosperity appeared in the Gulf of Oman on Tuesday after switching off its transponder in late July, laden with crude from the UAE's Abu Dhabi National Oil Co., according to Kpler. It's one of dozens of such exits from the Persian Gulf as the state-run producer embarks on a novel marketing drive.

Individual ships spotted on ship-tracking databases give clues about the trade, but the real number is likely larger due to these dark crossings. Since the start of June, Adnoc has sold over 130 million barrels in an unprecedented seven tenders, according to traders familiar with the matter, asking not to be identified as they're not authorized to speak publicly.

That's equivalent to more than a month of crude demand from Japan, Asia's third-largest consumer.

Workarounds like Adnoc's have been vital to limiting losses from the conflict and have helped keep oil markets in check, countering expectations of far more acute shortages and price spikes.

The UAE has been so successful in getting its crude out of the Persian Gulf that Vortexa estimates it was the only Middle Eastern producer to reach pre-war levels of seaborne exports in June and July. Most of those barrels have been picked up by Asian refiners, including in Japan and China.

That milestone was achieved even after the US ramped up a bombing campaign against Iran last month, and the Islamic Republic attacked more ships around the strait. The practice of shutting barrels out of the gulf—dark crossings that supply waiting vessels outside Hormuz—has picked up again

after those strikes, people familiar with the matter said last week.

A comprehensive deal to reopen the strait—should one be reached—would likely boost the volume of oil leaving the Persian Gulf, but the stop-start nature of negotiations over recent months means analysts and traders expect shuttling to continue in some form.

An Adnoc spokesperson said the company doesn't comment on positions, movements or routing of its vessels as a matter of policy.

"Adnoc's barrels have helped stabilize supply into Asia," said June Goh, senior oil market analyst for Sparta Commodities SA. Refineries in the region can't easily replace the medium-sour crude that's typically produced in the Middle East, making any oil exiting the gulf so essential, she added.

It's not just oil the UAE has managed to ferry out successfully, the producer has also been getting vital supplies of

The UAE snapped up tankers at exorbitant rates to embark on daring shuttle runs through Hormuz

liquefied natural gas to global customers. An Adnoc tanker called the Mubarak loaded with LNG recently appeared near India after turning off its transponder inside the

gulf last month.

The UAE splurged on logistics to make its workaround possible. The nation snapped up tankers at exorbitant rates to embark on daring shuttle runs through Hormuz. Iraq and Kuwait have also been able to ferry out some supplies, but volumes have been smaller.

Once tankers carrying UAE crude exit Hormuz, the cargo is typically transferred to another vessel in the Gulf of Oman before being exported to buyers around the world. At times, this process has been delayed by escalating hostilities in the region.

The UAE has also been able to make use of a pipeline stretching across the country to get extra barrels out, bypassing Hormuz. Saudi Arabia has also kept large volumes of its crude flowing during the war by piping oil to its Red Sea port of Yanbu, allowing the kingdom to bypass Hormuz.

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

The wait for an Iran-Oman deal that partially reopens the Strait of Hormuz continued into Thursday, after the Islamic Republic said an agreement on proposed shipping lanes was in the final stages.

The two countries that border the crucial waterway have been negotiating a plan for the management of maritime traffic through the strait since last month. In recent days, Iran and the US have indicated a resolution is close.

"An understanding in principle has been reached on almost all the raised issues, including the map for maritime traffic entry and exit routes," Iran's Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said to the *Islamic Republic News Agency* on Wednesday.

The arrangement may remain valid for "two to four months," he added.

Yet, he cautioned a bilateral deal with Muscat "does not mean the full reopening of the Strait of Hormuz." Tehran has insisted the US is not part of the agreement with Oman and hinted that a normalization of the strait will depend on Washington lifting its blockade on Iranian ports.

US President Donald Trump repeated late Wednesday that a deal regarding the strait is imminent and that his administration is in contact with Iran. "We are talking. Let's see what happens," he said at a rally in Las Vegas.

The president has claimed diplomatic breakthroughs in the past, only for a lasting agreement to prove elusive.

The waiting pattern was reflected in oil markets, where prices swung between small gains and losses as traders assessed the likelihood of a speedy increase in oil flows from the Persian Gulf. Brent crude traded up 1% at \$80.21 a barrel on Thursday.

Any deal for the Strait of Hormuz



The deal on Hormuz may enable both sides to come to the negotiating table to address Iran's nuclear program... REUTERS

would have to be approved by Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei, who has been in hiding since being injured in the initial attacks of the war by the US and Israel, in February. It's unclear if he's given his consent yet

and Iranian officials have said that communicating with him takes time.

President Masoud Pezeshkian said in a televised interview on Wednesday that communication with Khamenei is "very difficult at the moment."

The developments follow months of deadlock between Washington and Tehran over how to conclude the war, with control over shipping a particular sticking point.

Tehran has demanded that vessels obtain its permission to cross and

possibly pay fees of some kind. It has continued to attack ships it deems to be in violation in recent weeks.

Fighting between the sides has largely paused for now, but a number of other issues remain unresolved.

The deal on Hormuz may enable them to get back to the negotiating table to address Iran's nuclear program.

Trump called off a new round of attacks on Iran over the weekend, which he said would have been the largest since World War II. *The Washington Post* reported that a shortage of key missiles and air-defense systems was among the reasons for the reversal.

According to the newspaper, Trump lashed out at Hegseth on the sidelines of a cabinet meeting last

Fighting between the sides has largely paused for now, but a number of other issues remain unresolved



Donald Trump is trying to exert greater influence over Fed. AP

Journal.

While the full nature of their conversations remains hazy, Trump has long implored the Fed to slash interest rates. Past presidents and Fed chairs have held calls and meetings, though they have been rare,

and Trump's drive to influence monetary policy has amounted to the most forceful intervention in the central bank's policy making in decades.

Trump routinely brushes away inflation concerns in calling for lower borrowing costs, but has taken a less combative approach since Warsh's confirmation.

In testimony to lawmakers last month, Warsh said Trump hasn't tried to interfere with the central bank but avoided directly answering questions about whether he's communicated with Trump since taking

the Fed's helm.

"I just don't want to be in the business of sharing discussions that the president and I have," Warsh said during a Senate Banking Committee hearing, while vowing to be "an independent guy."

"I certainly don't feel uncomfortable receiving a call from the chairman of this committee or the president of the

United States," Warsh said on

15 July.

Previous Fed chairs have issued press releases after meetings with the president. One example: in May 2025, then-Fed Chair Jerome Powell

2 Israeli soldiers killed in Lebanon

AP
feedback@livemint.com

Two Israeli soldiers were killed in an explosion in southern Lebanon, Israel's military said Thursday, the first Israeli deaths since a shaky truce between Israel and the Lebanese militant group Hezbollah began nearly two months ago.

Four other soldiers were seriously wounded, the military said. An Israeli military official, who spoke on condition of anonymity in accordance with the army's policy, said that "an explosion was detonated" when the soldiers entered a site in the village of Majdal Zoun and that the nature of the explosive was under review.

Israeli media reported the two deaths a day earlier.

The Israeli army launched strikes Wednesday in southern Lebanon in response to what it described as Hezbollah's violation of the ceasefire and called on residents of the village of Mansouri to flee—the first such warning Israel has issued in Lebanon for weeks.

Lebanon's Health Ministry said one person was killed and 12 wounded in an Israeli strike in the town of Tebnine Wednesday and another eight wounded in overnight strike.

Trump said to call Warsh in latest signal of push to remake Fed

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

US President Donald Trump has periodically spoken by phone with Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh since he took the role, people familiar with the matter said, the latest sign of Trump's effort to exert greater influence over the central bank.

Trump and Warsh have spoken multiple times since the latter was confirmed in May, with Trump inquiring about Warsh's forecasts and opinions but not pushing him to take any specific course of action, one of the people said, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss the private conversations. One person

said they speak irregularly, and another said their calls are infrequent. It's unclear if the two have discussed monetary policy.

"President Trump has repeatedly stressed that he is giving Chairman Warsh the space he needs to restore confidence and competence in Fed decision-making," White House spokesman Kush Desai said in an emailed statement. "While the President has his First Amendment right as an American citizen and duty as Commander in Chief to voice his thoughts about the Fed, he has also repeatedly reaffirmed Chairman Warsh and the Fed's independence."

The Fed declined to comment. The calls were first reported by the Wall Street

Google AI veterans depart during seismic leadership shift

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Investors Alphabet Inc.'s Google is losing some of its most prominent artificial intelligence veterans in a seismic overhaul that is casting doubt over leadership of a critical area of growth right as competition intensifies. Alphabet shares fell 4% on the news.

Jeff Dean, a longtime Google employee central to the development of the company's AI strategy, is departing to launch a startup, taking several high-profile colleagues with him. Demis Hassabis, the head of Google DeepMind, is moving into a chairman role at the lab.

In the new structure, Hassabis will assume the dual titles of chairman of Google DeepMind and chief scientist of Alphabet. He is handing over operational control of the lab

to Koray Kavukcuoglu, a longtime deputy, who has been promoted to senior vice president of Google DeepMind and will report to Alphabet CEO Sundar Pichai, the company announced Wednesday in a blog post.

For Google, staying at the forefront of the AI race is existential. The rapid advances in generative AI are introducing new ways for consumers to get answers to their questions, presenting real alternatives to Google search and potentially undercutting the company's advertising business.

The right talent is considered essential to succeeding in the AI race. Only a select few engineers in the world have extensive experience building complex, broad AI models. Historically, Google employed a bulk of them. The changes in leadership may make it harder for Google to recruit top talent and compete with rival labs.

Dean is bringing along at least three other prominent DeepMind employees to his new venture, including Sanjay Ghemawat, Quoc Le and Oriol Vinyals. The startup, called Discovery Loop, will automate machine learning research to improve its own technology. Google provided investment funding for Discovery Loop and signed a deal to supply the startup with cloud computing resources.

Google had already lost two prominent staffers earlier this year when Nobel laureate John Jumper left to Anthropic PBC and star researcher Noam Shazeer went to OpenAI. One staff member characterized Wednesday's departures of veteran staff as an earthquake for the organization. They declined to be named because they were not authorized to speak publicly.

Despite pouring tens of billions of dollars into AI infrastruc-



Despite pouring tens of billions of dollars into AI infrastructure and talent, Google has faced criticism for being slow. BLOOMBERG

ture and talent, Google has faced criticism that it has been too slow to turn its world-leading research into tangible progress in areas that matter commercially, like AI coding. The shakeup also comes as the flagship version of Google's latest Gemini model has faced a months-long delay, despite a

planned June launch.

Dean's departure could "intensify scrutiny" of the company's AI efforts, Bloomberg Intelligence analysts wrote in a note Wednesday.

The personnel changes, including Hassabis' move away from operational leadership and the departure of Dean

—one of Google's longest-serving and most influential AI leaders—represent the biggest reorganization of Google's AI efforts since the company combined its research teams under DeepMind in 2023.

Hassabis co-founded DeepMind, a pioneering artificial intelligence research lab that sold to Google in 2014.

"I've decided that now is the right time for me to hand over my day-to-day operational responsibilities at GDM, so that I have the time and space to focus on the big picture and help influence what is to come to the best of my ability," Hassabis said in a blog post.

A chess prodigy and neuroscientist, Hassabis is one of the most recognizable figures in AI. He reached global fame

after the virality of AlphaGo, DeepMind's algorithmic system that outmatched human champions in the ancient game of Go and demonstrated great leaps in machine learning capabilities.

Google placed Hassabis in charge of its AI efforts in 2023 after merging DeepMind, its London-based lab, with its research efforts based in California. Engineers at Google had helped develop the transformer architecture that powers chatbots like ChatGPT, but OpenAI beat the company to market with the technology, forcing Google to scramble to reset its AI strategy.

In 2024, Hassabis won the Nobel Prize in chemistry—along with DeepMind's

Jumper—for their work on AlphaFold, an AI system that can predict the structure of proteins.

In its blog post Wednesday, Google said that Hassabis will remain the head of Isomorphic Labs, an Alphabet division spun out of DeepMind that is focused on drug discovery. Since launching in 2021, Isomorphic Labs has formed partnerships with major pharmaceutical companies and recruited several DeepMind researchers.

While Hassabis is one of the most famous AI figures outside Google, Dean is perhaps a larger force inside the company. The computer scientist joined the search engine in 1999. After Pichai took over as Google CEO from co-founder Larry Page, Dean rose internally as one of Pichai's most reliable lieutenants, overseeing the company's search and AI divisions.

NEWS
NUMBERS

44,523

THE NUMBER of individuals currently staying in relief camps in Assam, as floods across 14 districts wreak havoc, impacting over 160,000 people.

22,149

THE NUMBER of US F-1 student visas issued to Indian nationals in 2025, down 62% from 2024, according to the Centre for Immigration Studies.

3,437

THE NUMBER of *Candida auris* cases detected across 27 US states as of 25 July, down by nearly 1,000 from 4,290 cases during the same period last year.

220

THE NUMBER of employees Etsy Inc. is laying off, representing 12% of its workforce, as part of a restructuring plan to improve operational efficiency.

\$116 mn

THE VALUE of Darnell Wright's four-year contract extension with the Chicago Bears, making him the highest-paid right tackle in National Football League history.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

OpenAI makes Indic languages a priority



For startups and venture capital, voice AI represents a massive opportunity in India. REUTERS

Artificial intelligence (AI) foundational model company OpenAI is now making Indic language performance and voice one of its top research priorities in India, according to Marc Manara, global head of

startups at the IPO-bound tech firm.

"Last year, we got so much feedback from founders on Indic language performance and voice specifically," Manara told *Mint* in an interview. "It's a big priority internally because we want to overcome this and it's important for our B2B customers and our consumer business." The focus on Indic voice comes as OpenAI works to expand its engagements with startups in India, which it counts among its most important.

The firm has also cut the cost of some of its models to woo more customers in what it considers to be one of the more mature and vibrant startup ecosystems worldwide.

For both startups and venture capital investors, voice AI is a massive opportunity in India, where spoken language remains the primary mode of communication. Industry experts bet that AI-driven voice will become the primary interface for how Indians interact with technology.

RWIT GHOSH



'Education, jobs, zero poverty core of Viksit Bharat'

Comprehensive healthcare, equipping youth with skills also part of vision, said Sitharaman

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Thursday outlined the government's vision for Viksit Bharat, or a developed economy, where there is zero poverty, universal access to quality education, affordable and comprehensive healthcare, and where every young person is equipped with skills and meaningful employment.

The minister underscored the need for women's full participation in economic activity and for farmers to make India the food basket of the world while delivering the C.D. Deshmukh Memorial Lecture at the 23rd India Policy Forum organized by the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER).

Calling for a partnership between generations, she said India's future hinges on combining the experience of older generations with the energy of younger Indians. "The older generation carries the wisdom and memory of this nation," she said, while the younger one "brings the energy, innovation and the leadership to execute the next phase. They are actually the people

who'll live in 2047 and beyond."

Reflecting on India's economic journey since Independence, Sitharaman said the country inherited Partition, widespread poverty, food insecurity and a weak industrial base. Also, successive wars, droughts and external dependence strained public finances during its early decades.

Playing the earlier centralized model and 'licence-quota-permit raj', the minister argued that concentration of authority and government-led investment calls delayed growth. At the same time, she said India's early decades saw building of key institutions and projects that laid the foundations for future development.

Describing the turn of the millennium as a decisive pivot, she said economic development, connectivity and digital infrastructure moved to the forefront of national priorities. While the 2008 financial crisis tested major economies, India's household savings and regulated banking helped cushion the impact, she said.

The minister said since 2014, reforms brought in financial inclusion, inflation targeting, the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, digital public infra and the GST.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Bajaj General, Swiss Re explore tie-up

Bajaj General Insurance and Swiss Re Corporate Solutions have signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) to explore a commercial insurance partnership in India, the companies said in a joint statement on Thursday.

The partnership will combine Bajaj General's domestic distribution with Swiss Re Corporate Solutions' International Programs platform to develop structured insurance solutions for Indian businesses.

Focus will be on tech and manufacturing risks, while providing international insurance programmes for Indian companies expanding overseas and supporting multinationals operating in India.

SAMRIDDI MAHAR



ONGC Videsh Ltd. recently secured a licence to operate in Venezuela. REUTERS

ONGC eyes two Venezuela oil blocks

Oil and Natural Gas Corp.'s (ONGC's) overseas investment arm is seeking to take over operatorship of two shallow onshore oil blocks in Venezuela from state-run Petroleos de Venezuela SA, as the South American nation becomes a key focus after receiving a US licence to operate there, the company's chief financial officer said.

ONGC Videsh Ltd. recently secured a licence from the US office of foreign assets control, giving it "full freedom" to operate in Venezuela, ONGC chief financial officer (CFO) Anupam Agarwal told analysts on an earnings call.

ONGC Videsh currently holds a 40% stake in the San Cristobal field as well as an 11% stake in the Carabobo-1 block.

The two projects are comparable to ONGC's onshore acreage in India's western state of Gujarat, providing the company with the technical expertise to operate them, Agarwal said.

India, the world's third-largest oil consumer, has been seeking to diversify crude supplies beyond the Middle East while expanding overseas upstream investments to improve energy security and reduce exposure to price shocks.

RWIT GHOSH

StanChart gets nod for GIFT products

Mumbai: Standard Chartered has received in-principle approval from the International Financial Services Centres Authority (Ifsca) to distribute capital market products from GIFT City, the bank said in a statement on Thursday.

The approval will allow the lender to launch its wealth management business from GIFT City, with retail services expected to begin over the next few months. Standard Chartered was the first foreign bank to start operations in GIFT City in 2020. It currently offers lending, trade finance, transaction banking and financial markets products to corporate and institutional clients from the international financial centre.

SAMRIDDI MAHAR

Swiggy eyes ₹10,000 crore Ebitda by FY31 amid growth

Sowmya Ramasubramanian
sowmya.r@livemint.com
BENGALURU

Swiggy Ltd on Thursday set a five-year roadmap to build a ₹10,000-crore adjusted Ebitda (earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization) business by FY31, driven by rapid growth in food delivery, quick commerce and dining out.

At its Capital Markets Day, the company said it aims to more than triple consolidated gross order value (GOV) to around ₹2.5 trillion by FY31, implying a CAGR of over 30%. It expects adjusted Ebitda margins to rise to about 4% of GOV.

The Bengaluru-based company expects its earnings per share to improve from a loss of ₹16 in FY26 to ₹30-33 by FY31. Swiggy's shares rose nearly 5% Thursday on the announcement. They later pared some gains and were up 0.5% at ₹297.90 apiece on the BSE.

Swiggy aims to meet its target by hiking monthly transacting user base 2.5-3 times, raising ordering frequency and broadening consumer use cases across platforms. The firm ended the June quarter with a B2C GOV of ₹18,926 crore and 27.5 million average monthly transacting users.

"Our confidence in achieving our five-year Ebitda goal is



Swiggy said Instamart has improved unit economics. MINT

rooted in the strength of our fundamentals," MD and group CEO Sriharsha Majety said, adding that Swiggy operates in three large consumer markets.

The food delivery business is expected to contribute roughly half of the FY31 Ebitda target. Swiggy sees it generating about ₹5,000 crore in adjusted Ebitda, with GOV growing 2.5-3.5 times from FY26.

Swiggy said affordability initiatives, including its recently launched Toing platform, would be a key growth lever as it looks to close the frequency gap in the food delivery market, where about 70% users now order less than once a month.

The company estimates India's food services market to expand from around \$90 billion in 2026 to about \$150 billion by 2031, creating room for

above-market growth. Affordability alone could unlock 5-7 percentage points of additional category growth, it noted.

Quick commerce
In quick commerce, Instamart aims GOV of over ₹1.5 trillion by FY31, a four- to fivefold rise. It aims to expand monthly transacting user base to over 40 million while moving towards Ebitda breakeven.

Swiggy said Instamart has improved unit economics, with contribution margin losses narrowed to 0.2% of GOV in Q1. About 45% of dark store network is contribution-margin positive, while five of seven top cities are operating profitably.

"To stand out in a crowded quick commerce market, we are building differentiation through better products, stronger brand partnerships and our own brands, rather than competing only on speed," Nandita Sinha, Instamart's new CEO, said.

Swiggy said it remains debt-free with a cash balance of ₹14,400 crore. It reiterated that the transition to an investor-owned commerce company structure and proposed hike in foreign shareholding cap to 49.5% would help Instamart's move to a first-party inventory model within two-four quarters of shareholding nod.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

IPO-bound Milky Mist flexes its *paneer* punch

Neethi Lisa Rojan
neethi.rojan@livemint.com
MUMBAI

After global dairy majors found it tough to crack India's cooperative-led dairy market, the Tamil Nadu-based Milky Mist is betting on a different strategy. It is headed to the stock market with a focus on value-added dairy products rather than milk in pouches to compete with giants Amul and Mother Dairy.

"In the last few years, transformation is happening from the unorganized to organized sector," Satish Kumar T, chairman and managing director, told *Mint*.

Milk in pouches is among the most popular packaged food products in India. "It is not necessary to be present in the milk category. Since we established it as an entire product range, we see a lot of advantages there," K. Rathnam, chief executive officer, said.

Milky Mist's portfolio includes *paneer*, cheese, butter, curd, yoghurt, buttermilk, milkshakes, chocolate, ice cream and frozen food items such as *parotta*. Competition from cooperative dairy players is massive in India. The Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation, which markets Amul, saw total turnover top ₹1 trillion in FY26, while Noida-based Mother Dairy reported revenue of ₹20,300 crore, up 17%.

French multinational food giant Danone entered mainstream dairy



Milky Mist CMD Satish Kumar T (left) with CEO K. Rathnam.

business in India in 2011, eventually shutting its local dairy operations around 2018 on competition from cooperatives. Other giants such as Lactalis adapted via acquisitions.

Milky Mist's IPO will be open 11-13 August. Its price band is ₹133-140 per share of face value ₹2.

Milky Mist cut its IPO size to ₹1,553 crore from the ₹2,035 crore proposed last July after its ₹357-crore pre-IPO fundraising. Promoters hold 93%, in the firm while public shareholders— including Temasek's Jongsong Investments that has 5.16%—own the rest.

In the last decade, dairy players such as Parag Milk and Doda Dairy listed on the exchanges. Shares of the sector players are trending down amid inflationary pressures.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Founders of Fisdom to exit Groww a year after buyout

Mansi Verma
mansi.verma@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Fisdom co-founders Subramanya S.V. and Anand Dalmia are set to exit Groww after completing the integration of the wealth management firm Groww acquired last year in one of the largest consolidation deals in India's wealthtech sector. Both founders will have completed a year with Groww by the exit, following the closure of the transaction, it said in a statement on Thursday.

Mint earlier reported that Groww signed a definitive pact to acquire Fisdom in May 2025 and closed the all-cash deal at about \$150 million in October. The buyout brought Groww more than 150 wealth advisers, over ₹10,000 crore in AUM, research and advisory capabilities, bank partnerships, and licences spanning portfolio management services and alternative investment funds.

Fisdom's research and advisory teams have folded into MF Prime, Groww's research backed, AI-powered mutual fund recommendation engine, the firm said. Fisdom was founded in 2015 by Dalmia and Subramanya. Groww does not plan to bring in external replacements.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Motherson Q1 net profit surges 77.5%

Auto component maker Samvardhana Motherson International on Thursday reported a 77.5% jump in consolidated net profit at ₹1,075.66 crore in the first quarter ended 30 June 2026, riding higher revenue.

The company had posted a consolidated net profit of ₹606.09 crore in the corresponding period of the last fiscal, Motherson said in a regulatory filing. Consolidated total revenue from operations in the first quarter stood at ₹35,243.77 crore as against ₹30,212 crore in the year-ago period, it added.

Total expenses in the quarter under review were higher at ₹33,964.73 crore as compared to ₹29,408.42 crore in the same period a year ago, the company said. "Despite input cost inflation and an evolving geopolitical environment, disciplined execution and cost optimisation drove resilient profitability," said chairman Vivek Chaand Sehgal.

PTI



Tenors range between 6-1/2 years and 7 years with proceeds to refinance an existing debt. REUTERS

Vedanta unit seeks mega loan post split

Vedanta Aluminium Metal Ltd, a Vedanta Group unit is raising ₹13,500 crore from at least three banks, the first large loan since the conglomerate was split into separate firms, according to people aware of the matter.

Axis Bank signed a loan agreement for ₹5,500 crore with Vedanta Aluminium Metal Ltd, said the people who asked not to be identified as the information is private. HDFC Bank and ICICI Bank will collectively lend ₹8,000 crore to the new entity, they said.

The loan tenors range between 6-1/2 years and 7 years with proceeds to be used to refinance an existing debt that Vedanta Aluminium inherited from the previous structure, the people said. The banks are offering interest rates in the range of 7.9%-8%. Representatives for Vedanta Group, Axis Bank, ICICI Bank and HDFC Bank didn't immediately respond to requests for comment.

REUTERS

OfBusiness mulls reviving IPO plan

OFB Tech Pvt., the operator of technology supply chain and financing platform OfBusiness, is considering reviving plans for an initial public offering (IPO) that could raise as much as \$800 million, according to people familiar with the matter.

The company is aiming to file its draft prospectus as soon as November, the people said. An earlier attempt to list OfBusiness a few years ago was put on hold amid weak market conditions, the people said. The revived offering is expected to include a fresh issuance of up to \$200 million, with the remainder being sold by existing shareholders, they said.

A representative for OfBusiness declined to comment on details. Referring to the previous attempt, the spokesperson said the filing had to wait for a corporate restructuring to be over. This regulatory process took longer than expected, the spokesperson added.

BLOOMBERG

Nazara eyes ₹733 cr from share sale

Nazara Technologies has announced plans to raise ₹733.5 crore through a preferential issue of equity shares, the gaming company said on Thursday.

The shares are proposed to be issued at ₹306 apiece and will be subscribed entirely by the founders and senior leadership team of Bluetile Games and BestPlay Systems.

"Bluetile and BestPlay founders and senior leadership to collectively invest ₹733.5 crore in Nazara equity at ₹306 per share," the company said in a statement.

The capital raise is expected to strengthen Nazara's balance sheet and support strategic acquisitions and growth across its gaming portfolio. "Raymond Albaladejo Stauffer, who assumes office as chief executive officer of Nazara Technologies with effect from 1 September 2026, subject to regulatory approvals, will subscribe to equity shares aggregating approximately ₹583.5 crore," the statement said.

PTI



INSIDE HYBE'S PLAN TO REINVENT INDIAN POP

The South Korean music giant wants to build its next global girl group from India

Soumya Gupta

soumya.gupta@livemint.com
MUMBAI

In the summer of 2002, five women clad in various shades of pink hit the TV screens on Channel V, singing and dancing to 'Hum naye geet sunaaye' (we sing new songs), promising to be the rebellious new voice of Y2K girls and young women. Store shelves were lined with pink cassettes exclaiming 'Viva!'. It had eight songs written by the legendary poet Javed Akhtar, spanning the nature of love and relationships and a fierce desire for independence. The all-girl group was India's first, and sold over 500,000 copies of its album, as per *The Economic Times*, before splitting a couple of years later.

In the two decades since, India has barely had an all-girl music group. Cassettes gave way to CDs, only to be rapidly replaced with the era of music downloads and now, streaming. Film music engulfed the music industry in the 2000s, before the resurgence of independent (but largely male) musicians in languages like Punjabi, Haryanvi and Bhojpuri, along with Tamil and Telugu.

Indian music occupies an entirely new universe today than it did at the turn of the century. Yet, the country is set to get a brand new all-girl band again, 25 years later, thanks to a billion-dollar South Korean music and media corporation.

Last September, Seoul-based Hybe Corp., the 'Big Four' music company behind Korean boy-band BTS, discreetly set up an office in Mumbai. This year, it began a series of auditions across 10 Indian cities and five global ones with a large Indian diaspora, hunting for the members of an all-girl band the company intends to build on the principles of K-pop hit acts.

Hybe's best-known girl groups include Le Sserafim and their recent American co-creation Katseye.

Alongside Hybe, Korea's 'Big Four' includes SM Entertainment, JYP Entertainment and YG Entertainment.

But why is a South Korean multinational music label, with over \$5 billion in market cap and \$1.8 billion in annual revenue, setting up shop in India? Why is it building a 'K-pop-style' girl band in the country? Most important: what does this tell us about the future of the music business here?

THE NEW WAVE

While teenaged girls and young women were reciting the lyrics to the music of Viva! and other American bands, a generation of young children were getting their first brush with Korean music instead.

"When I was a kid, I would watch the TV channel Animax a lot," says 20-something Aditya Mhaske, a Mumbai-based executive who runs K-pop fan meets and other events in his spare time. "In those days, the early-2000s, Animax played K-pop music instead of ads during its ad breaks. That is how I got started. Then, I really got into K-pop because of Super Junior (a K-pop band founded by Hybe's rival SM Entertainment in 2005)."

For an entire generation of young Indians, largely under 25 and brought up in the big cities, non-Indian music has always included the stars of Korea's 'Hallyu wave'—a term referencing the rise of South Korean culture across the world. For 22-year-old singer and dancer Payal Chaudhary, based in Mumbai, the first brush with Korean music was a little later than Mhaske's Animax days.

"*Gangnam Style* (released 2012) was the first time I was introduced to a new culture," she says. "I was in the 4th or 5th standard. I had watched the video on someone's phone. I did not understand the lyrics but the music was so good! Every kid was dancing to it."

Gangnam Style by Korean singer PSY was the first video on YouTube to ever reach 1 billion views, in less than six months from its release. Another four years later, Chaudhary and her friends were caught up in an entirely new wave of Korean music.

"Everything changed in 2016 when I first saw BTS," she says. "That year, the band received a global award. When I saw the band members, I remember thinking the seven of them look the same."

Cut to today, Chaudhary is waiting to hear back from the Mumbai audition of Hybe's upcoming all-girl music group. This wasn't her first audition for the Korean music industry though. In 2022 and 2023, JYP had also held auditions, looking for a K-pop idol from the country.

"I went to audition for them (JYP) in Andheri (a Mumbai suburb). I sang and danced well, but I was too overweight. I weighed 65kg back then. The Korean

Korean music and entertainment is no longer niche. A large number of Korean bands and individual artists have come to India since 2014



(Left to right) Fans watch Korean artistes perform at Hybe's 'Pop-Up Park' at Inorbit Mall, Malad, Mumbai; Shreya Lenka from the band Blackswan.

labels are very strict about their criteria—you have to be able to sing and dance, and you have to look a certain way," Chaudhary says.

Determined to make it work, she worked hard on her physique in time for Hybe's auditions. "I am 43kg now."

GIRL OR BOY?

Hybe Corp. has been keeping an eye on generational changes in India for years, waiting for the right time to set up camp in one of the world's largest music markets.

"When we first said we will be entering the India market, people were surprised but also welcoming," Dahae Lee, chief operating officer of Hybe India, told *Mint* in an interview. (Lee's responses were translated in real time from Korean to English during the interview by a translator provided by Hybe).

"We decided to go into India not just because it is fast growing. We have been researching the market for a long time and looking for the optimal time to enter," she says.

The surge of smartphone and internet use post-pandemic changed how Indians across age groups 'consumed culture,' Lee adds. "Looking at the streaming data, Indian independent artistes have seen rapid, exponential growth. Their face and

individual identity are promoted. Regional and local language music has also grown. We believe we can elevate independent artistes in India to the global stage."

For now, Hybe has two main goals. First, to systematically bring more Korean music to India and cultivate an audience here. And two, to set up the country's first all-girl music group that can promote 'harmony in diversity'.

"We want to make our girl group loved by every single Indian," Lee says. "Our foremost goal is to support this first girl group. We are going to create music rooted in Indian authenticity and identity, but make them global artistes with a global audience."

Auditions are still under way both online and offline and Hybe did not share a timeline for when the girl group may be ready.

But why an all-girl group and not a boy band like BTS? Lee, after all, worked with BTS in her previous roles at Hybe in Seoul. "We had a very intense debate on whether to go with a girl group or a boy group," she says. "I have worked with Seventeen and BTS and I thought a boy band would be a better option."

However, the company commissioned market research firm Nielsen for a survey—it surveyed about 2,000 Indians. A qualitative survey was also conducted in six Indian cities.

The findings underlined the need for

more female representation—young women had few female role models to look up to in entertainment.

"India really needs a girl group right now," Lee stresses.

THE MASTERCLASS

Hybe isn't the only one to realise India is ready for an all-girl group. Music producer Mikey McCleary founded a four-member all-girl band Wish, which debuted their first song Lazeez in 2024. Late last year, music management company The Hello Group signed up Wish to manage the band.

The Hello Group has worked with major Korean music labels behind acts like BTS, and has an office in Seoul. When Hybe laid plans to enter India, Wish was one of the musical acts the company's executives saw.

"When Hybe came into India last year, they did a bunch of masterclasses," Hamza Kazi, head of artiste relations and development at The Hello Group India, says. "Wish was at one of those interactive sessions about two months ago. They spoke about how they built their identity, how they use fashion, and the themes they talk about when writing songs. They also performed two-three of their songs. It was great, also a sort of nod of approval for Wish."

Kazi says Wish, as an all-girl group, occupies a wide gap in the Indian music scene but in the minds of an ordinary Indian fan, bands of young singers and dancers have become inextricably linked to K-pop.

"A lot of people confuse Wish for a K-pop band just because it's a girl group," Kazi says. "But if you listen to their music, it is not K-pop music at all, which has a very specific sound, ideology and ethos."

That shows the chokehold that Korean music labels have on the concept of bands and how they have slowly altered the perception of musical bands across the world, and in India.

Once, the idea of bands was dominated by the American rock legends of the '70s and '80s and later, boy bands like Backstreet Boys while the best known all-girl pop music bands included the UK sensation Spice Girls and US superstar Beyoncé's band Destiny's Child. These acts defined mainstream music of the '90s and influenced pop bands in India in the early 2000s such as Viva! and A Band of Boys.

Now, artistes and fans alike associate bands with high-fashion dancing-singing performers. They know that getting into a K-pop band is highly competitive and the training rigorous—spanning singing and dancing lessons, personality development, media training, and cultivating a strong sense of identity that can, in turn, create extremely loyal fans.

Fandom of bands like BTS—who call themselves ARMY—and girl bands like Blackpink can be fierce. That world attracts not just fans like Mhaske and singers like Chaudhary, but also small-town performers like Shreya Lenka.



\$5 BILLION +

Hybe Corp.'s market cap, with \$1.8 billion in annual revenue, underscoring the massive scale of the South Korean firm

14.4 MILLION

Monthly active users on Weverse in Q2 2026, representing direct-to-fan monetization model Hybe relies on beyond streaming

10 MILLION

Views clocked by the video of Karma thus far, a song by the band Blackswan that was shot in Odisha

THE GIRL FROM JHARSUGUDA

Lenka, who goes by the stage name Sriya, moved to Seoul in 2021 after she got through auditions to win a place in the band Blackswan. Sriya is from Jharsuguda, a town in Odisha, and is a trained Odissi dancer.

"There is a huge cultural difference between both the music industries," she told *Mint* in an interview. "In India, we focus on one single person, the artiste. They (the music industry executives) want results. They will help you, but you have to do the work on your own."

In contrast, Sriya says, Korean labels treat their bands as intellectual property (IP) and band members behave as teammates and colleagues. "Working in a musical group is very different because you have to communicate," she says.

"You have to work with all personalities and cultures while doing your business. You have to understand everyone, communicate well, stand out, discipline yourself and go through intense training because you have to measure every single detail on stage," she adds.

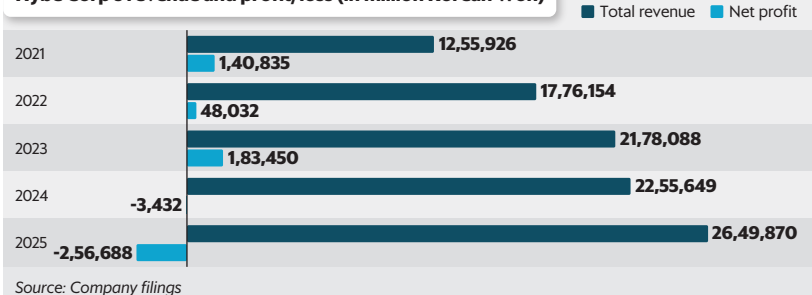
This complex architecture is all in service of building extremely loyal fandoms, the kind that can feed into sales of concert tickets, physical media including vinyls and CDs, and newer forms of IP monetization including feature-length documentaries on the bands and their members.

These revenue streams are more lucrative and endure longer in the long-term than money made from streaming, which can fetch as little as a few cents per stream. India's music industry relies almost entirely on streaming and other digital rights.

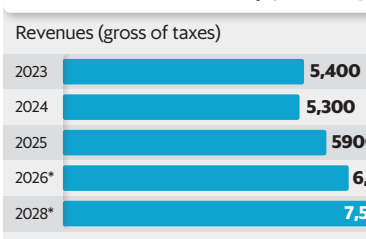
Music mix

Hybe Corp. has been keeping an eye on generational changes in India for years

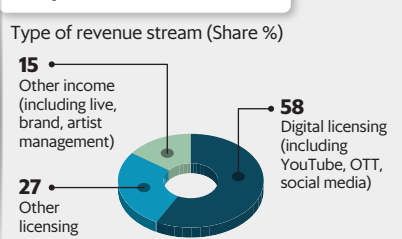
Hybe Corp's revenue and profit/loss (in million Korean Won)



Size of India's music industry (in ₹ crore)



Composition of music revenue



Source: EY-FICCI Media & Entertainment Report, 2026

mint
MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

In contrast, Hybe made more than 36% of its annual revenue in 2025 from 'artiste indirect involvement' revenue such as content, merchandise, and fan clubs, and another 34% from ads, public appearances, and concerts of their artiste roster.

Concerts, in particular, can change the fortune of large labels like Hybe.

For example, after a loss-making first quarter in 2026, the company swiftly moved into profits largely due to BTS' ongoing world tour for its latest album *Arirang*.

Hybe's India entry and plans to make a new girl band are coming at a momentous time. It is bringing this newer, more global business model to the country as music listening habits change significantly.

Korean music and entertainment is no longer niche. A large number of Korean bands and individual artistes have come to India since 2014.

Some, like Sriya and her band Blackswan, performed at K-Town, a Korean music festival co-organised by JetAlive, the live events arm of gaming firm Jet-Synthesys. Suho of the popular K-pop band Exo, first visited India way back in 2015, and then returned in 2024 for a solo performance.

Besides, mainstream and niche Korean artistes have been making inroads into Indian audiences, collaborating with desi artistes and even featuring in ads and movies.

In June, Hybe's Le Sserafim released a remix of their global hit Boompala with Punjabi singer-songwriter Guru Ran-

dawa; the video has 1.2 million views. In August 2022, girl group Tribe released a song *Memu Aagamu* with singer-songwriter Armaan Malik and actor Allu Arjun for that year's Coke Studio India.

Singer Aooru has featured in reality TV shows *Bigg Boss* and *Jhalak Dikhhla Ja* along with an Ekta Kapoor soap made for YouTube called *Saas Bahu Aur Swaad*.

And in June last year, Crocs India released an ad for their shoes starring actor Sidhanth Chaturvedi and K-drama star Chae Soo-bin. Sriya's band Blackswan returned to Odisha to shoot their song *Karma* in 2023; the video has over 10 million views.

NOTHING PERMANENT

Fandom has never been more important to the business of music, Kazi says, and Korea's biggest music labels have mastered the art of building it. Hybe owns a tech platform Weverse that lets fans connect with their favourite artistes via direct messages, watch them live, and buy their merchandise.

Weverse reported 14.4 million monthly active users in the second quarter of 2026.

Hybe's Lee says Indian artistes also want to use Weverse; but the company will get to this line of business in India a little later. For now, the company's aim remains focused—get the all-girl music band going.

(The Hybe brand is stylized by the company in all capital letters, as are the BTS album *Arirang* and the bands *Le Sserafim*, *Katseye*, *Blackpink*, *Blackswan*, and *Exo*. *Wish* is stylized as *W.I.S.H.*, and *Tribe* as *TRIBE*.)



Liked this story?
Share it by
scanning the
QR code.



What NRIs must consider before buying or selling property in India

From Fema rules and TDS to repatriation limits and powers of attorney—key factors NRIs need to get right

Apurita Sharma
apurita.sharma@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Buying or selling property in India can be far more complicated for NRIs than for resident Indians. Beyond finding the right buyer or negotiating the right price lies a maze of tax rules, FEMA regulations, repatriation limits and documentation requirements.

A wrong choice of bank account, a missed TDS deduction or an improperly executed power of attorney can delay transactions, lock up money for months or even invite penalties.

Here are the key issues experts say NRIs should keep in mind.

Currency reality

If you earn in US dollars, converting that income into Indian rupees can make Indian property appear more affordable because of the rupee's long-term depreciation. Similarly, when you sell the property, the gains in rupee terms may look impressive. However, what really matters is the return in the currency in which you ultimately intend to spend or hold your wealth.

Sidhant Agarwal, a chartered accountant and co-founder of India for NRI, illustrated this with an example. Suppose an NRI invested ₹22.6 crore in a premium property between 2015 and 2020 and sold it today for ₹60 crore. On paper, the investment appears to have nearly tripled, yielding a gain of about ₹37.4 crore after costs. Adjusted for currency movements, however, the picture looks very different. "The currency-adjusted internal rate of return (IRR) works out to about 10.7% in rupee terms but only around 6.5% in dollar terms over 11 years. That's broadly in line with what a simple global index fund could have delivered, without the construction risk, illiquidity and compliance burden that comes with owning property," he said.

The tax impact comes on top of this. "Indian capital gains tax is calculated entirely in rupees using the property's purchase and sale value. It does not compensate investors for the loss in value caused by currency depreciation, unlike the treatment available for certain financial instruments," said Agarwal.

That said, the comparison is relevant only for NRIs who intend to use their wealth in US dollars. If you plan to spend or reinvest the proceeds in India, rupee returns are what matter.

Agarwal also cautioned against using cash if you intend to repatriate funds later. Repatriation requires a chartered accountant's certificate backed by documentary proof of the source of funds.

Account matters

The choice between an NRE/FCNR account and an NRO account can significantly influence how easily

NRI guide to property deals in India

The essential checklist covering TDS, PoA and more to help avoid costly tax, compliance and documentation mistakes.

1 The rupee return illusion

- ▶ Measure returns in the currency you'll ultimately use.
- ▶ Gains in rupees can shrink after accounting for currency depreciation.

2 Pick the right account

- ▶ **NRE/FCNR account:** entire principal can be repatriated*.
- ▶ **NRO account:** repatriation capped at **\$1 million** a year.

*Capital gains remain subject to the \$1 million annual cap.

3 Route sale proceeds to NRO account

- ▶ An NRI buyer and seller cannot settle a property transaction through their NRE accounts.

4 Don't ignore TDS

- ▶ Buyer must deduct **12.5%** TDS (plus applicable surcharge and cess) on long-term capital gains.



5 Selling to family? You may not need a sale deed

- ▶ Save stamp duty by transferring property via:
 - ▶ Gift deed
 - ▶ Relinquishment deed
 - ▶ Family settlement deed

6 How a PoA works

- ▶ Both steps are essential:
 - ▶ Embassy/Consulate attestation (or apostille, where applicable)
 - ▶ Registration at the local sub-registrar's office in India

7 Rental income

- ▶ Ensure your tenant deducts TDS before paying rent.
- ▶ TDS is **30%** (plus applicable surcharge and cess).

8 Avoid delays by keeping key documents ready

- ▶ Seller must have a PAN card.*
- ▶ Original (or certified copy of) sale deed.
- ▶ Legal heir/succession certificate (if the property is inherited).
- ▶ Freehold conversion deed (if applicable).

PoA: Power of Attorney, NRE: Non-Resident External, FCNR: Foreign Currency Non-Resident, NRO: Non-Resident Ordinary, TDS: Tax Deducted at Source

*Otherwise, TDS will be deducted at 20% plus surcharge and cess.

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

sale proceeds can be repatriated later.

If the property is purchased using funds from a Non-Resident External (NRE) account or a Foreign Currency Non-Resident (FCNR) account, the original investment can generally be repatriated in full upon sale. However, for residential properties, this benefit is available only for up to two properties, after which the \$1 million annual repatriation limit applies. Commercial properties are not subject to this restriction.

If the property is purchased using funds from a Non-Resident Ordinary (NRO) account, repatriation is capped at \$1 million per financial year regardless of the number of properties sold. Any amount above this requires prior RBI approval through the authorised dealer bank.

However, Agarwal said many NRIs misunderstand what the funding source actually achieves. "The funding source only protects the principal's speed of exit. Any appreciation, which is usually the point of the

investment, still falls within the \$1 million annual repatriation limit either way," he said.

Where the sale proceeds are credited is equally important. Under the FEMA rules, the sale proceeds from an Indian property must be credited to the seller's NRO account from the buyer's bank account.

"If both the buyer and the seller are NRIs, they cannot settle the property transaction directly through their NRE or any foreign bank accounts. Doing so would violate FEMA rules and could attract significant penalties," said CA Ajay R. Vaswani of ARAS and Company.

TDS pitfalls

Also, note that TDS compliance is the buyer's responsibility, but sellers have a strong interest in ensuring it is done correctly.

If the seller is a resident Indian, the buyer deducts 1% TDS (for properties above ₹50 lakh), subject to applicable conditions. If the seller is an NRI, the buyer must deduct TDS at 12.5% (plus

applicable surcharge and cess) under the new capital gains regime for long-term gains.

Failure to deduct TDS attracts interest of 1% per month (or part thereof) from the due date until deduction. If deducted but not deposited, interest of 1.5% per month applies until payment.

"The seller should ensure that the buyer deducts the applicable TDS. If the TDS is not deducted, the seller may not receive credit for it while filing the income tax return. The seller may also have to pay self-assessment tax, along with interest, as the tax department could treat the shortfall as a failure to pay advance tax," Vaswani said.

If the actual capital gains tax liability is lower than the applicable TDS, the seller should apply for a lower or nil deduction certificate before the sale deed is executed. This reduces the tax deducted upfront and avoids waiting months for a refund.

NRIs earning rental income should

also remember that tenants are required to deduct TDS at 30% plus applicable surcharge and cess before paying rent.

Beyond sale deeds

Many families unnecessarily execute sale deeds while transferring property among close relatives.

Agarwal recalled a case where a son transferred property to his mother through a sale agreement, resulting in avoidable stamp duty.

"We routinely meet NRIs who paid full stamp duty and transaction costs on a property transfer to their own sibling or child when the situation didn't call for a sale at all. Gift deeds, relinquishment deeds and family settlement deeds exist precisely for such situations, but many people discover them only after they have already paid the extra cost," he said.

The power of attorney trap

Many NRIs assume they must travel to India to complete a property transaction. In many cases, a properly drafted specific or general power of attorney (POA) allows a trusted relative to complete the formalities.

However, embassy attestation alone is insufficient.

"The POA stamped only by the Indian Embassy abroad will not work. It still has to be registered at the local sub-registrar's office in India to be legally binding," Agarwal said.

He added that many NRIs complete only the overseas attestation and fail to register the document in India, discovering years later that it has no legal validity.

Keep your documents ready

Documentation is another area where transactions often get delayed.

A common mistake among NRI sellers is not having a Permanent Account Number (PAN), particularly among those who left India at a young age and never needed one. A PAN is essential because the buyer cannot correctly deduct and deposit TDS without it. "Without PAN, the TDS will be deducted at 20% plus surcharge and cess," said Vaswani.

Other important documents include the original sale deed (or a certified copy), a legal heir or succession certificate in case of inherited property, and, where applicable, the freehold conversion deed for properties converted from leasehold to freehold status.

For NRIs, buying or selling property in India is not just about finding the right deal but also navigating a maze of regulatory compliance. Seeking professional advice early on can help avoid expensive mistakes and regulatory hassles later.



Liked this story? Please share it by scanning the QR code.



POWER
POINT

DEEPTI BHASKARAN

Respond to this column at
feedback@livemint.com

PORTABILITY BLIND SPOT: A REFORM WITHOUT REFEREE

Nothing stings quite like having a health insurance claim rejected for no apparent fault of yours. Yet, this is a risk policyholders may unknowingly face when they port their health insurance policies.

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority (Irdai) introduced portability to ensure customers were not trapped in unsuitable policies. The idea was simple: let policyholders switch insurers, encouraging better service, products, competitive pricing and greater choice. The system works well on paper. In practice, however, it has not worked as intended.

Switching health insurance is not as simple as changing other financial products. A new policy means serving waiting periods from scratch. Portability addresses this by allowing policyholders to carry forward time spent with their existing insurer, preserving continuity benefits when they switch. To ensure portability worked as intended, Irdai barred intermediaries from earning commission in the first year after a policy was ported.

Over the years, Irdai strengthened the portability framework by creating a central repository at the Insurance Information Bureau of India (IIB). All porting requests pass through this platform, enabling the acquiring insurer to access the policyholder's underwriting and claims history within a specified period. The new insurer remains free to assess the customer based on the available information. Once approved, the policyholder carries forward benefits under the previous policy, including the no-claim bonus, credit for waiting periods already served and progress towards the 60-month moratorium.

When portability becomes a sales tool

Yet *Mint Money's* reporting points to failures at two levels. First is how intermediaries use portability—instead of serving as an instrument of customer choice, it is being used as a sales tool.

Intermediaries are paid incentives to port policies, even though such payments are prohibited. Porting itself is not the problem; the regulation exists to let dissatisfied policyholders switch insurers. The problem arises when the decision is driven not by the customer's needs but by the intermediary's payout.

At the industry level, roughly one in four customers did not renew the same plan, according to FY26 retention data for insurers' best-selling health plans. The data does not reveal whether they ported to another insurer, switched plans with the same insurer or dropped coverage altogether. Insurers, however, say porting accounts for a significant share of this churn. If decisions are driven by sales incentives rather than customer needs, it points to a clear problem.

Second, some intermediaries sell a fresh policy under the guise of a port. For customers, the distinction may not become apparent until much later and, often, when it matters the most.

The transparency gap

The second failure is regulatory. Nearly 15 years after introducing portability, Irdai still does not publish enough data to assess whether the mechanism is working as intended. Insurers' public disclosures do not report the number of policies ported in and out each year. While routing porting requests through the IIB is mandatory, no public data is available to verify compliance.

There is also no data on claims rejected in ported policies, leaving little clarity on how alleged non-disclosure is treated. Since the acquiring insurer can centrally access the customer's underwriting and claims history from the existing insurer, a claim rejected over information that should have travelled with the policy raises obvious questions. Policyholders deserve to know where the process failed. More importantly, such cases should trigger compliance scrutiny.

Under the current system, portability appears seamless until a claim arises. Only then do the glaring gaps between regulation and implementation become visible. Without greater transparency and oversight, portability—meant to be a lifeline for policyholders—risks becoming a noose around their necks.

Deepti Bhaskaran, editor, *Mint Money*.

Mandatory insurance policy tagging will strengthen accountability

Apurita Sharma
apurita.sharma@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) has notified Insurance Intermediaries (Amendment) Regulations, 2026, overhauling the regulatory framework for insurance intermediaries.

The changes mandate tagging every insurance policy to a salesperson, replace periodic licence renewals with perpetual registration, and

strengthen governance and disclosure norms. In an interview with *Mint*, Narendra Bharindwal, president of the Insurance Brokers Association of India (IBAI), discusses what the reforms mean for brokers, their potential to curb mis-selling, the implementation challenges, and the evolving role of intermediaries in a digital market. *Edited excerpts:*

The new rules mandate every policy sale to be tagged to a salesperson. Will this curb mis-selling, or will implementation be the bigger challenge?

This is a significant step

towards strengthening accountability and consumer protection. Assigning responsibility to an identified salesperson enhances transparency and creates greater ownership of the advice and service provided to customers.

Implementation will naturally require investments in technology, training and internal governance, particularly for firms with large distribution networks. However, the industry has consistently adapted to regulatory reforms, and we are confident this

framework will strengthen customer trust and improve the quality of insurance distribution.

Irdai has replaced periodic registration renewals with perpetual registration. Will this ease the compliance burden, especially for smaller brokers?

Perpetual registration is among the most progressive ease-of-doing-business reforms introduced by the regulator. It eliminates repetitive procedural requirements, allowing intermediaries to focus more on governance, customer service and business development rather than

administrative renewals.

That said, perpetual registration should not be mistaken for lighter regulatory oversight. Compliance remains continuous. The reform shifts the focus from periodic paperwork to ongoing compliance and responsible conduct. For smaller brokers, the benefits are particularly significant, reducing administrative costs and uncertainty while allowing them to invest more in technology, talent and customer service.

What will be the biggest operational challenge for brokerage firms under the new framework?

The biggest transformation will be strengthening governance through technology.

Brokers will increasingly need integrated digital systems that maintain complete audit trails—from customer advice and documentation to policy issuance, remuneration, servicing and claims support. Firms will also need stronger compliance monitoring, better data governance and structured training programmes.

The future of insurance distribution will be built on robust processes, documented advice and technology-enabled



bled compliance rather than manual supervision.

Should intermediaries be evaluated on policy persistency, complaints and claim record, rather than premium collected alone?

Absolutely. Insurance distribution should increasingly be assessed on customer outcomes rather than business volumes alone. Metrics such as policy persistency, complaint ratios, quality of advice, grievance resolution, customer retention and claims support provide a more holistic measure of an intermediary's contribution.

Insurance is a long-term

promise, and success should be measured by how well that promise is fulfilled throughout the customer journey.

How is the role of insurance brokers evolving as insurers invest more in digital and direct channels? Do you see competition or complementarity?

We see complementarity rather than competition. Digital channels improve accessibility and efficiency, while brokers provide personalised advice, risk assessment, product comparison and post-sales support, particularly during claims. As insurance products become more sophisticated,

the value of professional advice increases rather than diminishes. Technology will enhance brokers' capabilities, but trusted advisory services will remain key to informed customer decision-making.

After the removal of commission caps, have remuneration structures become more transparent across intermediaries?

The move to the Expenses of Management (EOM) framework has given insurers greater flexibility while placing stronger emphasis on governance, board oversight and prudent expense management.

Transparency is determined not just by commission structures but by robust governance, effective regulatory supervision and ensuring customer interests remain paramount.

The industry's focus should remain on delivering value to policyholders through quality advice and service rather than remuneration alone.

Do brokers feel pressure

from insurers to prioritize certain products because of commercial arrangements? How can conflicts of interest be minimized?

Insurance brokers are licensed professionals with a fiduciary responsibility to act in the best interests of their clients. Regulatory requirements, internal governance mechanisms and professional ethics

require brokers to recommend products based on customer needs and suitability.

Conflicts of interest are best managed through strong governance frameworks, transparent internal controls, documented advice processes, regular staff training and a customer-first culture. Maintaining public trust must remain the cornerstone of the broking profession.

What changes would you like to see in claims servicing across the industry?

The claims experience ultimately defines customer confidence in insurance. The industry should continue

working towards faster settlements, greater transparency, simplified documentation, proactive communication, increased digital integration and stronger coordination among insurers, TPAs, surveyors and intermediaries.

Brokers have long played an important role in supporting policyholders through the claims journey, and closer collaboration among all stakeholders will further improve the customer experience.

Should brokers be given a more formal role in resolving claim disputes?

Brokers already play a significant role in facilitating claims by helping customers with documentation, communication and coordination with insurers.

There may be merit in exploring structured mechanisms that allow brokers to participate more formally in early-stage dispute resolution or mediation, without compromising the insurer's responsibility for claims adjudication or the independence of grievance redressal forums.

The objective should always be faster, fairer and more customer-centric dispute resolution while preserving the integrity of the claims process.



MONEY GURU



OUR VIEW



Let UPI pay for itself: a tiny fee is all it will take

Public infrastructure attracts capital if users are ready to pay fair and transparent usage charges. The user-pays principle should apply. Let the e-rupee serve as India's digital cash

A day after India's finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman introduced the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill in Parliament proposing changes to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act of 2007 that would let banks and payment system providers charge fees on UPI and RuPay debit-card payments, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra made a pointed reference to such fees. In response to a question posed at RBI's post-policy conference, he pointed out that costs have to be borne by someone. "Ultimately, it is the consumer, in some way or the other, who is paying [for] it already. It may not be the same consumer, it may be the general economy, and you don't get to see it directly... Somehow, it is already getting passed on; it may not be directly on the user-pays principle." This principle applies to much public infrastructure, be it physical or digital.

Coincidentally, this week also saw Chief Economic Advisor V. Anantha Nageswaran call out free services, saying 'free' is "the most expensive word in public policy." He pointed out that infrastructure built on the promise of free or below-cost services cannot attract patient capital. The latter demands durable returns, which rest on two basic premises: a price that covers the economic cost of the service and users willing to pay a fair charge. Unfortunately, this point often gets lost in the context of public amenities. The country's freebie culture, for example, fosters perceptions of the state owing people these. Yet, there is no free lunch. It is thus imperative that the cost of public infrastructure (as distinct from pure public goods such as law-and-order and defence that need taxpayer money) is recoverable if we wish

to sustain investment in India's infra build-up. The Unified Payments Interface (UPI), run by National Payments Corporation of India, would therefore need to recover costs too, be it the base platform's digital expenses or bills borne by apps and the network of banks that transfer money from one account to another. Set up under RBI's aegis, UPI was initially made charge-free for users to spur adoption, but it has achieved high penetration now.

Those who want UPI kept free forever argue that it is widely seen as a cash substitute, not a bank service, and should stay so. There is no denying its benefits at both the micro level (convenience) and macro level (transactions brought into the formal system), so a fee must not end up slowing down UPI usage. Today, the government subsidizes payments of up to ₹2,000 made to small merchants through an incentive scheme to promote RuPay and low-value Bhim-UPI transactions. This public outlay goes to banks, payment service providers and third-party app providers. But according to a March report by the Standing Committee on Finance, a parliamentary panel, the total subsidy paid from 2021-22 to 2024-25 at ₹8,730 crore was "only 11% of the cost incurred by the digital payment industry," which implies an annual cost of about ₹20,000 crore. This is no trifle. A good solution would be to charge a nominal merchant discount of 0.3-0.6% on UPI transactions for large merchants, who may pass it on to customers, while keeping transfers under a certain limit exempt. For vast multitudes, it would still be like cash. Once RBI's e-rupee takes off as the currency's *de facto* digital clone (it being a direct liability of the central bank), UPI could gradually be made a fully charged service.

MY VIEW | FARM TRUTHS

Youth protests have as much to do with jobs as exam paper leaks

Creating jobs is not sufficient. India needs jobs that offer a decent living wage and social security



HIMANSHU

is associate professor at Jawaharlar Nehru University and visiting fellow at the Centre de Sciences Humaines, New Delhi.

Recent protests in Delhi have brought out the frustration of Indian youth over a dysfunctional educational system. While exam leaks, both for entrance to professional courses and specific job roles, were the main reason of protest, these were also a result of growing anxiety over the employment situation.

However, a simple reading of India's employment statistics would suggest an improvement in recent years. Overall employment by the internationally-comparable gauge of weekly status has increased substantially from 431 million in 2017-18 to 563 million in 2025, with an accompanying decline in unemployment rates. It is a different matter that most of the increase in employment is driven by agriculture, female employment in particular. None of this is a sign of improvement in India's employment structure. A deeper analysis suggests it is distress that is driving more women to farm jobs. Further, the overall employment increase in this sector shows a reversal of the structural transformation away from farms that takes place in any emerging economy.

In any case, the real measure of employment is not just the ability to get any work and earn a living. In a society with a large vulnerable population, even though not poor by official standards, remaining jobless is a luxury few can afford. What should ideally be

counted as employment is work that provides a decent level of earnings along with work conditions that would be seen as decent in any developed economy. Most self or casual employment in India is without any security of tenure, social security or a decent living wage. But even regular employment characterized by job continuity can hardly be deemed decent employment without security of tenure, social security and a decent pay cheque. That is precisely why India faces a unique phenomenon of a premium being placed on government jobs, which are widely seen as superior to private-sector jobs. No such example exists in any developed country. Such is the situation that even the lowest-paid level of a government job invites applications from lakhs of applicants, including PhD holders.

India's unemployment rate in the 18-25 age-group has fallen from 25% in 2017-18 to 17% in 2025 among rural youth and from 28% to 22% among urban youth. Still, almost one in five youth are actively seeking work but are unable to find it. It's also worrying that they are withdrawing from higher education—the proportion of students in this age group declined from 27% in 2017-18 to 25% in rural areas but was stable at 36% in urban areas. Whether the move away is a result of rising edu-

cation costs or the futility of acquiring higher education is a matter of research.

But among those who are fortunate to land a job, only a fourth are in regular employment. Even in regular jobs that the young hold, their real earnings from such employment have been almost stagnant over the years. The average earnings from regular employment in the 18-25 age-group have only grown by 0.85% per year between 2011-12 and 2025, as against India's per capita income growth of more than 4% per year. But the data also points to a decline in returns from education, with real earnings growth declining steadily as one moves up the education ladder. The primary-educated have seen real earnings increase by 2% per annum between 2011-12 and 2025, whereas these have declined for people who have finished higher-secondary studies or above. Graduates fare worse, with their real income declining 1.1% per annum while those with higher secondary or diploma seeing a decline of 0.2%. Unfortunately, even their regular jobs do not guarantee a secure future. In 70% of the cases, there are no written contracts and only 20% have a written deed of one year or more. Almost 60% are not eligible for paid leave or any social security benefit.

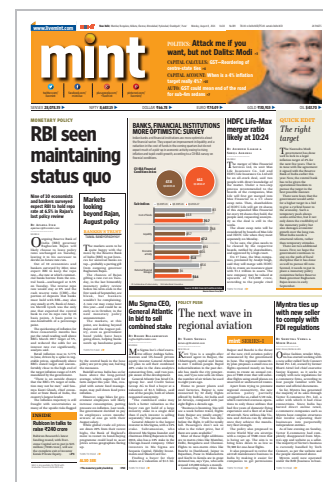
Clearly, the issue of unemployment is not just about getting a job. Declining unemployment rates do not capture the precariousness of even the best jobs available to the youth. While the immediate trigger for youth protests may have been exam leaks, the anguish is no less about the system, which seems unfair to those who want higher education or seek better livelihoods. An examination system rejig is only a part of the reforms needed in education. Euphoria over India being the world's fastest-growing major economy has stoked aspirations among the youth who confront a different reality. Job creation is not enough. India needs jobs that guarantee a decent living wage, security of tenure and social protection.

QUICK READ

India's employment statistics show new jobs being created but these have been driven by agriculture, reflecting a reversal of the shift away from farms that any emerging economy sees.

India must not only create new jobs but ones that offer decent living wages, security of tenure and social protection. Euphoria over India's rapid economic growth has stoked aspirations.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

Digital payments have gone from novelty to necessity, and our oversight must reflect this reality.

ROHIT CHOPRA

THEIR VIEW

Why nobody expected the MPC to increase interest rates

PUJA MEHRA



is senior fellow (consultant), Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) did exactly what almost every RBI watcher expected this week. It left the repo rate unchanged. The decision was unanimous. By the time the announcement arrived, financial markets had already moved on to the RBI governor's explanation.

That reasoning was what gave economists something to get their teeth into. Inflation has been edging up for five consecutive months and remained above RBI's 4% target since June. Yet, the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) sounded more dovish about the outlook than many economists had expected.

The immediate reason is easy enough to identify. Consumer price inflation during the first quarter of 2026-27 came in below RBI's own forecast. Core inflation is subdued too. The committee's judgement is that inflation is rising without becoming broad-based. RBI believes it will peak later this year without breaching its tolerance limit of 6%.

That assessment may prove correct. Equally, it may not. Surveys suggest that

inflation expectations are firming up, as the MPC itself noted in its previous meeting. Much therefore turns on RBI's inflation projections. Yet there are good reasons to be cautious about them. Geopolitical disruptions and recurring global shocks have all made that forecasting unusually difficult.

RBI lowered its inflation projection for 2026-27 marginally. Even so, its forecast implies inflation above 5% for three successive quarters (5.9% in the third quarter of 2026-27, 5.5% in the fourth and 5.3% in the first quarter of 2027-28). It also raised its 2026-27 growth forecast from 6.6% to 6.7%, with the governor noting at the post-policy conference that 7% was "not inconceivable." The interesting question, then, is not whether RBI should have raised rates this week. The more revealing question is why almost nobody expected it to.

Expectations of a central bank's moves are formed less by reading policy statements than by observing what they repeatedly do. Every MPC says it balances inflation against growth. Markets pay closer attention to what committees actually do when those objectives are in conflict.

Over time, a fairly settled view of RBI has emerged. It is widely seen as an institution that prefers to wait rather than tighten pol-

icy unless inflation becomes impossible to ignore or external developments leave it with little room for manoeuvre. That reputation did not arise from this meeting. It has been accumulating over several years.

The inflation shock that followed Russia's invasion of Ukraine is part of that record. Like several central banks abroad, RBI initially thought inflation would be transitory. As prices continued to rise, policy remained largely unresponsive. The eventual tightening came only after the US Federal Reserve had begun raising interest rates, and in an unscheduled meeting that caught markets by surprise.

RBI never suggested that exchange-rate considerations had influenced its decision. It did not have to. The timing led many observers to conclude that protecting the rupee had become at least as pressing an aim as containing domestic inflation.

That episode changed expectations of how RBI approaches tough trade-offs. There are other rea-

sons those expectations have hardened. During the pandemic-time inflation surge, the MPC appeared willing to tolerate inflation above the limit prescribed under its inflation-targeting framework. Official price statistics had been disrupted during covid lockdowns, so the government did not make RBI's explanation for the breach public. The central bank may have consequently escaped much scrutiny, even though the underlying inflation trend was evident from other indicators.

None of this proves RBI has given up inflation targeting. Nor does it imply that this week's decision was an error. What it does suggest is that markets observe central banks pursuing several objectives and infer a hierarchy among them. Conversations with market participants reveal a recurring concern that is expressed more in private than in public. Many investors would describe the hierarchy roughly as: exchange-rate stability, government's borrowing costs, growth and finally

QUICK READ

The monetary policy panel's decision not to hike RBI's repo rate in the face of inflation risks felt like a foregone conclusion. It was inferred from its record of actions if not words.

Market participants seem to have assumed an RBI priority order. This shapes expectations, which play a role in the efficacy of policy moves, just as a central bank's reputation does.

Market participants seem to have assumed an RBI priority order. This shapes expectations, which play a role in the efficacy of policy moves, just as a central bank's reputation does.

inflation. Whether RBI itself would recognize such a priority order is beside the point. Once markets begin to believe it, the perception acquires economic significance of its own.

That view influences not only expectations of the next policy decision, but also how markets interpret every inflation reading and communication from the MPC. The coming weeks may offer an early test of that perception. The Fed will meet again in September, ahead of RBI's October policy review. The MPC may well decide by then that inflation warrants higher rates. Many market participants expect the Fed's decision to shape RBI's room for manoeuvre as much as domestic inflation.

The MPC may well decide that inflation warrants higher rates by then. Whether that expectation proves right is less important than the fact that it has become part of the market's reading of RBI. That may explain why this week's decision felt less like a close call than a foregone conclusion. Inflation has been rising and inflation expectations are showing signs of firming up. Yet, very few analysts bet on a rate hike. They have come to believe they know how RBI reacts under such circumstances. Monetary policy works through expectations. So, increasingly, does RBI's reputation.



GUEST VIEW

Upper Assam floods reveal how outdated our financial set-up is

Deluge patterns are changing but disaster response and mitigation funding follows yesterday's data. It should be proactive



AMIT KAPOOR & SHEEN ZUTSHI
are, respectively, chair and research manager,
Institute for Competitiveness. X: @kautiliya.

Assam is the latest victim of a pattern that is becoming normalized in India to a dangerous extent. Another year, the headline may name Bihar, a Himalayan district or a coastal city where a familiar hazard has acquired an unfamiliar intensity. Assam's floods this monsoon have claimed 87 lives and affected 349 villages and hundreds of thousands of people across seven districts, with the chief minister describing water levels as unseen in half a century. Upper Assam is not accustomed to such inundation. The suffering reveals a story of policy mismatches.

This tragedy needs to be understood against Assam's wider climate risk landscape. The Climate Risk and Vulnerability Assessment of 2025 places the state fifth among India's 28 states overall, with the second-highest exposure score nationally. The report estimates that 47% of Assam is highly vulnerable to floods. Exposure indicates the scale of risk, but adaptive capacity determines if warning channels reach communities, roads stay accessible, drinking water and healthcare function, and electricity and communications recover swiftly.

As per a report prepared by the Institute for Competitiveness, Assam has an adaptive capacity score of 76.6, making it the third most constrained among the states assessed. This reflects structural weaknesses in water, sanitation, surface roads and telecom facilities. The latest floods left nearly 13,000 households without electricity 11 days after the deluge, while sediment continued to obstruct access in some areas after the water had receded.

Keeping its risk landscape in mind, over the years Assam has seen a rise in its disaster finance provision from ₹2,541 crore under the 14th Finance Commission (FC) to ₹4,742 crore under the 15th FC. The 16th FC has recommended an allocation of ₹5,825 crore for 2026-31. Lack of fund provisions does not seem to be the state's problem.

Climate-related finance should be judged by the capacity it has created, not merely by the funds allocated. The relevant test lies in checking whether embankments, roads, shelter, water systems and communications stay functional during a flood. In July 2026, the state government reported that 3,000km of the state's 4,800km embankment network required repair or reconstruction because its flood resistance capacity had declined. Around 1,800km had been strengthened, including 863km over the last five years. But the story doesn't end here. There are also other issues that cause havoc in Upper Assam that need to be highlighted for effective crisis mitigation and prevention.

One pertains to whether formally recognized risk can prompt comprehensive preventive action. Another concerns the challenge of managing a tributary basin with much of its catchment area lying across the state's boundary.

In 2019, concerns about mining, erosion and



REUTERS

possible changes in the Dikhow's course reached the Gauhati high court. The state had then proposed a multidisciplinary study and master plan, and the court called for an enforcement mechanism. While the case tells us nothing about the role of mining in this year's flood, it raises the question of whether a recognized risk was met with proper preventive action in the last six years. An institutional gap is only part of the problem; another is geographical. A 2014 Geographic Information System study on the Dikhow's drainage system of Northeast India estimated that its drainage basin is roughly 3,889-sq-km. Although estimates differ across studies, it is clear that much of the basin lies upstream in Nagaland, with water and sediment flowing into the Assam plains before joining the Brahmaputra.

Nagaland's soil and water conservation department has documented extensive coal mining and marked expansion of rat-hole and open-cast mines in Wokha, Mon, Mokokchung, Longleng and Tuensang. Its 2024-25 administrative report records several ecological damages from acid mine drainage and describes programmes intended to restore mine-spoil areas.

This does not mean that the identified mines fall within the Dikhow catchment or that mining materially worsened this year's floods, but it establishes a need to examine Dikhow as a connected basin. Water, debris and sediment transcend state borders. Yet, mining regulation, forest administration, catchment restoration and disaster expenditure are state functions. So climate risk varies by river basins, but governance and finance are sliced up by administrative boundaries. This is one

mismatch. But there is a bigger one in the design of India's FC architecture.

Although the 16th FC recognizes disaster risk, its weightage remains low. For state disaster response and mitigation fund allocations, the 16th FC gives a 70% weight to adjusted average disaster expenditure between 2011-12 and 2023-24, excluding the two pandemic years, and 30% to a disaster risk index that incorporates hazard exposure and vulnerability. Although the risk component is recognized better than in earlier approaches, the difficulty lies in the relative weights. Historical expenditure is a justified parameter for assessing states'

recurring finance needs, but overall, the devolution formula is slow to take emerging geographies of risk into account; it is designed so that risk is fully recognized only after a record of damage has accumulated.

At this point, India lacks the institutional ability to anticipate vulnerability before disasters strike. While floods wreak havoc in changing patterns, our fiscal and administrative set-up largely remains the same. Waiting for the next cycle to reconsider climate risk within India's principal architecture of fund devolution could mean several more tragedies.

The Union and state budgets must therefore begin applying forward-looking climate risk criteria, while a stronger framework is developed for the next FC.

Climate mitigation must begin before recurring relief becomes a substitute for development. Recovery is not simply a matter of rebuilding what was lost at the same location. Once a settlement, agricultural field, school or village is consumed by a deluge, rebuilding happens elsewhere.

QUICK READ

Climate risk varies by river basins, but governance and finance are sliced up by administrative boundaries. This mismatch is smaller than the one in how funds are devolved to states.

India requires anticipatory funding. Budgets must start using forward-looking climate-risk criteria while a better devolution framework is developed for the next Finance Commission.

dies. The Union and state budgets must therefore begin applying forward-looking climate risk criteria, while a stronger framework is developed for the next FC.

Climate mitigation must begin before recurring relief becomes a substitute for development. Recovery is not simply a matter of rebuilding what was lost at the same location. Once a settlement, agricultural field, school or village is consumed by a deluge, rebuilding happens elsewhere.

MINT CURATOR

Are AI movies all slop? Not if they prove equally enthralling

Filmmaking is an art of storytelling that AI could surely help hone



CATHERINE THORBECKE
is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering Asia tech.



Audiences can spot inauthenticity whether AI is involved or not. ISTOCKPHOTO

I went to an AI film festival in Tokyo last week expecting slop, and left surprised by how much humanity emanated from the screen. My favourite was an 11-minute short film from a child's perspective of spending a magical summer with his grandparents. He records mermaid sightings and fleeting, sun-drenched images of youth. The biggest crowd-pleaser, *The Postman*, imagined a future where a trash-sorting robot longs for the human connection it once found delivering handwritten letters as a postal worker.

These films made me feel something, which itself has become a provocative statement. Even suggesting that an AI-generated movie might be good tends to draw indignation from filmmakers and cinephiles who still see the technology as an insult to creativity (it can be), a mass heist of intellectual property (no doubt) or a looming threat to artists' livelihoods (all true).

The anger is understandable. We have all seen the soulless junk that defines much AI-generated content online. But what happens when that technology lets artists tell stories they could not otherwise afford to?

Human composition has never guaranteed artistry. On a recent flight, I flicked through several Hollywood movies made by armies of people. None seemed to have a soul. It left me wondering what is so sacred about this process that we cannot make room for others to create?

Audiences tend to rail against AI-generated art—at least, when they know it is involved. People often judge AI-generated art more favourably when its origins are concealed, then downgrade the same or similar work after learning it was involved. Rather than proving machines can be artists, this suggests we judge a work partly by how we feel about how it was made. Winning over audiences will require proving that these films involve far more labour than simply prompting a machine.

The filmmakers I met were not reckless AI accelerationists but artists, often the first to acknowledge the technology's limits.

Yang Wang, co-director of *Between Before and After*, a moody breakup story, told me that AI reduced costs and improved efficiency, but had not changed the essence. Filmmakers still have to build relationships between characters and organize shots. Long takes, such as Martin Scorsese's famous nightclub entry in *Goodfellas*, remain nearly impossible to pull off with AI, he lamented.

Sound, colour and digital production all changed filmmaking jobs, he added. Some repetitive work might disappear due to AI.

But he believes the technology will also create new roles and empower more people to make movies.

Yuuki, the artist behind *The Postman*, came from anime, where work can be extraordinarily painstaking. He saw AI as a practical way to manage the workload and finish projects. Human creativity stems from accumulated experiences, something a machine can't replace, he noted. Japan's storied animation industry has long faced criticism over poor pay and working conditions. Used well, these tools could help preserve rather than replace the craft.

The event was hosted by US-based Runway, the \$5 billion startup that makes video and world models. CEO Cris Valenzuela told me that even in the face of loud critics, "Every Hollywood studio is using AI, every one of them." It's true that while executives still publicly emphasize their commitment to human creativity, they have also been investing in AI talent and tools.

That shift has created a sense of fatalism. Artists must embrace AI or be left behind. I have long resisted this rhetoric, especially in art. A technology's existence does not excuse how it was built—by sweeping up vast troves of creative work, often without permission or remuneration. The industry should find ways to compensate those creators. Without their labour, Generative AI as we know it would be useless.

It can undoubtedly help with tedious parts of production, and many creatives will adopt tools that let them work faster or stretch their budgets. But most workers want a greater say in this transition. That is why creative industry unions will be essential in determining how they are used.

The debate is often framed as a battle between artists and Silicon Valley boffins. Ultimately, audiences will decide which stories deserve their time and money, whatever tools made them. Consumers are adept at sniffing out inauthenticity, whether AI was involved or not.

The films I saw were all short, more a glimpse of potential than an immediate threat to the box office. They felt human because a person decided what mattered enough to share. Machines cannot experience the ache of missing a grandparent, for instance. AI can change how stories are made, but not what motivates us to tell the ones we do.

©BLOOMBERG

GUEST VIEW

India ought to resolve this asymmetry in its GST regime

MANJUNATH A.N. &
ARJUN RAGHAVENDRA M.



are former officers, Indian Revenue Service.

Nine years after India rolled out its Goods and Services Tax (GST), one philosophy has proven more durable than anything in the architecture of the law: when a taxpayer misses a deadline, it is enforced to the day; when the state misses one, it is extended by notification.

GST has been Independent India's largest fiscal experiment: one tax across all states, touching every citizen in a way that even the 1991 reforms did not. In the early years, extensions owing to "teething problems" were a necessity, not an indulgence. That is precisely why their persistence into the later years raises this question: is it a confession of structural unreadiness or an act of self-exemption by the state?

As a tax-return form, GSTR-3B was a stop-gap while the invoice-matching architecture of GSTR-1/2/3 stabilized. GSTR-2 was suspended within months and GSTR-3 forms were not filed. The provisions for matching were deleted in 2022 and the rules amended retrospectively to institutionalize 3B, which

is now GST's foundational fiscal record.

Section 168A of the Central GST Act institutionalized the state's leeway on a time limit for dispute cases. Three notifications in 2022-23 extended the time span to pass adjudication orders for 2017-20, invoking covid as 'force majeure' long after those relaxations ended. One of them lacked even the GST Council's prior recommendation, though the council ratified it later; high courts are now split on its validity and the Supreme Court is yet to settle the matter.

The GST compensation cess, originally meant to run from July 2017 to June 2022, was extended to March 2026—not to compensate states but repay the roughly ₹2.7 trillion borrowed by the Centre during the pandemic. This 'transitional' levy that outlived its purpose by four years and became a debt-servicing instrument has finally ended.

Reverse charges on purchases from unregistered persons were suspended within months and eventually redrafted in 2018 to apply only to notified classes, thus diluting what Parliament had enacted in July 2017. Provisions for tax deducted and collected at source (TDS and TCS), also enacted nine years ago, went live only in October 2018.

The GST Tribunal took eight years to constitute. The case limitation clock was held in

suspension to cover the gap. Even this fix is an extension; with the Tribunal operational only from September 2025, a notification that month gave taxpayers until 30 June 2026 to file their entire backlog of appeals since 2017 (some 480,000 of them), a deadline that was then pushed to 31 July when its own internet portal buckled.

GSTR-9/9C, the annual return, was not ready to be filed annually: the first, for 2017-18, arrived in staggered batches in 2020, and 9C's audit certification gave way to self-certification in 2021. A New Return System (RET-1, Sahaj, Sugam) was announced, piloted and abandoned. E-invoicing was deferred, then lowered through six turnover tranches from ₹500 crore (in 2020) to ₹5 crore (in 2023). Even the e-way bill's "ship-to" field was pushed again to August 2026.

Yet the state's rigidity where an extension would favour taxpayers is stark. Some extensions did spare taxpayers the price of a system that

could not take their returns, but that only concedes it was not ready. The input tax credit deadline was enforced to the day, generating demands running into tens of thousands of crores, until the law was amended retrospectively to extend it to 30 November 2021 for 2017-18 through 2020-21: an admission that the deadline was unrealistic. The transitional credit window (Tran-1/Tran-2), litigated across high courts, needed a 2022 Supreme Court order to re-open the portal for two months—five years after the 'transition.'

The taxpayer's side lacks basic discretionary elasticity. The appellate authority can condone a delay of one month; and the Tribunal, three months. Beyond that limit, no authority in the GST hierarchy can hear an appeal a single day late, whatever the cause.

We don't need novelty to address that asymmetry. The state already trusts its own officers with discretion on direct taxes. Under the income-

QUICK READ

It is odd that the Indian state has granted itself wide leeway on GST implementation timelines but offers taxpayers no respite, unlike the country's much older system of direct taxation.

Income-tax officials have the discretion to pardon delays by taxpayers who cite good reasons. The GST regime ought to adopt this. Countless small businesses would be relieved.

tax law, the appellate authority and Tribunal may condone a delay of any length for "sufficient cause," and a tax commissioner may waive a penalty for genuine hardship. That discretion is bounded; negligence is still refused relief, but genuine cases get a fair hearing. Six decades of this have not brought tax administration to its knees. It is GST that treats its adjudicators as unfit to weigh a taxpayer's cause—its tribunal is stricter than the excise and customs tribunal, which too could forgive a delay of any length for good reason.

Today's question, then—for Parliament, the government and writ courts—is whether a law that has survived on the power of deadline extension can deny every discretionary extension to those it governs. A statute that lived by extension should not preach a hard limit. The durable answer lies in the law: give GST's appellate forums the same latitude that direct taxation allows.

India's GST regime must show restraint. Or we risk small businesses getting engulfed, even failing. A shop-owner who recovers from a bereavement or hospitalization must not get trapped by an order six months old; income-tax law would give the same taxpayer a hearing but GST will not. Grace is not a concession, but an act of proportionate maturity—and it's not a novelty either.



Trying out an alternative reality

For city dwellers, a second home is a space to cultivate another lifestyle and interests, far from their 'regular' lives

Anjali Kochhar
feedback@livemint.com

On most Friday evenings, Senthil Kumar Hariram, 40, adopts a version of the life that he has consciously built as a response to the one he was living. "I live and work in Bengaluru. The pace is constant, the noise never switches off, and over time, you start functioning more on momentum than intention," says the founder of FTA Global, a search engineering company.

He realised he needed a space to recalibrate, not necessarily escape. "I didn't want a vacation spot. I wanted a different way of living for a few days every week, something that changes how I exist," he says, explaining why he invested in a second home in Vellore, Tamil Nadu, where he spends weekends farming.

Second homes are increasingly being used to reconstruct ways of living that feel lost in urban life. "I try to spend almost every weekend there unless work commitments require me to stay back. It has become a regular part of my routine rather than an occasional getaway. The consistency is what makes the experience meaningful because it gives me dedicated time to disconnect from the pace of city life and reconnect with nature."

The time there, however, hasn't made him want to shift fully to that way of life. "I enjoy the balance that both worlds offer. Bengaluru is where I build the business, work with my team, and pursue my professional ambitions, while Vellore gives me the space to slow down and recharge. I don't see them as competing lifestyles

but as complementary ones. Spending time at my second home has certainly made me value a simpler way of living, but it hasn't made me want to leave entrepreneurship behind. Instead, it has helped me become more intentional about how I approach work and life," he says.

"We're seeing second homes bought less like a portfolio line-item and more like a 'different pace of life' kept on standby," says Chandresh Vithalani, director of Mumbai-based Palladian Partners Advisory. "It's where people try out quieter routines, hybrid work, weekend farming, or a more intentional way of raising children, because the city does not allow for those experiments," he says, pointing out that these homes function as testing grounds for alternate lifestyles rather than passive investments.

"Buyers are increasingly considering how a home fits into their lives, not just their portfolios," agrees Rishi Raj, in his 50s, CEO of Conscient Infrastructure, a real estate company with operations in Delhi and Goa. He sees it most clearly in North Goa pockets like Assagao and Siolim where time in a second home becomes "a way to test new ways of living—blending work, family, wellness, and community—while remaining connected to urban life."

This shift is reflected in Knight Frank's *The Wealth Report 2025*, which notes that 32% of India's ultra-high-net-worth individuals

are either planning to acquire or already own second homes. The demand for second homes is disproportionately high in hills and coastal regions, suggesting that environmental and experiential factors are central to decision-making.

Geographically, the market skews west: Alibaug, Lonavla, Karjat and Goa account for nearly half of India's second-home demand, followed by northern hill destinations like Kasauli, Shimla and Rishikesh, and southern retreats such as Kodagu (Coorg) and Nandi Hills—all united by accessibility from Mumbai, Delhi and Bengaluru. New infrastructure, from the Atal Setu bridge to the Navi Mumbai airport and regional expressways, is compressing travel time.



Distance from the primary residence remains the first filter—the India Sotheby's 2025 *Luxury Residential Sentiment Survey* found 55% of HNIs (high net-worth individuals) prefer second homes within four hours of their main residence. Beyond drive time, buyers weigh healthcare access, road quality and water availability. The wish list has moved beyond a pool and a view: weekend farming, wellness routines, nature trails and hospitality tie-ups to earn rental income when owners are away.

"The idea is to create second homes not as dormant assets but as spaces for alternate living," says Jimmy Mistry, 55, chairman and managing director of the Mumbai-based real estate business Della Group. Developers are integrating hospitality, wellness and community into such projects so that "owners could live in their second homes as first homes, rather than visit them occasionally."

For Apeksha Niranjani, 42, Bharatnatyam artist and choreographer, the second home is not a lifestyle upgrade but a cultural and emotional return. "A second home is our dream home that we do not think of only buying and selling," she says, deliberately rejecting the language of investment that typically surrounds such decisions. "In our childhood, we used to



(From top) A house by Terra Grande in Kasauli, Himachal Pradesh; and a residential property by Conscient Infrastructure in Candolim, Goa.

play without shoes. We would take hints from nature to understand seasons and rhythms. Today, that tactile connection to soil and environment is very rare," she reflects, identifying a gap that her second home attempts to fill.

Niranjani lives in Navi Mumbai, and her second home is in Jambhulpada in Raigad district. "I love spending time in nature there—planting trees, taking care of the garden and breathing the pollution-free air. Although some final work is still in

progress, I have made a beautiful dance studio where I can practice and create dance. This is more than a second home for me. It gives me mental peace and relaxation, allowing me to take a break from the day-to-day routine and reconnect with nature and myself," she adds.

Once the house is complete, she plans to take her students there. "I want them to experience a gurukul-like environment where learning is immersive, unstructured, and rooted in presence."

For Narinder Paul Kathuria, in his 60s, director at Flash Electronics, a Delhi-headquartered auto components manufacturer, his second home serves a specific need. "Living in Delhi, where pollution is a major issue for most of the year, I was looking for a place where I could step away from that environment," he says, framing his decision through the lens of necessity rather than luxury.

His second home is in Kasauli in Himachal Pradesh, a five-to-six-hour drive from Delhi. "It had to be something that I could access without over-planning," he explains. "When everyday living itself becomes difficult, you start looking at things differently—clean air and open space stop being luxuries and start becoming necessities."

This is echoed by Suresh Sharma, managing director of Noida-based Advant IT Parks, whose second home is also in Himachal Pradesh. "You don't want something that feels far removed from your life; you want a place you can go to whenever you need to reset, without turning it into a logistical exercise."

"There is a clear shift in mindset," says Amar Kapoor, CEO, Terra Grande, the luxury second-home vertical of Delhi-NCR developer Eldec Group with villa projects in the Kasauli hills, contextualising these individual decisions within a broader behavioural transformation. "Earlier, people associated breaks with international travel, planning months in advance, dealing with visas, uncertainty. Now that mindset has changed significantly. People want ease. They want to be able to just pack their bags and go to a place that is theirs, without having to go through multiple processes every time."

Most of his buyers are in the 45-55 age group. "At that stage, they are not trying to escape, but reshape their lives in a way that feels more balanced and controlled," he says, highlighting how financial stability often leads to lifestyle experimentation. Most buyers ask detailed questions about water availability and infrastructure, which shows that their priorities are grounded in everyday realities.

Second homes are becoming spaces of experimentation for individuals who want to experience alternate rhythms without completely stepping away from their primary lives; spaces where work coexists with stillness, and where time is not always measured in output.

MG SELECT

EVERY GREAT JOURNEY
BEGINS WITH ONE DECISION.
ONE THAT DEFINES EVERY MILE TO COME.



M9

THE PRESIDENTIAL
LIMOUSINE

SECURE AN ASSURED **60% BUYBACK** AT THE END OF **3 YEARS.***
ENJOY **DEPRECIATION BENEFITS OF UP TO 40%.***

EMI starting at **₹88,888[#]**

www.mgselect.co.in

BENGALURU ELECTRONIC CITY: 9240940499
6/1, NH 44, Lavakusha Nagar, Electronic City - 560100

BENGALURU CENTRAL: 9240940490
04, Skav 909, No. 9/1, Ashok Nagar, Lavelle Road - 560001

*Buyback value is insured by Zuno General Insurance. Lockton India is the Insurance Broker. T&C apply

*Disclaimer: All prices are ex-showroom India. Actual performance figures may differ in conditions other than test conditions. Vehicle body colour may differ due to printing process. Images used in this ad are for representation purposes only. In view of our policy of continuously improving our products, we reserve the right to alter specifications, features, and designs without prior notice and without liability. All models are subject to availability. Please check details with your nearest MG Select Dealer Partner for latest information. Accessories and features shown in the pictures may not be a part of standard equipment and will differ according to the variant. Available pan-India. *T&C Apply. #EMI is indicative and subject to financier's sole discretion. Terms and conditions apply.